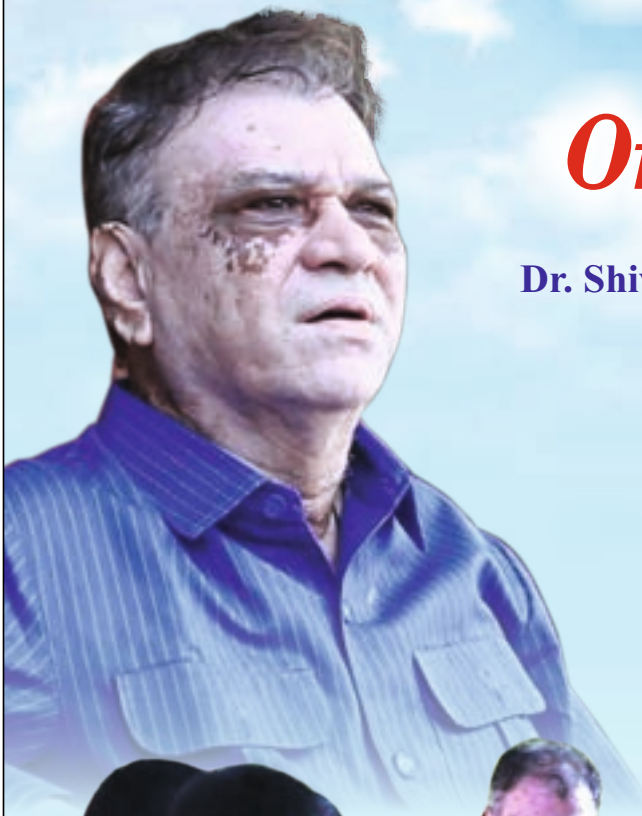


Father of Orphans

Dr. Shivlal Ambaji Jadhav



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Maitri Publication
Father of Orphan | Shivalal Jadhav



Publisher
Mohini Karande
Maitri Publication, 267/3, Anandnagar,
Malwadi Road, Hadapsar, Pune - 411 028.
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Cover Design
Shinde Infotec (Pvt.) Ltd., Pune



Printer
Shivani Printers, Pune



ISBN : 978-81-938102-8-6



First Edition
2019



Price
Rs. 250/- only



Humbly Dedicated

*To my dear mother Laxmibai,
who led me on to this path of
serving the orphan children,*

*To the innumerable hands -
known and unknown,
who assisted me on this path,*

and

*To my countless sons and daughters
who otherwise,
would have been doomed
to be orphans.*

Monologue / My Monologue

'Become 'big' in your life' - were the five significant words expressed by my dear mother as she conferred her blessings on me at every successful stage of my life! These uplifting words and her unwavering blessings helped me to mould my life. I really don't think I am that 'big' - that noteworthy or significant, but my mother always thought so. She always had an unflinching admiration towards each achievement of mine. In her eyes, I was really very significant and she continued to spur me to achieve loftier heights. Though she is no more on this earth, yet in a very true sense she has been, she is and she will always be the guiding beacon in my life, my strength, my inspiration and also my role model.

My mother, Lakshmibai, worked as a Caretaker in a Remand home, but, she never looked upon it as a mere 'job'. Being a caretaker was inherent to her and all through her life at the Remand home, she showered all the inmates with her unconditional love and warmth. While I experienced the same, I was also very familiar with her other virtues of being a strict disciplinarian, punctual and honest. These same virtues were

inculcated in me right through my early childhood. My teachers, Mrs. Paranjpe and Mrs. Bansode indoctrinated the virtues of education and discipline. They ingrained interest, liking and penchant for study in me. They looked upon me as their very own offspring. I still remember the unstinting efforts taken by my teacher Mr Wadekar so that I could win a Scholarship. In this journey of life, I came across many teachers. Some came in the guise of a friend while some as colleagues or associates and some as valuable guides and mentors. During my college days I came across excellent friends like Arun Datar, Vinay Mundale, Arvind Dharwadkar, Vikram Gokhale, Balu Gawali and Samarnath Dube. The days spent in their company proved to be the golden era of my youth. Later on in life, during the period of political agitations and activities, my associates, Laxman Mane, Balkrishna Renake, Moolchand Bhat, Anil Awachat, Arun Khore, Neelam Gorhe, Vilas Wadekar and many others as also the most valuable and influential guidance accorded by distinguished leaders like Baba Adhav, Bhai Vaidya, S. M. Joshi, Sharad Pawar considerably helped me shape my life. Their companionship, their beneficial guidance, collaboration imparted the essential values of life as also the effective skills of standing up for injustice. I worked up a storm on the issue of the nomads. A nomad community in Mundhwa was granted some land. As Pune Municipal Corporation tried to get the possession of that land, we launched a huge agitation so that the land could be retained by the nomads. In the process, we suffered a lot of hardships, harassments and humiliations. We had to plead, even implore at many levels but in the end, we were successful in retrieving the land in the name of the nomads. The entire outcome was successful, hence gratifying.

I was able to solve the problems of the poor, needy and down trodden with the valuable help of my colleagues, co-activists and guides. This process facilitated tremendously towards my self-

development. I drew my strength from it and this imparted a new meaning to my life. Due to them, today I am on the pinnacle of success. On the way up, I was subjected to a hoard of humiliation and rejections. At times, I even starved. Yet, I cheerfully faced all the hurdles in my path with grace. The attitude of 'meeting any challenge in life headlong, with courage and with smile' was the valuable lesson imparted by my dear mother.

After completing my college education, I did a brief stint as a Professor but I really did not enjoy teaching. I was offered a Government job too, but I declined. My mother always wished me to do something for the society. She would persistently question me 'Your job will improve the financial status of our house, but what about the society?' And she would question me purposefully. During her span as a caretaker at the Remand home, she had personally seen the ordeal and the torment of the girls over there. She had also shared the anguish in the life of the orphans there. With this as the guiding force, she decided to spend her retired life in the service of the orphans. Spurred on by the impetus from my mother, in the year 1985, I offered shelter to orphans, physically challenged and destitute children in our house. We were not very well to do and had to starve at times, yet, we had shouldered this responsibility. We were aware that our path was not smooth but was rough with many ups and downs and strewn with thorns along the way, yet we decided to embark on it. This journey of offering a shelter to about 10-12 children continued and as of today, we have around 700 children. We continued treading this jagged path and gradually, found our way. We always nurtured the guiding principle that 'education not only enriches an individual but the entire society too' and accordingly, we stayed focussed on this goal. The Educational Institute which we founded thrived and vastly expanded. A small fledgling blossomed into an enormous tree. The mission that I began is an unending one and so I cannot stop, I cannot even take a halt, I

must continue my journey - day and night, years after years. Work is being done, no tiredness, no weariness. In between failures came, I faced setbacks, but they did not undermine me, did not discourage me. Work is being carried out in an indefatigable manner. All my co-workers and my colleagues graduated to become my family – rather a loving family. Over a long period, I received remarkable help and cooperation from Revered Shivajirao Ghule, the owner of Yashwant Sakhar Karkhana (Yashwant Sugar Mills) for the children in my institute for providing the best education, wholesome food and all the necessary amenities and facilities. Subsequently, his grandson Naval Ghule too, spontaneously lent a hand by building an office for the institute, in memory of his grandfather. It is impossible for me to forget the valuable help and co-operation accorded to me in the hour of need. With a profound sense of gratitude, I wish to place on record the personal assistance and social patronage conferred by the prominent personalities of the Jain community like, Jayabala Shah, Babulal Lodha, Suneeta Madane, Virupaksh Javalakar, Ravi and Mrs. Rekha Deshmukh, Kashmira, Pushpa Lunkad, Sunil Kothari and also the members of the Rishabh Jain Group, Amrutbhai Chhajed, Manoj Rathod, Ramesh Rathod, Mahendra Jain and many other innumerable individuals.

During this journey, till date, my dear wife Sangeeta has been a virtual pillar of strength. Right through the lean days when I was heavily riddled with debt, her unwavering support as well as that of my children was the true secret of my success. My entire family stood by me. Recently I lost my son Pintoo (Motilal Shivalal Jadhav), my daughter-in-law and my grandchildren. This crushing grief and sorrow are going to be with me for the rest of my life. But then as I reflected, it occurred to me that when I am on a mission to alleviate the sorrow of the downtrodden ones in life, how long can I indulge in mine? Gradually, I tried to overcome my grief by getting more involved in new activities and projects

and thus, I have succeeded. At present a programme is being conducted at Pabal for the rehabilitation of the physically challenged, deaf and mute, autistic and nomad children. Besides, with the help of Dr. Bharde (Deputy Commissioner, Animal Husbandry, Maharashtra State) and Mr. Dnyaneshwar Dhoble (C.A.), a project for the Geer cows is being conducted for about four to five hundred farmers in which I am taking a keen interest. Now, I am seventy one years old. Though my body has slowed down but my mind is still very vigilant and active. Many of my colleagues have retired but my work has no retirement - till my last breath.

Throughout my life, I bonded rather well with people along the way. I made it a point to only harvest the intrinsic worth from them. I walked the unrelenting, gruelling path as countless helping hands lent their support to me. These helping hands bestowed me with the necessary strength to forge ahead on my path. I sincerely place my gratitude towards such known and also to the unknown hands. I also thank those who criticised me with disparaging remarks because that proffered an opportunity to rectify my short comings.

Many of my associates and colleagues persuaded me to pen my journey in words, in the form of a book. I have honoured their wish. In the course of penning the chronicle of my journey, innumerable people - from my institute, outsiders, my well-wishers - accorded help. Without them this compilation would not have materialized. I place my humble gratitude towards them. I am grateful to my guides, associates and all my family members who have written good words about me as a part of this book. May your abiding love and support be ever with me since I will draw my strength from that for my forthcoming work.

- Dr. Shivrul Ambaji Jadhav

Foreword....

I am most delighted to write a foreword to the autobiographical book 'Father of the Orphans' penned by Dr. Shivalal Ambaji Jadhav, the industrious activist working for the welfare of the nomads. For many, the lives of the nomads are the fragmented vestiges of tangible memories consisting of a string of bitter experiences, abhorrence and indignation towards the social system which compels these nomads to lead their lives like stray cats and dogs. While taking a stock of these memories, a two pronged grief is inflicted. One, it leads to tremendous tension of reviving of unwanted memories in the fabric of a life well lived and two, bitter memories inflict tremendous pain. The author of this autobiography had to endure such labour pangs akin to the pains of childbirth. Dr. Shivalal Jadhav was born in a family belonging to a nomadic tribe called 'Takari' which was declared as a criminal tribe by the then British Government which ruled India. He lost his father prior to his birth and hence his widowed mother had to bring him up all alone. It was a very challenging environment to rear a child in face of no support from the society at large and at the same time, provide an apt impetus for the son to stand and wage a battle against inequality. For an activist to be

born in a tribe that was labelled as a 'criminal', is a very unique experience. At the outset, it is imperative for the readers to comprehend and grasp the unique struggle of the author through his own, original words. It is amply evident that the battle waged by Dr. Shivalal is a common fate of all those born in similar nomadic tribes, especially in 'so called' independent India. Many families and classes of that category of society still wander and their number keeps on growing for want of appropriate social awakening. In this autobiography, along with the details of the writer's own work and experiences, there is lot of information which bears a historical value about the people, their living habits, professions, culture and religious beliefs and worship.

That history of such persons or their communities is as ragged as they are. Such fragmented pieces when sewn together form a quilt. Dr. Shivalal Jadhav's autobiography is akin to this quilt. It narrates his life story - his father's demise prior to his birth, mother's second marriage to a man from the Maratha community, the ensuing trials and tribulations the new couple had to face from Jadhav's Takari community as also from the village council, the remarkable compassionate attitude displayed by Janardan Kadam, his stepfather during such a challenging period, the stand taken by Mr. Kadam's family and the life saga of his mother and stepfather. The book also narrates about his schooldays, his love for studies, his loving teachers, his friends - some who discriminated him on the basis of caste while some who did not believe in it, the number of compromises he had to face to continue his studies, his ability in surmounting innumerable pecuniary and other difficulties and ultimately, his successful graduation in Economics as also post graduation in Economics and Politics, how he excelled in all the cultural activities in school and in college too, his vision of becoming a District Collector, his timely action to take a stand against injustice and to confront the administration. Being curious and fastidious, he was attracted towards socialist movement led by leaders such as Baba Adhav

and Bhai Vaidya. He attended the Rashtriya Sevalal's camps. Just like the other contemporaries who grow more vigilant about social issues, he too, became more aware about the social issues and was drawn towards the movement of the nomads. In this book he has written about various thinkers, philosophers, activists and workers he met during those movements.

This autobiography will be useful in understanding how the social outlook of this activist participating in the revolutionary movement got broadened, how he got entrusted with various responsibilities, his demeanour towards the bouquets and brickbats in his path, his management of his pecuniary segment, surmounting the inconveniences faced by his family, his effective management of productive and categorical work, the attempts carried out on him to defame and disgrace him. It will also be useful in knowing how an orphan boy fights his way to become a professor, how he lays the foundation of nine different institutions and attains the position and title of 'Father of the Orphans', how he becomes the 'apple of the eye' of those who have attained the peak positions in social movements. It also narrates on how he got selected as a member of many different Government committees and panels and his experiences in those positions.

Lives of the activists who constantly strive for the rehabilitation of the orphans and nomads are filled with ups and downs and bitter-sweet experiences and memories. The author of such an autobiography has to implement a very effective tool to present it in a precise manner because it becomes a document of history of social development. His achievements or failures are a reflection of the movements that he stands for. During his formative years such movements or agitations form his constitution and shape his social awareness. Such stirring movements educate the activists that the good or bad environment that befalls their lot is not their making but is a part of the social development. Such movements

also motivate to change the social structure that is based on inequality. The memories are innumerable and mainly based on the oral accounts, patriarchal families and communities, their cooperation or non-cooperation, negative experiences during educational years, friends and their support, influence of books, diversified reading, cooperation or non-cooperation of castes and communities, productive work done during agitations, their urgency, agitations, methods of execution, meetings and rallies, marches, demands, statements, their drafts, the practice of writing drafts, their language and comprehensiveness, focus of the agitations, follow-up of the demands, raising funds for the movements, their economics, cultural fights, activists and authors developed during those fights, reactions from the government, punitive actions against the agitators, members of the agitations and rallies, the basic philosophy of the movement, the strength and weakness, friends and enemies, supporting and opposing organizations, parties, unions, their obstacles and hurdles, the strain and stress, accusations, allegations, charges and counter-charges, winning the agitation and many more. That oral account and the collection of memories must be rearranged and methodically documented in an autobiography.

The integrity of the author basically lies on how well he portrays the authenticity and the awareness of the events around him. The autobiographies written post an active life are more matured and enriching. It is very vital that every activist must maintain a daily record of the events, so that the history of the background can be documented properly. In the autobiography titled 'Father of the Orphans', written by the seventy two year old Dr. Shivalal Ambaji Jadhav, all the above facts have been precisely documented.

For anybody, 'To be or not to be' depends on the social structure. It is factually proved that human beings and their groups have progressed, they are elevated. On the other hand, it is also observed that their hard work is pilfered and used for selfish

purposes by some. The Asian countries and its' citizens have progressed through long drawn struggles with major compromises on the vicious systems such as slavery, bonded labour, sanctions, caste discrimination, capitalism and effrontery of the Brahmin religion. There is a possibility that such long and strenuous struggle gets an all-encompassing exposure in the autobiographies of such activists.

Dr. Jadhav has written about the necessity of this book in his own note. He has written about the history of the nomads. He has inserted coloured photographs about his work and accomplishments. Prominent personalities like Baba Adhav, Bhai Vaidya, Balkrishna Renke, Neelamtai Gore, Laxman Mane, Ramnath Chavan, Jaybala Pankaj Shah, Bharat Jadhav, Crystal, Sangeeta Shivalal Jadhav, Ratnamala Shivalal Jadhav, Milind Shivalal Jadhav, Ratanlal Shivalal Jadhav, Nikheel Bhausahab Barve, Sheetal Parshunath Thakare, Geetanjali Parshunath Thakare, Gokul Pandurang Shirore, Vikram Gokhale, who have witnessed Dr. Jadhav's remarkable work have duly recorded their views. For a researcher and an activist like me, such a type of book is very valuable. With a book like this, it facilitates one to get acquainted with the backdrop which is very vital in moulding the character of a person. Readers will definitely welcome this autobiographical book of an activist who has dedicated his whole life for well-being of orphans and nomads.

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My family hails from a small town called Konhali of Akkalkot Taluka in the district of Sholapur. Prior to my birth, my parents resided in a colony known as the 'settlement' which was created by the British Government for the nomadic tribes. That area was recognised as 'Limayewadi' which is also my birth-place. The Britishers had declared certain nomadic tribes as 'criminal' tribes. I was born in one such 'Takari' tribe, hence I was inevitably a 'criminal by birth'! Under normal circumstances, like all other children in our country, children from such tribes are also named during their 'name keeping ceremony', generally celebrated on the twelfth day of their birth, but here they were anointed as 'criminal' from the time they were born. As a matter of fact, my parents never ever committed any crime throughout their life, but since the tribe they belonged to was declared as 'criminal tribe' there was no way to get exonerated from that name. My father worked in a cotton mill. However, the claustrophobic atmosphere of the 'settlement' and stressful conditions at the mill took a toll on his health and he succumbed to it while I was still in my mother's womb. The sheer

cautioned my mother against carrying such heavy boulders at such a delicate, recuperative stage of motherhood, warned about the ill effects on her body and advised her to discontinue the work. She then, promptly employed my mother to work at her home. My mother was literate. She had studied up to seventh standard. She was well versed in sewing and embroidery. She could stitch curtains, draw designs on handkerchiefs or cloth and embroider the same. But under the present circumstances, it was of little or no use. Hence, she had to toil and carry the heavy boulders. The kind British lady relieved her of the physical labour and employed her at her home. My mother worked at her home for some time on a salary of Rupees Eleven per month. That lady was suitably impressed by my mother's diligence, honesty and hard work. She turned more compassionate towards my mother. On her recommendation, my mother was appointed in the Certified School, a Remand Home - in our settlement as caretaker and cook. Besides, looking after the girls from the settlement, she even taught them the art of cooking, sewing and embroidery.

My mother's revolutionary decision :

Post my father's demise, my mother, singlehandedly, had to shoulder the entire responsibility of our family. Her job at the Remand Home had improved our lot to a certain extent. At least, she was no longer required to hunt for some work or engage in strenuous physical labour. She carried out her assignment very diligently. Her work place, i.e. the Remand Home, was about two kilometres away from where we resided in the settlement. She used to reach home pretty late at night. The road which she had to take daily, was not a normal road but just a rough, lonely winding path. Many residents of the settlement, at that time of the evening, used to wander around in an inebriated state. She always used to walk home alone late in the night. One day in the year of 1948, on

bliss of a delightful childhood spent in warm, loving cocoon of parents is absolutely unparalleled in this world. But I was not destined to experience this bliss since the paternal canopy of my world collapsed before I arrived in this world. The entire responsibility of managing the house had to be borne solely by my mother. She was faced with a very paradoxical, unique situation, on one side was the untold grief of losing a life partner in the prime of life and on the other side was the joy of being a mother for the first time and to crown it all was the imminent need to work for the sustenance of the self and the tiny life that was a now a part of her. It was unthinkable and impossible for her to avail of postnatal recuperation because she could not afford to do so. She went to work just a few days after my birth. The Britishers had provided work for the residents of the settlement. Work was very laborious and there was no discrimination in the nature or quantum of work, be it a man or a woman. When I was very tiny i.e. only eleven days old, my mother was engaged in picking heavy boulders from the pit of a deep well and carrying them all the way up. While she was toiling, my grandfather looked after me. There was a lemon tree near the well where my mother was working. My grandfather used to sit beneath the shade of that tree with me in his lap. He used to keep near him a bowl of water with sugar added to it. Whenever I would cry, he would slowly let me sip that sweet water. If I would cry incessantly, then my mother would come, breastfeed me and go back to work. She was torn between motherhood and work. Though she would physically work yet her maternal being hovered around me to envelope me in her tender loving care. A British woman silently observed her trauma for a couple of days. She was deeply moved by my mother's pathetic condition. There is always a one in a hundred who understands the pathos of a distressed soul. She seemed to be that one. She called my mother aside and inquired about her. When she learnt about her heart-rending conditions, she

her return from work a drunkard accosted her and attempted to molest her. She vehemently fought back but also gave him a sound lesson. The following day, it became a hot topic of discussion in the entire settlement and also at the Remand Home. At that time one Mrs. Yedgunje was the Chief of the Remand Home. She was deeply shocked by that incident and was worried about the possibility of its recurrence. So as a matter of abundant caution, she decided to send a chaperone for my mother on the way her home. Accordingly, she selected a guard, Janardan Dnyanba Kadam and instructed him, 'You take the same route to go home on your cycle. So, from today, you will accompany her and walk with her till she reaches home safely and then proceed to cycle up to your house.' Accordingly, Mr. Kadam began accompanying my mother every night. There was a very famous and renowned wrestling school [Taleem] - a place where men used to wrestle. It's name was 'Patra Taleem'. Mr.Kadam used to stay in that Patra Taleem and was a well-known wrestler. Ever since, he began escorting my mother, no one dared to misbehave or even ogle at her. My mother too, felt secure in his company. Slowly they began conversing with each other. Gradually the conversations assumed a personal hue as they became acquainted about each other's likes and dislikes. As the companionship blossomed to a more comfortable level, they realized that they liked and cared for each other. Eventually, they discussed marriage and decided to take a plunge.

When Mr. Kadam broached the topic with his family, there was a stiff opposition. He hailed from the prestigious Maratha community whereas my mother was from a nomadic tribe and a widow with children. In spite of this, Mr. Kadam was firm on his decision. Being the only offspring of his parents, his firm decision did not leave them with much choice. Finally, they relented and gave their conditional consent. The first condition was that my

mother should give up her job since they were quite well to do and hence, it was not necessary. The second condition was that the marriage must be legally valid.

The marriage of my mother with Janardan Kadam soon became the hot topic of discussion in our society. My mother firmly declared about her decision to our relatives and that left them with little or no choice. It was a very radical decision on her part, to opt for an inter caste marriage and that too, a second marriage. Under such circumstances, in our society, it was extremely unthinkable and the customary reaction would be to issue death threats. My mother too, faced such threats but she and Janardan Kadam, both were absolutely firm about their decision. They were oblivious to others opinions and views. My mother sought appropriate advice about the procedures necessary for the remarriage and also for inter-caste marriage to become legally valid. As per advice of the teachers at the Remand Home, the couple completed all those procedures, published a legal gazette and finally got married.

As a result of her unconventional marriage, the ladies and the elderly persons from the community behaved in a very curt manner with my mother. Our tribe was very traditional and was bound by the dominant council of our tribe. But my mother was neither worried about the outcome nor did she falter or get frightened. That was not akin to her nature at all. According to me, her decision was revolutionary. Besides, it was not only her but Janardan Kadam too, who deserved appreciation. Being the only offspring of his parents and born into a highly affluent and cultured Maratha family, he took a bold decision to marry a poor widow from a nomadic tribe along with her three children! He actually deserved profound appreciation and also respect.

Thus, after marriage Janardan Kadam became my father. We used to call him Tatya. My mother got a transfer. So, we three siblings

and my parents came to Pune at a place called Mundhwa. Tatya got a job at the Camp branch of Punjab National Bank. During those days he used to travel on a bicycle. Tatya and my mother did not have any children of their own, but Tatya loved and nurtured the three of us just like his own children. He was very loving and good-natured and we never missed our own father. In reality, he suffered a lot of agony and misery. He hailed from a very affluent family and was a very dear child of his parents but he was alienated from them for marrying against wishes of his loving parents. No one from his family ever visited us for nearly ten to fifteen years. Thereafter, a few stray visits began but he had to keep away from his family for a very long time. Tatya passed away in Pune. My mother passed away ten years after his demise. At every step, I realized how determinedly my mother led her life!



Nomads' *Independence Day*

15th August, 1947 - The independence day, day of paramount importance, extremely memorable day for every Indian, day of liberation from the oppressive British Rule, day of freedom from the servitude. Indian citizens were liberated on that day but the nomadic community that predominantly contributed to the freedom struggle of the nation was deprived of this freedom. Even post-independence, they continued to be bound by the shackles of the wretched rules imposed on them by the Britishers and were also deprived of the basic rights. Hence, we, the members of the Nomadic community, in spite of being the citizens of independent India, had to bide time till 31st August 1952 to be truly liberated. To us, that day is as significant as the Indian Independence Day.

Criminal Tribes Act of 1871

The uprising of 1857 struck the Achilles tendon of the British Empire. The nomads and the Adivasis belonging to the scheduled tribes had significantly contributed to this historic struggle. In order to gain independence from the wealthy and mighty British

government, the prerequisite factor of this struggle was to harness a substantial amount of funds. These funds were amassed by plundering the wealthy Indians and also by raiding the vaults of the British Government. This 'plundering' was skilfully carried out by the nomads, especially by the *Takari* community. The British Government was hounded by the Adivasis, nomads and many other independent tribes. These groups were the descendants of various families who worked as 'secret agents' of the Great Chatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. The members of these families, like Umaji Naik, used to carry out guerrilla attacks on the British, pillage them, relay their confidential information to Shivaji Maharaj. The Britishers were considerably distressed by such activities of nomads. Hence, they legislated an act under the law of Bombay Presidency, on 12th October 1871, known as the 'Criminal Tribes Act'. This Act was the outcome of the triple factors like the Adivasis' struggle before independence, uprising of 1857 and the Government's escalating need for a huge task force for the Railway project. Under this act, the British Government proclaimed around 272 tribes as 'criminal by birth'. This act which avers a human being as 'criminal by birth' must be the first of its kind in the entire world and was prepared by a British Officer named T. V. Stephens. He justified the terms of the act by expounding that, 'In India, the caste and the occupation are always co-related just as the son of a carpenter at all times becomes a carpenter and eventually this occupation develops into a family tradition for centuries. With this elucidation, the concept of 'professional criminal' would be lucid. It meant that members of such tribes are criminals from eons, have used their caste for committing crimes and as their successors inherit the same criminal disposition, they will also continue to commit crimes. Hence, improvement is impossible since their profession, belief and religion is committing crimes.' Under this act, the British Government proclaimed the following nine tribes as 'criminals'.

Kaikadi, Takari (Bhamta), Pamlor, Bestar, Kanjarbhat, Chaparband, Mang Garudi, Rajput Bhamta and Fasepardhee (haranshikaree).

This act eventually got converted into 'Criminal Tribes Central Act of 1924' which was in force till 1952.

Incarceration in the Settlement

After bringing the Criminal Tribes Act in force in 1871, Government began widespread arrests of people from those tribes which were included in the act. They were sent off to the 'Settlements'. A settlement was a specially formed cramped colony which was actually an open jail for nomads, who were confined within and had a 17 feet high barbed wire fence on its periphery. There were total 52 settlements in the country - in Delhi, Madhya Pradesh, Bengal, Madras, at Ahmedabad and Zabwa in Gujarat, at Hyderabad in Andhra Pradesh, at Gulbarga in Karnataka, at Ambarnath, Mundhwa, Sholapur, Gokak in Maharashtra. The one in Sholapur was the largest. Tribal families were virtually cramped in that settlement like a flock of sheep. There were families of seven tribes - *Laman, Banjara, Wadar, Kaikadee, Bhamte, Takari, Ramoshi and Pardhee*. The rules of the settlement were very harsh and oppressive. They were applicable even to the new-born infants. A virtual head count was daily conducted in the morning and evening. Police used to conduct random raids at any odd hour of the night to re-check on the inmates by brashly pulling the covers off the sleeping people. There used to be a daily journal maintained for people going out for work. One had to obtain a written permission of the presiding officer to visit another place. One had to submit that pass to the officer known as the '*Patil*' of the visiting town and retrieve it while returning. The men from the settlement used to get harnessed as labourers at the construction site of the Railway

tracks while their families - the womenfolk and the children were locked up. The only saving grace was, education was mandatory for every child and the men would be paid daily wages at the end of the day, but the lives of the residents of the settlement were virtually monitored by the British Rulers. They were under constant surveillance of the Government Officers. The men were never allowed to walk independently to work, the policemen used to truss them with a rope and propel them to the place of work. A group of twenty to twenty five men were controlled by four to five policemen. In short, a form of slavery!

Nomads became 'distinctively free'.

With the joint efforts of the then Law Minister Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar and a few other members of parliament along with the initiative led by the then Prime Minister, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, on 31st August 1952 this cruel Criminal Tribes Act was given a solemn burial! Prime Minister, in his speech in the Parliament said, 'After Independence, we all are free, but I wish to tell all my countrymen belonging to the different societies that as all the members of the so called Criminal Tribes are freedom fighters, today they are 'distinctively free'. From that day, they were given the name '*vimukt*' in Marathi which is translated as 'de-notified' in the Government records. That day was the dawn of the freedom for the nomads. After Maharashtra became an independent state, on 13th August 1961, the then Chief Minister of Maharashtra, Yashwantrao Chavan at a function, invited the then Prime Minister of India, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru to cut the wires of the fence around the settlement in Sholapur as a token of freedom to the residents of the settlement. Thus, the Nomads got the freedom twice. But the real question lingers : even with the distinct freedom, what have they achieved?

In Maharashtra alone, there are 42 nomad and de-notified tribes as also, there are about three hundred and fifty sub tribes. Even after so many years of Independence, these nomads still continue moving from one place to other with all their belongings on their backs. The hallmark of 'criminal' on their foreheads is yet to get erased. Still a crore and a half of people, equivalent to roughly a ten percent of the State's population, are scattered in these tribes and sub tribes. The real tragedy, till date, is they have not been conferred with the customary and respectable life. The entire community of these tribes was at the forefront in the struggle against the British Rule. In the latter half of the nineteenth century, the idea of '*swaraj*' - self-rule - had started acquiring roots in the Indian psyche. The nomadic tribes were at the forefront in this struggle as they fought with a single minded focus. But to wage war against the mighty British Rulers involved a lot of money. The nomads, particularly *Takari* community garnered funds by pillaging and marauding the Government vaults and houses of the wealthy people. They even helped Kings and Princes in their internal wars. Thus, the *Takari* community gained notoriety as 'criminals' in the eyes of the British Rulers. Britishers could not bear the fact that their treasures were being plundered and pillaged by the nomads. Consequently, they enforced the '1871 Criminal Tribes Act' and confined the so called thieving nomads. *Takari* tribe was notorious for its daredevil and devious acts among all nomadic tribes. This community's contribution to the Independence struggle is very vital and significant. Malharrao Gaikawad from Baramati, Bajeerao Balwant Pawar from Mundhwa, Pune, Bheemrao Jadhav Guruji from Sholapur are major freedom fighters of that community. I belong to the same community.

The origins of the *Takari* community are from Andhra Pradesh, in the basin of the River Godavari and their native language is

Telegu. In that region, they were known as '*Bhumenoru*' - people who take land on lease for farming. In the markets of the districts like Satara, Sangli, Sholapur and talukas such as Barshi and Madha in Maharashtra, these nomadic tribes used to wander aimlessly and stealthily carry away the parcels of farmers' purchases. They were, therefore called '*Uchlya*'- Pickers. They were known with the same name as '*Uchlya*' in Pune too. They were very shrewd charlatans and thieves. They used to engage the wealthy people in a conversation and at the same time, deftly succeed in obtaining the golden rings from their fingers while replacing the same with gilded brass rings. In some parts of Marathwada, the women from this community too, used to go from village to village under pretext of selling stone grinders. They would then locate the houses of wealthy families. While engaging the ladies of the house in conversation, they would minutely observe everything and relay that information to the menfolk, who in turn used to plunder such houses at night. In this part, the community got known as *Takari*. Around Kolhapur and Belgaum, they were known as '*Ghantichor*'- stealers of temple bells. In Khandesh, this community used to help people by delivering water from the rivers and wells to their homes. They used a '*Kavad*' for this purpose. The *Kavad* is basically a bamboo horizontally carried on the shoulder and at both ends pots of water are suspended by means of ropes. Thus, they were known as '*Kamathis*' in this region.

This '*Takari*' community has a place in the famous love story of Bajirao-Mastani too. When Mastani arrived at Pune with Bajirao, she was not accepted by the Peshwa family. So, Bajirao Peshwa built a separate palace for her in Pabal near Pune. While she was living there alone, Peshwa entrusted round the clock security for her on responsible, trustworthy, sturdy and honest men from the *Takari* community. They carried out that responsibility so

efficiently that Peshwa rewarded them with land and a permanent monthly allowance (such allowance is called '*Tankha*' in Marathi). There used to be some armed guards from '*Uchlya*' community also.

Takari community is divided in two surnames and four clans. Gaikwad and Jadhav are the two surnames and *Kasaknoro*, *Papnoro*, *Bhumeneru* and *Minagloru* are four clans. Marriages take place between Gaikwads and Jadhavs. At some places, the residents adopt the surname of their respective village. In the state of Karnataka, some people adopt the surname based on the names and descriptions of the towns or on the construction work at which they work as labourers. For example, *Dodmani*, *Hadimani*, *Myalginmani*, *Telgimani*, *Kattimani* and many more. However, the base surnames are either Gaikwad or Jadhav, with a rare addition of Pawar. Some people have changed their surnames to co-relate with others from that place where they work and live.

Takari community is mainly populated in Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Gujrat and Rajasthan. In Maharashtra, the population of this community is around a lac and is predominantly scattered in Sholapur, Satara, Sangli, Kolhapur, Pune, Ahmednagar, Usmanabad and Latur districts. In Pune it is spread in Baramati, Mundhwa, Pabal, Dapodi, Bopodi, Fugewadi and Bopkhel. In Maharashtra, the names of some villages are recognized as belonging to the '*Takaris*'. For example - Takari's Wadgaon, Uchlyas' Shindegaon (in Karjat Taluka).

Soundati from Karnataka and Yellama Devi in Konhali near Akkalkot from Sholapur District in Maharashtra are two main family deities of the *Takari* community. *Takari* community along with the people of Kaikadi and Pamlor castes attend the annual pilgrimage of these deities in large numbers. The highlight of these pilgrimages is a popular game called '*Shidi*' (Ladder). An

individual undertakes a vow before the deity and upon fulfilment of the same, he carries on his back, a ladder bearing nails which are secured on to his back and he is surrounded by many other devotees. It is believed that the devotee who executes this torturous activity is blessed by the deity. This ritual is, however, now been suspended. An offering of *Puran Poli*, a typical vegetarian, sweet delicacy of Maharashtra is presented to the deity.

There is a legend about this deity : Some members of the *Takari* community from Soundati (the deity from Karnataka) were returning from some place and decided to camp for the night in the town of Konhali (in Sholapur District). In the morning, when they were about to resume their return journey, they found that none of them could lift one particular sack, that was otherwise easily carried on the back by a few during the earlier part of the journey. It had become extremely heavy and even the sturdiest of the men were unable to lift it. It was then opened and emptied except for a few coconuts. Yet, it could not be lifted. Then a divine voice ordained from the sack, 'I am Renuka Devi (the Goddess). I wish to stay here.' It being a mandate of the Goddess, it was duly respected and a 'Gudi', a scaffolding of bamboo and stone was erected at that place. This deity became well known as '*Yellamma Devi*' of Konhali. Record shows that the King of the princely state of Akkalkot donated the idol of *Yellamma* (also known as 'Renuka'). There is also another legend : Shri Swami Samarth, along with many of His devotees was proceeding towards Akkalkot. By evening, the devotees were exhausted and famished. When the pangs of hunger turned excruciating, one devotee mustered enough courage and approached Swamiji to inform Him that they all felt famished. Swami was furious as He retorted, 'Why did you not tell me earlier?' Then he indicated the temple of Yellama Devi and said, 'Food is ready at the temple.'

When the group reached the temple, they found plates laden with scrumptious food and five sweet delicacies laid out for them. An old woman bearing a stick in her hand guarded the food. She was *Annapurna Devi* - the Goddess of food. This legend is recorded in *Bakhri* script in the library of the Akkalkot temple.

The honour of worshipping *Yellamma* Devi of Konhali is bestowed on the *Takari* community. We, the members of this community are recognized as the officiating '*Pujaris*' - the '*priests*'. Our family and a few other priestly class families have the honour of bestowing the 'first offering' (*Naivedya*) to the Goddess. My mother worshipped this deity for 42 years. She used to attend the annual pilgrimage each year without fail primarily for two reasons : first being that the ashes of my father have been interred in front of the temple. Hence, this reason made the place very special for her. Another reason - the place of pilgrimage is around 1 to 2 kilometres away from the main road and it takes place during the long, hot summer month of May, the pilgrims get parched with thirst and this part being drought affected, drinking water is not easily available. My mother used to arrange for a free potable water tanker for the pilgrims to quench their thirst. In addition, she would also provide food for those who would stay overnight. She continued this philanthropic act for very many years without fail. It is precisely for the very same reasons, I have a deep, abiding faith in this deity. I have interred my mother's ashes too, in the vicinity of this temple. I diligently follow my mother's footsteps in philanthropy and social work with equal devotion as hers.



On the Path of learning

In the year 1956, my mother's services were transferred to the Certified High School for Girls, which was also known as the 'Remand Home', located at Mundhwa, a suburb in Pune. At that time I was studying in the first standard. Our family consisting of my mother, father-Tatya, my two sisters Sarojini and Ratnamala and myself - resided near 'the settlement' in Mundhwa. Only a barbed wire fence separated the settlement and the Remand Home. The Police used to nab the aimlessly wandering orphan girls on the streets and admit them in the Remand Home. My mother was the caretaker of the girls and also used to cook for them. I was put in the primary school very close to the Remand Home. Thus my 'schooling' career began. We were quite fortunate to leave the settlement of Sholapur and settle in a place like Pune. In our view, it was quite commendable. Mother used to leave for work at seven in the morning. She used to cook our meals before leaving for work. The food used to be quite monotonous – whole green gram (Moong) and Moth beans (Matki) or *Ganji*- a porridge made from wheat floor. As the adage goes, 'hunger knows no taste', so also, we used to eat whatever was cooked to

overcome the pangs of hunger and leave for school. School timings were from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. Post school, we were not very particular about returning home directly. At times, we would loiter, play and then return home as per our whims and fancies. I was good at studies and hence a bright student. So my mother used to be very pleased with me and never put any curbs on my playing or loitering activities. She would always reiterate, 'Study and learn as much as you can. Gain knowledge and be 'big' in life!' A very humble expectation from her, though not for herself but for my own well-being! So, I used to attend my school daily and diligently study hard. At that time we were living in the Government Quarters of the Remand Home where my mother was working. One Kumudini Paranjpe - Paranjpe Madam as we used to call her - was a teacher in the same Certified School. She used to live in the quarters next to ours. Her son Vijay was in my class. We were very close friends. I was a frequent visitor to his house. Paranjpe madam used to love me a lot and would treat me as her own son. She used to make me study a lot. She used to make me recite the divine hymns such as Ramraksha, Gayatri Mantra and Shubham Karoti. The Chief of Remand Home was one Mrs. Lagoo. Her son Balasaheb used to trail behind in the class since he was not very good at his studies. So she would request me to study with him. I was well-liked by all since I was clever in studies and used to look cute with a chubby mien.

As I progressed very well in my studies, all my teachers fussed over me and encouraged me to study harder. When I was in the fourth standard, Mr. M. G. Wadekar was our teacher. He encouraged me to appear for the external Scholarship Examination. He nurtured a firm belief that I would win the Scholarship. He not only took personal efforts in coaching me but also ferried me on his bicycle to and from the Examination Centre. I stood first in that examination in Pune and thus, lived up

to his expectations. I won the scholarship. My mother was extremely happy. As she used to be busy the whole day long, she could not devote time for me but she was well aware that others were helping me.

There was another external scholarship examination for the seventh standard students. It was considered to be equivalent to the Bachelor Degree's examination. This examination used to be held in Pune city. My Examination Centre was near Perugate. There was a lodge named 'Shashank Lodge' in Navi Peth area close to the examination centre. Arrangements were made for me and my classmates to reside at that lodge during the entire week of the examination. Other students used to get lunch from their respective homes. Since my mother was busy and working, she was unable to send lunch for me. But my teacher Mr. Wadekar used to do that for me or arrange it with someone for me. My mother used to visit me and carry lunch for me over the weekends when she was free. Thus I passed the prestigious external examination with good marks. Considering our average financial condition, my teachers advised me to study for the 'STC' course. Upon completion of that course, it would facilitate one to get a job as a teacher in a school. I took my mother's advice. She convinced me against going for the course. She said that I was too small to be a teacher, no one would make me teacher. (I was only twelve years old at that time.) The school which I attended was only up to seventh standard. So it was necessary for me to change the school. Fortunately, one of the teachers, Mr. Nemade had started a school in Mundhwa – Vidya Vikas Mandir - for standard eighth, ninth and tenth. He and one Mrs. Kulkarni were teachers in that school. I joined that school. I continued to score good marks and also excelled in sports and drawing. In those years, the daily newspaper '*Sakal*' used to publish a special supplement. Though I really do not recall the exact year but I clearly remember that I had

drawn a picture of Lord Ganapati which I had sent to the *Sakal* Newspaper and it was published in that supplement. It was a very memorable event for me and filled me up with great happiness and pride. After school hours, we had to compulsorily spin yarn for an hour on a daily basis in school. We used to weave cloth and get our clothes made from that cloth.

I completed my education till tenth standard at Vidyavikas Mandir and the Government unexpectedly suspended the recognition of this school! I thought that was the end of my education. It was not just a school for me but my future was hinged on it! But my mother firmly supported me. She was fully aware of the importance of education in life and had always cherished a dream that I ought to be well educated. She was not the one to see her dream get shattered. The comforting thought of my mother's unflinching support reassured me considerably. It was then imperative to seek further path of learning. In the days that followed, I had a single focussed motive and that was to cycle down from Mundhwa to Pune City in search of good schools. It was an amply clear situation that in spite of locating a school, I may or may not obtain admission immediately.

I had a very close friend called Samarnath Dubey during my school days. We studied together right from first standard. He used to stay with his uncle. His parents were in Uttar Pradesh. His uncle used to work at the Deccan Paper Mill at Pune. Though they were Brahmins yet, his uncle never discriminated me on the grounds of my substandard caste. My house was like a second home to Samarnath. Our firm and close friendship continued for years. Even as of today, we are together. For a short while, he was working at my Institute. So, Samarnath and I went to New English School to seek admission but unknown to us that school was steeped in casteism. Accordingly, Samarnath got admission immediately on account of his superior caste while I was rejected

on account my substandard caste. Since admission was not granted to me, Samarnath too, decided not to join that school. He always sacrificed his school admission for my sake. Our frantic and desperate search for school continued till we landed at Bharat High School. We made inquiries for admission. Till such time, due to myriad refusals, we despaired as the future looked bleak. In such a forlorn state of mind, we went to Bharat School and sat hunched in front of the Headmaster's office and wept in utter despair. A teacher, called Godbole, inquired in a rather harsh tone, 'What are you doing here? Why are you crying?' We told him about our desperation for the admission in the school. He looked at us and then looked at the mark lists which were tightly clenched in our hands. He asked for those mark lists, had a good look at them. The marks were very good. He went in the Headmaster's office with those mark lists in his hands. Though the ensuing discussion with the Headmaster, Mr. B.N. Kulkarni was inaudible yet we could surmise from the gestures that another refusal was on the way. Our hopes plummeted as that meant further hunt for more school visits and more petitions... After quite some time both, Mr. Godbole and Mr. Kulkarni came out. We were not aware about the discussions between them, but Mr. Kulkarni told us, 'You will not get admission right away but a conditional one for three months only, after which you have to appear for an internal examination. If you score more than 50% marks, we will confirm your admission. If not, you will have to leave the school.' We were in a tight spot but we readily accepted the condition. I earnestly wished to attend school. I was ready to put in phenomenal amount of efforts. Our school began. I constantly reminded myself about Mr. Kulkarni's condition of the three months' period. I toiled real hard at my studies. Finally, the examination took place and ... I scored 90% marks in that test as against the mandatory marks of 50%. Even the Headmaster was speechless! He was so uncertain that he ordered a reassessment of the papers. The results remained

unchanged. All papers scored around 85-90 marks. He liked my answers so much that he called me before the classroom and expressed his appreciation as he patted my back before the entire class. He mentioned, 'Here is a student whom we had almost denied admission in our school and see how has he performed! It is exemplary. All of you should follow his example. You all hail from well-to-do families and have everything going well for you, yet you all find it difficult to score even 80% marks!' Thus, I was finally admitted in Bharat High School to study in the eleventh standard. I was extremely happy but over and above that, was my boundless happiness and satisfaction of fulfilling the stringent condition laid down by the Headmaster and surmounting it with stupendous success.

When I narrated the entire story to my mother, she was deeply overwhelmed and happy about her son's achievement. During those days, there used to be only one bus at seven in the morning to go from Mundhwa to Pune and only one at seven in the evening for the return journey. So the bus service was not really feasible for me. The only available option was to use a bicycle. But I did not have a bicycle. There was only one shop in Mundhwa where bicycles were available on rent. At that time, Mr. Aaba Jagtap from Saswad used to run that bicycle shop in Mundhwa. The monthly rent of a bicycle was five rupees and was naturally too steep for me. In order to pay the bicycle rent every month, I began to work at his shop over the weekends. This routine continued till I received my Post Graduate Degree.

After passing the twelfth year examination, I took admission in Maharashtra Education Society's Garware College. I opted for the Arts stream and graduated in Economics with Honours with a very good score of marks. During my college days, I made many new friends. I shared close friendships with senior actor Vikram

Gokhale and renowned sportsman (Maharashtra Shree) Arun Datar. Vikram was a seasoned actor on stage as well as on screen. In our group, he used to act as Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj and deliver dialogues befitting the distinctive historic era. He would then seek our feedback on the delivery of his dialogues and histrionics and our appreciation would spur him further. He was and still is a remarkable thespian. On the strength of his brilliant acting ability, he has attained such lofty heights in the world of entertainment. In those days, there used to be an Irani Hotel, Cafe Sunrise at Deccan Gymkhana. Our group of friends used to meet there once a week. Arun, Vikram, Dharwadkar, Mundle, Chhotya Datar, Vijay Bhide, Balu Gawli and myself used to spend 2 to 3 hours together over 10-20 cups of tea. In that cafe, there used to be a Juke Box where one had to drop a coin in the slot, select a record according to choice and it used to play the song. It was probably first of its kind in Pune. However, after a while, we had some dispute with the Hotel owner and we changed our meeting-place to another coffee house opposite Deccan Gymkhana Bus Stand. It was being run by Suresh Kalmadi. He was thirty two years old and had started a very big institution, 'Giant'. Eventually, he brought us, college friends together to conduct some programmes and formed a students' association.

I used to commute to college on a bicycle. But during the time of examinations, with the intention of saving the long commute time, I used to rent a room in Sadashiv Peth from the landlord, Mr. Shashank Barawkar for a monthly rent of Rupees Ten. I earned my Bachelor of Arts degree in the year 1968 with good marks. During those college years, Balasaheb Bharde used to help me out by providing the necessary books, notebooks and other study material. After graduation, I received a call for a Government Service to work as an Officer at the 'Bureau of Economics and Statistics' in Ahmednagar. Without informing or consulting my

mother, I accepted the job. After a week, when I mentioned it to her, she was not only hurt but annoyed too. She berated me, 'who told you to work?' She insisted that I must complete my Post Graduation. I was also ill- treated and harassed at the work place owing to my substandard caste. My superiors humiliated me. I felt morose and my mother's displeasure compelled me to resign and seek admission in Pune University for my Post Graduation studies.

In Pune University, I opted for a dual Post graduation in Economics and Politics. Both the subjects used to be taught in one department. The Professors were renowned scholars. We had privilege of learning Economics from Professors Dhawle, Rath, Dandekar and Politics from Prof. Sirsikar and Ram Bapat. For both the subjects, it was mandatory to appear for eight papers within two years. I completed all the sixteen papers and earned both the degrees - Masters in Economics and Masters in Politics. During my years at the University, I was not living in the hostel. For some period I continued my commute on the bicycle between Mundhwa and Pune. Then I found a place near Deccan Gymkhana. It was in a bungalow owned by one Mr. Gadgil. There was a small room - ten feet by ten feet - under the staircase. I used to share the room with one of my close friends Balasaheb Ramchandra Gawli from Saswad. The room could accommodate only one cot. So we used to take turns to sleep on the cot, one week I would sleep on the cot and next week Balasaheb. The same weekly pattern was followed in case of food. For one week, the tiffin used to come from my house, the next week from Balasaheb's house. There used to be *Bhakris*, flat bread made of jowar or millet in the tiffins. Those Bhakris were our daily food intake. Those two years were very vital for me. I used to spend more time outside the classroom than inside. I had spent maximum time on playground. During that period, Pune

University was full of students coming from other states, other countries, from Nepal and Southern India too.

I was very fond of singing right since my childhood. My mother and my elder sister were good singers too. My elder sister had a very melodious voice and I too, had a good voice. While at the University, I used to sing songs sung by the then popular singers such as Mohammed Rafi, Kishore Kumar and Manna De. I could modulate my voice to sing to their respective style.

Once there was a talent hunt singing competition. I sang '*Laga Chunarime Daag*', '*Ye Dil Na Hota Bechara*', and '*O Duniya ke Rakhwale*', originally sung by Manna De, Kishor Kumar and Mohmad Rafi respectively. I won the first prize in that competition. I became famous after that resounding success and it turned into a topic of discussions at the University. A big group of friends used to sit in the canteen and discuss varied subjects. I used to enthusiastically participate in those discussions, but my role was limited to that of a listener. Sometimes arguments would arise on the sensitive subjects like Brahmins and Non-Brahmins and then the discussions would acquire discordant hues. I refrained from such controversial discussions. I had friends of different religions, castes, and backgrounds. A small group of 'close friends' was also formed. Due to my happy and gregarious disposition, my friends nicknamed me as 'Raja'. We used to visit Lonavala by railway and used to enjoy rambling amidst the verdant nature. Sometimes, we used get to watch a film shoot in progress while occasionally, we used to get paid for our participation as spectators. The Municipal Corporation of Lonavala had a big hall for sports. We used to go there and play carom. One day, while playing, a friend indicated at a player at the next table and inquired whether I recognised that person. I looked at him and replied, 'Not really but the face seems to be familiar.' We decided to find out his identity. We went near him and politely

asked him his name. He was a bit taken aback as he wished to know why were we interested in knowing his name? We told him that his countenance appeared very familiar.' Then he replied, 'I am Manna De.' We could not believe our good luck. We asked him if he would accept our invitation for singing before an audience of 50-60 students in a hall. He immediately agreed. Prior to the start of this programme I sang a few of his songs and also some of Mohammed Rafi and Kishore Kumar. He appreciated my singing. While enjoying such extra-curricular activities, I never neglected studies. During that period, I attended a tuition class for English language too. At that time there were only two English Tuition classes in Pune - Dake's and Sattigiri's. I joined Sattigiri's classes. My English improved tremendously and I immensely benefitted from it in the future.

When I was doing masters at the University, a coaching course of the Indian Administrative Services had begun. I appeared for its entrance examination and obtained eleventh rank in the merit list and there were only ten seats. However, one of my friends obtained fifth rank in the merit list. I found it a bit strange because he always scored less marks than me roughly by at least 5 to 6 %. Under such circumstances, I felt something amiss, so I attempted to inquire about the same. Since my efforts were being thwarted, I directly approached the office of the Vice Chancellor of the University and expressed my misgivings. He casually replied that he would look into the matter but I found his answer very non-committal. At that time Dr. B. P. Apte was the Vice Chancellor and prior to that he was the Dean of the Sassoon Hospital in Pune. So, around eight o'clock that night I went to his residence. The security guard denied permission. I was furious. I picked up a stone and threatened him that if he did not allow me to meet the Vice Chancellor, I would assault him. Somehow, he let the Vice Chancellor know that I wanted to meet him and finally Dr. Apte

called me in. After admonishing me soundly for threatening the security guard, he asked me to explain the purpose of my visit. I expressed my suspicions and demanded that a reassessment of my papers and that of the candidate who had obtained the fifth rank be conducted in my presence, else I would not leave! Dr. Apte was taken aback and impressed by my confidence. He assured me that he would personally look into the issue and asked me to meet him the following morning at 11 A.M. in his office. I went at the appointed hour. He appointed a committee of three professors, one of them was Prof. Sirsikar. The committee reassessed the concerned papers in my presence. When asked by the Vice Chancellor, one of the members affirmed, 'I think he is right.' Thus, I obtained the right place in the merit list. The fact is I am militant. I find it difficult to bear injustice and dishonesties. When I am not at fault and anybody tries to frame me for that, I turn belligerent and retaliate but I fight back for the truth.

I was very pleased that my name appeared in the merit list but I was more happy about my own self-confidence for writing that paper and proving my aptitude. But around that same time my younger sister, Ratnamala passed away due to the sheer negligence of the attending doctors while conducting a minor surgery on her. My mother and I were devastated by her demise and my dream of becoming an IAS officer was also smashed to smithereens forever.



Reinforced at the Camps

After my post graduation, I met many friends with socialistic bent of mind. Many of them later attained lofty posts in politics and in society too. Respected leaders like Mr. S. M. Joshi, Dr. Baba Adhav and Bhai Vaidya were my mentors and guides in the world of activism and stir. They inculcated the valuable principles and ethics of agitations and demonstrations.

During my residential tenure at the settlement in Mundhwa, the members of the Rashtriya Seva Dal - an organization of young patriots - would congregate there. I would participate in their activities too. Many a times, their leader Bhai Vaidya used to cycle down all the way from Pune to visit and guide them. I was highly impressed by his socialistic trend of thinking. He also used to visit our settlement. That is how I was influenced by his philosophy. Around that time, the Rashtriya Seva Dal used to conduct residential camps in Pune for duration of a week or sometimes even for a month and many great national leaders and thinkers would attend. Thus, we would largely benefit by their guidance. I started attending those camps. I was not only suitably

impressed or influenced but overwhelmed too, by the thoughts and philosophy of visiting leaders. I virtually got moulded at those camps. Those great personalities fostered my ideologies. Among those were, S. M. Joshi, N. G. Gore, Acharya S. D. Jawdekar and also Jayprakash Narayan, Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia, Sane Guruji and Madhu Limaye. Being profoundly inspired by such great thinkers and leaders, I began to participate whole heartedly and actively in many agitations and demonstrations, predominantly for the well-being of my nomadic communities. During those days, we all workers used to meet at a place in the Timber Market which was owned by one Shantaram Diwekar. Besides me, N.G.Gore, Shantaram Diwekar (Ex Mayor of Pune), Narendra Dabholkar, Anil and Anita Awachat, Wyankappa Bhosle (a worker from Pardhi community) Laxman Mane, Balkrishna Renke, Vilas Wadekar, Mulchand Bhaat, Nawa Mane, Wahroo Sonavane, Siddhu Shinde (from Vaidoo community), Smita Patil and Neelam Gorhe used to attend those meetings. These co-workers and activists imparted the valuable fundamental knowledge of how to stand up against injustice and how to cope with the various machinations. They virtually moulded me into a social worker and metamorphosed my thought process and ideologies which helped me immensely during the forthcoming period of my life.

Once, when Barrister Govindrao Adik was the Chief Minister of Maharashtra, he was going to hoist the national flag on Police Ground on the occasion of the Independence Day. We all had planned a mass protest to raise our demands for obtaining 'justice for the nomadic communities and freedom from being treated as criminals' during that flag hoisting ceremony by desisting him from hoisting the flag. This demonstration was being executed under the able leadership of Baba Adhav. As soon as we got the information that the Chief Minister was on his way from the

University to arrive at the Police Ground, Baba Adhav ordered all the protestors to lie down on the road and block his path. Since we had not given any prior intimation about our demonstration, this unexpected action created a furore. Unknown to us, our agitation amounted as a contempt of the national flag and hence, a national crime. The police swiftly swooped on us, mercilessly thrashed us and packed us in police vans. They took us away and left us on the isolated Sinhgad Road, about ten to twelve kilometres from the Police Ground. We had to literally limp home on that long stretch after been brutally beaten and kicked by the police. The excruciating pain almost paralysed us for a week. The brutal, hard blow on my neck rendered by the police has effected a lifetime pain. But that agitation inculcated the strength and the tenacious capacity to fight against injustice and to work for the well-being of the unprotected and weaker sections of the orphans and nomads.



And I became the Chairman.....

In the earlier period, the population at the settlement camp in Mundhwa used to be around a hundred and now it has burgeoned to about five to six thousand! This area is known as the 'Ex-criminal community colony'. In the year 1965, my mother got a transfer to Shiroor. At that time I was studying in the First Year of Arts. My elder sister Sarojini was at the Sevasadan while Ratnamala was studying in Hingne. Till my mother's transfer, we resided at a house in the Government Quarters but owing to her transfer, we had to surrender that house and move out. As per my mother's instructions, we rented a house in the Mundhwa Settlement while she proceeded to Shiroor. The rented house was in a housing society and one Rama Shetty (Gaikwad) belonging to the Kaikadi community was the Chairman of that Housing Society. He was also our next door neighbour (he continues to stay there, even today). He had a tall, imposing sturdy physique and was also very rich and wealthy, a moneylender by profession. These factors made his personality rather awe-inspiring. People used to respect him mainly out of fear. He had five sons who were tall with a burly physique and

they were in the money lending business too. The three of us - my two sisters and I slowly got accustomed to the new environment. It was my very first association with the residents of the settlement, in other words, with fellow members of my nomadic and de-notified tribes. I had to put up with uneducated, boorish people, bootlegging activities, thugs brandishing knives and swords, abusive, foul exchange of words leading to very violent and gory fights. Only a few hours during the day used to be quiet and peaceful, but the nights were a nightmare. Though today times have changed, standard of living and sartorial habits have changed, yet the mind-set has remained unchanged.

There was a large, empty, room in the settlement, which earlier belonged to a British Officer. Freedom fighter Mr. Hiranman Goud's son got that room renovated. It was being used for public functions, programmes and was being referred to as '*Kendra*'-Centre. There I reinstated a '*Balwadi*' - place for children to study, play and to be together for some time of the day. This *Balwadi* was the maiden effort of my Social Work. I attempted to collect books, note books, toys for the children of my *Balwadi* with the financial help from Mr. B. G. Shirke, the owner of a very big factory - Bharat Forge. Gradually, I attempted to settle disputes and quarrels in the Settlement. People slowly made a note of my activities and I was looked upon as 'Rama Shetty's man'. He inspired considerable awe amongst everybody. People were not afraid of me but no one spoke against me or opposed my activities. I forged friendship with some youngsters like, Sawata Gaikwad, Shivdas Jadhav, Parmar, Heena Kacchaway, Shankar Gaikwad, Neelakantha Bhosle and we formed a friends' association called '*Sarvodaya Mitramandal*'. We used to organise events like Kabaddi and Cricket which were very popular games at that time. We used to hold competitions, matches etc. I recall, at one such inauguration of a competition, our donor, the renowned

industrialist, Mr. B. G. Shirke was the chief guest and he got down on the ground and played cricket with us. I used to also encourage children to participate in the other competitions than those held in our society. In the settlement, there were a few Muslims too, my friends and I used to participate in their Dargah festivals. My friends Vishwanath Gaikwad and Kashinath helped to maintain and even carried out a few repairs in the Dargah. My participation in the Society meetings, social work and also in working of the Community Council gradually increased. The '*Kendra*' became 'my office'. I began to be summoned for counselling and for settling disputes. Owing to my higher education, I was being looked upon as a role model in the field of education. People across all caste and creed approached me as I sincerely helped them. I attempted to discourage people from drinking, using abusive language and indulging in thefts. I established very cordial relations with friends like Govind Lonkar, Ramdas Lokar, Madhu Badhe, Ulhas Kulkarni, Ram Wadekar, Parshuram Bhandari and Uttam Kolhe.

The first Prime Minister of India, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru had cut the fences around the settlements and liberated the residents. In the year 1952, during the rehabilitation programme of these residents, they were offered houses and lands. That work is still underway. Under that programme, 225 acres land was given to Mundhwa settlement. That government land was being cultivated collectively and was titled as 'Sarvoday Collective Farming Society'. Rama Shetty, whom I used to refer as '*Mama*' - maternal uncle - was the chairman of that society also. He was illiterate, so he would consult me to read letters for him. He had a manager whose name was Mr. Hiremath. He was employed right from the British period, to look after the society's business dealings. Our nomadic community was always a victim of the hostile atmosphere and the distrustful attitude of the Government

authorities. As a result, there were hardly any educated people in the community. Since I was an exception, Mr. Hiremath was very pleased with me. He harboured a fear that in a fit of drunken rage the people around would damage his office and destroy his well-maintained records. Hence, he entrusted me with the responsibility of tending to the records. A few days later Mr. Hiremath passed away. Rama Shetty had great faith in my abilities, so he entrusted me with the Society's work and all the correspondence. I worked earnestly and gradually Rama Shetty became dependable on me for most of his work. He advised me to buy a house in the society. I did not have the necessary funds, yet we bought a house for Rupees One Thousand Four Hundred by selling off my mother's silver jewellery. Rama Shetty grew old and the daily grind of work used to exhaust him. One day, he announced, 'Shivalal, from tomorrow, you will be the Chairman of the Society'. I was speechless! He had already decided to hand over to me the reins of the Chairman's office with 45 houses and 225 acres of land! It was an overwhelming moment and I began to falter, 'Mama, how will I manage? I have no knowledge of farming activities...' But he firmly replied, 'I do not know about that. You are going to be the Chairman... and that is certain!' He issued a soft threat by insisting that I must be present for the Society meeting the following Sunday and if I avoided to do so, he would truss me up. I attended the meeting. As usual, most of the members present for the meeting were drunk. Mama said, 'This young man is the highly educated amongst us and so we must make him our Chairman.' The proposal was spontaneously approved by all present. The resolution of my appointment was also drafted and written by me and then a few signatories signed. Many, being illiterate, gave thumb impressions. - Thus I became the Chairman!

It was in the year 1972, I began to work as a Chairman. As I got involved in Society affairs, I gradually learnt the problems and difficulties. I earnestly set about to resolve them to the best of my ability. 225 acres of land was divided in very small parcels. People who had the wherewithal used to diligently carry out farming activities. Water was a very scarce commodity and in order to get that, they would steal water from the village in the dead of the night. Thus, this was the perennial reason for quarrels and fights. People were frightened. The villagers used to lodge police complaints. When the police would visit the houses, the man of the house would abscond and leave the women to face the police. Thus, the police would be constraint from taking any action, else they would be subject to stone pelting by the menfolk and the youngsters. Hence, everybody would refrain and stay away from this society.

The position of the Chairman gave me opportunity to know my community better. Till such time, I was not very conversant with the details about my community. Gradually, I learnt about the various castes and sub castes, their occupations, the art of pick pocketing, stealing, thefts and bootlegging activities. I familiarised myself with the 'illicit brewing process' of liquor. In very many houses, they would mix ammonium chloride, jaggery and kerosene in a big kerosene can. This can was kept in a deep pit in the dumping yard situated behind the house for a period of three to four days. This dumping yard was always frequented by stray dogs and the pigs to forage for scraps of food and also to defecate and urinate there. Later, this tin can used to be unearthed from the pit and put on the stove for distilling. The steam from it would be collected in a container and thus, the brew would be ready for consumption. This activity was carried out in almost all houses. During a police raid, they were paid 'hush' money as bribe and /or given a free drink of the brew and offered it to others too.

People from the village used to frequent here for drinking. I think this witnessing such squalid, unhygienic illicit brewery everywhere, desisted me from alcohol permanently. I have not touched alcohol till today. I realized that such regressive and degenerating attitude had become characteristic of our community. I must mention that this Chairmanship opened the vistas of the 'worldly wisdom' for me.



The Matrimonial Bond



Shivalal Jadhav's marriage ceremony.

My mother spared no efforts, whatsoever, while providing education for my two elder sisters and myself. She surmounted all the odds that came in her path. My second sister passed away in 1971 during a

tonsillectomy while my eldest sister was studying for a Nursing Course. As per the norms of our caste, it was mandatory for any auspicious ceremony like marriage to be conducted within a year of the demise in the family, as was in the case of my sister. So my mother took the decision of my marriage without consulting or even without informing me. It was during the year 1972 while I was at Pune, my mother was at Sholapur for some reason and she finalised my marriage there! The bride she had selected for me had studied up to fifth standard only - a barely educated girl for a well-educated boy. The bride and the bridegroom had neither met nor seen each other. My mother had personally taken all the decisions and informed me about the same through her letter. Her letter read as, 'Your marriage is fixed for 28th of May. You may leave Pune on the 25th for Sholapur. There are about two to three hundred rupees kept in the house. Buy some suitable clothes and shoes for yourself.' My mother's was the last word for me and I used to follow very obediently. In this case also, I followed her instructions by leaving for Sholapur by train. My bride shared the same name as my sister, Sarojini. So, post marriage my mother changed it to Sangita. At the time of marriage, Sangita was 15 years old and I was 21. I never went against my mother's decision since I always felt her decisions to be very apt. In other words, today when I look back, I realised my mother's decision was perfect because whatever I have achieved till date, is due to the staunch and unflinching support from my wife, Sangita. Owing to her encouragement and timely reassurance, I have been able to achieve all my goals.

As per my mother's instruction, I reached Sholapur on the 25th and the marriage preparations began. The celebrations were stretched for over five days. The festivities were in the form of games, involving active participation not only by the relatives but also by the bridegroom and the bride. For sake of much fun and

laughter, relatives would insist on my bride's and my participation in the competitive games. The fun games were like concealing mine or Sangita's footwear and the winner would be rewarded or the loser would be penalised in a comical manner, asking me to chew on the tough viscera of the goat while singing and dancing continued through the day and night. Many nuptial ceremonies such as applying turmeric followed by bathing accompanied by light banter were carried out. Though I did not enjoy or was in favour of such celebrations, yet I could not protest against them since the occasion called for the same and there was no alternative. In our *Takari* community, dowry system is not followed. There is one tradition known as the '*sulla*'. The bride's maternal uncle is honoured by the bridegroom by bestowing him with Rupees 11 or 21 according to the bridegroom's status. The maternal uncle, in turn, adds some more money, as per his resources, to this '*sulla*' and gifts the same to the bride. Then, the bride's family gifts one and a quarter kilo each of jaggery, rice, split pulse, jawar, wheat and rice to the bridegroom and his family and offers lunch of '*Pithle*' -chickpea flour cooked with water and tempered with spices and '*Bhakri*' – traditional Indian flatbread made from different types of millets flour. After the ceremonies and feasting, as a mark of the end of the festivities, guests are offered spicy non vegetarian food. Thus, the marriage ceremony ends. Since Sangita was just 15 years old, she stayed with her parents for a year after our marriage and then came to Pune.

My mother was of the firm belief that 'education is the foundation of progress'. She always took great efforts to encourage and provide help for people around her to benefit from education and evolve so that families and in turn, society could prosper. My first cousin, Sindhu Jadhav was very studious and was in the seventh standard. Once when we visited her, we found she was studying by the poor, dim light of a tiny kerosene lamp. My mother was

upset at her condition and brought her over to our house in Pune, provided her the necessary help to complete her matriculation and then enrolled her for a nursing course at the Sasoon Hospital. She completed that course, married an accomplished Doctor from Sholapur Civil Hospital named Dr. Ashok Kamble. Post marriage, the couple set up a big hospital in Palghar. Her son and daughter - Praful and Rashmi, too became Doctors. Hence, when Sangita came to Pune to stay with us, we took a decision to continue her schooling. However, when she was in the ninth standard, she was pregnant and had to discontinue schooling. My mother wished to marry her own younger sister Pakkuamma to an educated young man named Sidram Jadhav but my grandfather was staunchly against that marriage. My mother stood by her, took a lot of efforts and married them off. She always strived to see that people obtain education and progress well in their lives. All her nieces and nephews are highly educated and therefore very well placed in their lives. Her sister Laxmi's son Dhananjay is Deputy Superintendent of Police in Nasik, daughter Rajashri is a Police Inspector, another son Sanjay is a Heart Specialist in Jahangir Hospital. Sushama was Professor in Garware College. Sanjivani became a staff nurse, Kalpana a teacher, Swarupa and Niranjan Sales Officers. Most of them opted for inter caste marriages. Thus my mother's efforts bore success. Her other sister, Yamuna from Ankalgi, had nine children. Her husband had almost abandoned the family. Yamuna became depressed and attempted suicide. My mother brought her to Pune and enrolled her in a training course to become *Gramsewika* - caretaker of a village. Her two daughters were very young - one was as young as six months old. My mother looked after them in our house. Today my Aunt Yamuna's grandchildren are highly educated and are working abroad. My mother supported hundreds of families in need, undertook their responsibility, helped the family members to be educated. In the process of doing so, many a times she had to

make numerous sacrifices but she did it willingly and selflessly. She became a godmother to many orphans of the Remand Home, helped them to get married and settle down in life. Thus, she was a virtual pillar of strength to the needy. Since my early childhood, I always found a steady flow of people in and out of the house.

My wife, Sangita (Sarojini) Jadhav has played a major role in my success. Her spontaneous acceptance of all the decisions I took, propelled me to undertake and achieve my goals of social service. Initially, when I started a school at our house, she had to provide lunch to all the students of the school. She carried out the chores very willingly and happily. Gradually the number rose to 27 and Sangita had to take care of the students as well as our five children [two daughters and three sons], my mother and myself. Earlier, when she was attending school herself, she used to manage all the work at home as well as cook for the school children and then attend her school. My mother and I always helped her as much as possible.



My Job

I post graduated in Arts in the year 1971 and decided to be a Professor. I was a past student of the Garware College of Arts and Science. I knew quite a few people there. Being one of the students of Principal Jamadagni, I approached him for a suitable job. He recognized me immediately as he said, 'Oh! You were my student. You may join from tomorrow.' Thus, the following day, I became a Professor with a remuneration on an hourly basis. I knew almost all the professors in the college. In my class, there were a few students who were my classmates but being habitual repeaters, they were still in the class and therefore those were the rowdy students in my class. On this note, my job as a professor began. Since the income from this assignment was not really sufficient, I found teaching jobs in two other private coaching classes - *Swadhyay* and *Jidnyasa*. I continued my teaching job for almost a year. Then I came across an advertisement for a job in one of the Kirloskar Companies. I went for the interview which went off very well. At the end they asked me a question, 'How much salary do you expect?' I humbly told them to evaluate my work first and then decide my salary. My

down to earth reply really impressed them and I was asked to join. I was in dire need of money and so, I decided to put in my very best efforts. I was appointed as a Marketing Officer in Kirloskar Company. My workplace was at Karve Road. Initially I used to commute on a bicycle from Mundhwa to Karve Road to reach the office by eight in the morning. After a few days I stopped using the bicycle and began commuting by a Bus or Rickshaw. Eventually, the company gave me vehicle, a Kinetic Luna-50cc moped

At Kirloskar Company, there was a Punching Card system for recording the attendance of the employees but I was the only employee who was exempted from this rule. I was in charge of four departments which comprised of Transport, Marketing, Printing and a few other jobs. I was being paid the highest remuneration of Rs.7000/- per month. Captain H. S. Bhagat was heading the company and was whole and sole. [He was pilot of the private plane owned by Mr. Shantanurao Kirloskar-the Chairman of all Kirloskar Companies.] I was very sincere, diligent and efficient in my job and Capt. Bhagat was very fond of me. I used to get an Ex-Gratia amount of Rs.300 for my efficiency. Though I used to put in very long hours of work every day yet I never asked or expected any form of extra payment for that. Capt. Bhagat was a frequent flyer to various foreign countries. Hence, the planning of his itinerary was also my responsibility. That time, neither mobile phones nor Google existed for getting travel desk information. Hence, I had to visit Gokhale Institute or Jaykar Library at Pune University and garner information about the countries he was scheduled to visit, the suitable hotels at each place of stay with the details of the locations and the distances, conveyance arrangements for each scheduled place of work and meetings venue. I used to map out the entire itinerary of his tour very meticulously. Thus, just as his

trust in my ability augmented, so also my remuneration went on an upward spiral. I too, learnt a lot from him. I will always cherish working with Capt. Bhagat because he was very considerate towards me. I worked as a Marketing Officer in Kirloskar Company during the period, 1972 to 1975. So, when I quit from my well-paying job, my wife Sangita was worried about the finances for running the household. During that period, the workload as the Chairman of Society was also quite demanding. Yet, I decided to resign from such a sound, remunerative, satisfactory job with Kirloskar Company. My mother was helping us by remitting Rs. 150/- every month but that was not really sufficient. Sangita was of the strong opinion that I ought to continue working to obtain a steady and sufficient flow of income. But, somehow, I did not wish to be stuck in a 'duty-bound' life. I wished to do something unique and creative. I was confident that we would not starve. Mother had a job, my sister was also working in Certified School of Shiroor as Nurse and did not have any children of her own. Both of them were helping us to run the house.

During 1975 to 1980, I had no job. I was doing some odd jobs like marketing and managing to keep the home hearth working. My friend Samarnath and I had set up a small factory in Mahadevnagar, Manjri to make paper tubes. The business was very good but, suddenly the prices of paper shot up. During that period, the only source for paper suitable to make tubes was from a mill at Ballarpur. The supplies were short and the price had shot up considerably. This affected our business very badly. Consequently, we took a decision and shut down the factory. While Samarnath found another job, I was jobless. My mindset did not permit me to work for a living rather it was my altruistic spirit that ardently beckoned me.



Educational Institutes for Nomadic and 'Wimukt' (De-notified) tribes.



After participating in the stirs and agitations for the well-being of the nomadic and 'wimukt' tribes for few years, a feeling crept over me that only meetings, speeches, rallies and marches were not sufficient, and that was not really the correct manner for their progress and development. Instead, something fundamental and constructive on a sustainable note was the need of the hour. Hence, I turned towards education. The need to sustain themselves compelled them to move from place to place in search of work and that in turn deprived them of having a

permanent home and also education. Due to deprivation of a stable life and lack of education, the children were ensnared into immoral activities like thefts, fighting, pick-pocketing and drinking. This became a way of life for them. Going ahead, they were adopting the businesses which their ancestors were doing. The only way to bring a radical transformation and to make them eligible to be a part of the main stream of the society was education. I assembled all the nomadic folks from Mundhwa together. I undertook herculean efforts to discuss with them patiently and convince them of the importance and the need of education. It resulted in establishing two schools in the neighbourhood of Mundhwa and I persuaded them to send their children to my new schools known as '*Balwadi*'. But, I was not really at ease because I always felt that after school hours, these children would resume their immoral activities. So I founded an '*Ashram Shala*' a Residential School that took care of all their needs of lodging and uninterruptedly helped them to pursue their education up to tenth standard. As of today, hundreds of children are being benefitted by this venture and reaching to Tenth standard. In the year 1985 I founded '*Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha*' (Educational Institute for Nomad and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes.) This Institute provides knowledge, skills and guidance to make children self-sufficient. This Institute also runs centres for women for learning sewing and tailoring and also imparts vocational guidance to unemployed women. This centre is recognized by the Government and it used to receive grant from the Department of Social Welfare. For a few years, this centre was being run at my house and was named as '*Kamala Nehru Shivan Kendra*' (Tailoring centre).

It could accommodate a little more than twenty women at a time and these women were able to learn tailoring within a year, set up their own businesses, earn money and support their families.

Many women took advantage of this facility. Today this 'Educational Institute for Nomad and 'Wimukt' (De-notified) tribes' has a big set up in Wagholi and houses 450 children, orphans, deaf and mute, physically and mentally challenged children from the nomadic and de-notified communities. My motive behind the foundation of this Institute was to provide means to the nomads who have been wandering along with their families for the livelihood for hundreds of years so that they can settle down at one place and lead a simple and honourable life. I very well knew that the only means of uplifting them is through 'education'. So I founded this educational institute. Following schools and centres are managed and are part of the Institute :

1. Primary Residential School, Wagholi, Pune.
2. Balgruh - Children Centre, Wagholi, Pune.
3. Shree School for Deaf and Mute, Wagholi, Pune.
4. Madhyamik Ashram School, Bakori Road, Wagholi, Pune.
5. Centre for counselling and guiding physically challenged children, Wagholi, Pune.
6. Residential School for Mentally Challenged children, Pabal, Shiroor Taluka, Pune District.
7. Residential School for deaf and mute, Wadegavan, Parner Taluka, Pune District.
8. Training Centre for Self Employment, Pabal, Shiroor Taluka, Pune District.
9. Centre for counselling and guiding physically challenged children, Pabal, Shiroor Taluka, Pune District

Kamala Nehru Training Centre for Tailoring - Mundhwa.



'Kamala Nehru Training Centre' was launched in Mundhwa, solely with the intention of making the women of the Nomadic and *Wimukt* (De-notified) communities self-sufficient by creating self-employment for them. The women of these communities had to resort to begging, performing street acrobatic activities or prostitution to feed and support their families while the man of the house sat idle at home drinking or smoking cannabis. To relieve them from such squalid and disgraceful life, it was decided to bring them together and provide training in tailoring so that they would be able to stitch clothes, earn money and manage their homes. We constantly approached and rigorously followed up with the Department of Social Welfare of Government of Maharashtra for help and launched this Centre. Consequently, around 20 to 25 women were able to take advantage of this training annually.

Tailoring Class for Nomad Women.



By now hundreds of women trained at this Centre are competently running their own businesses, earning money and maintaining their families. Every woman trained in this Centre has become a financial backbone of at least one family from the Nomadic community. Establishing such a centre was not an easy job, but I accepted it as a challenge, put in all possible efforts to make the women of my community self-sufficient. Department of Social Welfare was kind enough to distribute hundreds of tailoring machines free of charge. This immensely helped to set up independent businesses and thus help the women to earn money to run their houses.

Balwadi (Kindergarten) to Ashram Shala (Residential School)

In the building complex of Educational Institute for Nomad and 'Wimukt' (De-notified) tribes, children get education from Kindergarten to SSC (Matriculation). In the beginning, when we established the *Balwadi*, (Kindergarten), we used to bring the orphans, nomad children from the streets to our school. Most of the times they used to be naked. Some used to wear either only a pant or only a shirt. As they used to get their clothes as alms from other houses, mostly boys used to wear torn, patched up pants and the girls ill-fitting maxis. Now-a-days even though the situation is slightly better yet, very often these children have not bathed for days on end and many suffer from various skin ailments as also from malnutrition. So, in our school they are bathed, provided with a fresh set of clothes and they also undergo a thorough medical check up. This school has now expanded and progressed very well. I see a new world in the eyes of each child of this school. Every child has his own long story behind him, like a novel. Parents of some of the children of my school ask me, 'my child will get education here in this school but will he get a job?' What I really do not understand is, just because a job cannot be guaranteed, should the child be deprived of education? My view is he should not. It is imperative that children must be educated and all of us must strive to make education easily available for them. Otherwise there is every possibility that parents from the nomadic communities will not enrol their children in schools and alternately, they will go back to their old, immoral, depraved activities. In other words, children will resort to thefts, pickpocketing or some sort of criminal activity. So they must educate and become self-sufficient. With this sole intention, we run this school and offer this social service.



Maha Sadhwi Preetisudhaji visiting our school

In our school we do not offer only education, but cultivate the principle of equality. In order to inculcate moral values, we have adopted the holy hymn called '*Navkar Mantra*' from the Jain philosophy, which teaches virtues such as abiding respect towards the Guru and the seniors. This mantra is recited daily by all students. In order to comprehend the importance of labour and hard work, we ask them to clean the entire school every morning. We strive to cultivate the virtues of self-sufficiency, patriotism and many more.

During the early days of this school, I used to approach people for clothes and food grains for my children. I used to knock on people's doors for books, notebooks, writing material required for the school and also construction raw material like wood, tin sheets, bricks, cement, sand etc. Thus, initially the school was set up in this manner. Many a times, people spontaneously helped in a very big way. But the biggest support was offered by my friend Anil Awachat. He bestowed on me the formula of life. The school began in a tin shelter. There were only two rooms for classes

which were insufficient for the students. We were in dire need of at least two more rooms and a few more tin sheets. So I approached my dear friend, Anil Awachat for financial help. He introduced me to a donor and that person gave us ten thousand rupees in cash! It was my very first experience to handle such a lot of money! That donation was sufficient to construct two more rooms and to obtain the necessary tin sheets. One of the earliest supporters was Dr. Baba Adhav, who moulded me, inculcated appropriate values and also helped me to participate in agitations. Baba holds an extremely important niche in my life.



Dr. Baba Adhav, Laxman Mane and the Mundhwa agitation.

In a very true sense, my social work began under the aegis of Dr. Baba Adhav. I owe all my success in this field to him and my associates in various agitations. Dr. Adhav has been my Guru, mentor and also my cherished associate. I entered this field only because of him and then got more interested and involved in various agitations due to my friends like Laxman Mane, Vilas Wadekar, Moorchand Bhaat. During various agitations against injustice and atrocities, very many, different set of activists and workers helped and stood by me. For instance, when Umaji Naik's memorial at Bhiwari was demolished, Sambhaji Khomane, Sharda Khomane, Chandu Chavan and myself agitated with all our might and in a very persuasive manner and settled the issue. While on the issue of women's rights, Urmila Pawar zealously supported me. Many a times, Rekha Deshmukh helped me by collecting clothes from the students of Huzurpaga Girls' School every year. In the year 1984, we organised a very big stir for the land in Mundhwa Settlement. In the year 1952, Government had allotted 225 acres of land in Mundhwa (Survey nos.9 to 14) for the sustenance of the resident members of our

community. In order to cultivate this land, '*Sarvodaya Samudai Sahakari Shetee Society*' - Sarvoday Co-operative Farming Society - was established and the land was entrusted to this Society.



**Mahsool Mantri with M. P. Ramkrishna More,
Dr. Baba Adhav and Shivalal Jadhav.**

Till 1971, this land remained in the name of the Society but, later the Government terminated this society, without notice. At that time about hundreds of families of Pardhi, Kanjarbhat, Kaikadi, Takari and Pamlor communities resided there and were engaged in cultivating it. In spite of that, Pune Municipal Corporation took an irrefutable decision of acquiring that land and relocating the barns of the animals from the main city to that land. The concerned bureaucrats were personally contacted and suitable applications to reconsider the decision were also submitted. A senior journalist, Arun Khore wrote an article in Pune's most popular daily newspaper, *Sakal*. But the Corporation did not pay any heed. So demonstrations and hunger strikes were held in front

of the offices of the Corporation and also before the office of the District Administration. Certain leaders and corporators were against us. They looked upon these residents as vagabonds who are more interested in begging than tilling the land. Besides, they did not wish to be in proximity with such families whom they looked upon as the 'scum' of the society. We had to face stiff opposition from around 75 corporators. We also got the news that, these corporators had illegally allotted parcels of this land to their relatives and friends! Pune Corporation passed a bill that in order to maintain the cleanliness of the city, barns in the city to be relocated to the land at Mundhwa Settlement. It became certain that the Corporation was going to acquire the land. I met Dr. Baba Adhav and sought his advice. He asked me to collect the documentary evidence to show that the people in question were cultivating that land.

The administration of the Society and the land was looked after by Mr. Hiremath who maintained all the records and was also the custodian of the legal documents. But post demise, the documents still remained in his custody. Around that time about 50 people were carrying out farming and they were also involved in brewing of illicit liquor. I called on these people of Kaikadi, Kanjarbhat and Pardhi communities and asked them for the documents. In some huts, I found some pretty old, yellow papers tucked in the wooden framework of the roof but these were the receipts of the payment of fines for pilfering the river water.

There is a river that flows adjacent to the land, but the people here were prohibited from the use of that river water. The Corporation did not even provide any facility for the use of the river water for the land. So people used to pilfer the river water at night or get it by rupturing the embankments of the other farmers. This 'water theft' was a regular issue. Many a times the Revenue Officers used

to conduct a raid. They used to interrogate these people as to how they cultivated the land without water. People had to confess that they illegally utilized the river water. Thus, they were penalized, asked to pay around Rupees Fifty or Hundred and receipts were issued for that. The old yellow papers were those receipts pertaining to the payment of the fines. I also had some old documents with me. I collected all these and took them to Dr. Baba Adhav. He directed me to a lawyer named Mr. Desai. Mr. Desai not only took initiative but formed an army of lawyers. Around that time, all the Socialist members used to congregate at Mr. Diwekar's house for meetings and discussions. This issue assumed a top priority for discussion. Laxman Mane was held in high esteem by all of us and was an author of his autobiography 'Upra' ('Outsider'). He was awarded the scholarship from the prestigious Ford Foundation and he became our trail blazer. The members of this group began to visit the Settlement more often. Vilas Wadekar and Moorchand Bhaat were active in their Pimpri Chinchwad area. Being the Chairman of the PCMT, Moorchand could easily assemble a large group of his community members. Laxman Lokhande was the Corporator of Bharatiya Janata Paksha - a political party known as BJP. Members of the Waidee Makadwala community from Chatushrungi area too, joined our agitation. Nomads from Hadapsar area were led by Shidoo Shinde. Member of Parliament Vitthal Tupe also helped us a lot.

During the discussions on this subject in one of our meetings, Dr. Adhav himself addressed the meeting. He said, 'The Government allotted this land to the nomads for cultivation and as a source of their livelihood. Now, Pune Corporation is snatching away the same land from them. It is undoubtedly, an injustice. We have decided to help Shivalal Jadhav in his fight against this injustice.' He then asked me to meet and unite all those who were going to lose their land. He promised full support of his group. I began to

meet these people every week and patiently explained in detail the matter but their response was very poor.

So one day, I invited Baba Adhav to accompany me to meet these people. Most of those who attended the meeting arrived in an inebriated condition. Not just the menfolk but even womenfolk were in an inebriated condition. As I stood before them to introduce Dr. Baba Adhav, an octogenarian from the Kaikadi community, named Gangaram Jadhav, stood up to question me. He shouted, 'Shivalal, who is this man - Baba Adhav - you have brought to day?' This old man had been a daily visitor to the Collector's office. He would clutch a bunch of papers of his land and visit the Collector's Office. En route to the Collector's office he used to beg for food, then shower curses and abuses on the officer on duty, summon him and order him to return the land back to him. The 'on duty guard' used to drive him away. This stupid 'ritual' continued for 15 to 20 years. It took me 2 to 3 years to placate him. In this meeting, this same octogenarian stood up to grill me, I pacified him. Baba silently noticed my persuasive efforts. Even the women in the audience were belligerent. Holding aloft their infants in hands they would threaten to harm them by striking them on the ground. Thus, in that meeting Baba realized the gravity of the issue and the challenges that lay before me.

There was a leader of the Pardhi community, named Bhimsen. Some of his opponents killed him out of sheer resentment for his popularity. Bhimsen's supporters immediately took revenge by murdering one person from the community. People were totally uncivilized and savage. Their talks and deeds were very erratic and volatile. They would seal their colonies and outsiders were debarred from entry.



Shri. Kaikadi Maharaj, Laxman Mane and Shivalal Jadhav.

Entry after six in the evening was not permitted to me too. They would clamp down an 'unannounced curfew'! Since I was educated, I was a suspect in their eyes. They used to think that on the strength of my education, I would manipulate them and get their land registered in my name. They were, therefore, against me. Even the police were afraid of them and hesitated to enter their colonies. Laxman Mane, Sada Dumbre, Arun Khore, Vilas Wadekar, Moorchand Bhat were regular members of those meetings. I used to conscientiously follow Baba's advice, conduct weekly meetings and brief him accordingly. Since different communities were at loggerheads with each other, I used to conduct separate meetings. This went on for two to three years. One day, I just asked Baba to show me some way out of it! He gave me a weird suggestion. He asked me to reach the Pune Corporation along with as many as donkeys, pigs, dogs, buffalos and sheep that was available along with maximum number of land owners i. e. men and women and their children. This unique

crowd was taken in a procession to the destination. All the animals were then set free inside the Corporation building and very rapidly they reached all the floors, created a ruckus and made the place filthy with their excrements. The staff in the Corporation was taken unawares and began fleeing as they were thunderstruck to see a huge herd of varied animals and a melange of over 1000 persons. It was an innovative demonstration. Women outnumbered the men and they were more aggressive. Laxman Mane, Vilas Wadekar, Moorchand Bhaat, Arun Khore, Laxman Lokhande also brought with them many demonstrators and they in turns, stormed the Corporation. The starting point was Mundhwa but some people from Pune city area also joined. When the crowd reached Council Hall, Baba Adhav personally joined us. The women danced and sang. Traditionally attired women from the Laman tribe not only danced but also sang the *Powadas*-motivating ballads describing the historical events. There was an area called '*sadesatra nali*'. Parshuram Bhosle brought men from that area who played a typical string instrument called '*Tuntune*'. Saraswati Bhandwalkar served '*Bhel*'- a savoury, spicy snack of puffed rice, onions, potatoes and a tangy tamarind sauce. Someone arranged for that *Bhel* to be distributed in the crowd. Baba himself brought *Bhakris* - flatbread of jowar, a staple diet of the poor, for the demonstrators and distributed them. Finally the officers from the Corporation came down, met us and assured us that the decision would be withdrawn and the demonstration was terminated. Had the officers not given us the assurance then the *Hamal Panchayat*, an association of porters, offered us their participation in the demonstration the following day. Fortunately, we achieved our goal and the decision was withdrawn.

During the agitation period, one day, at the crack of dawn, between four and five in the morning, the police reached the colony with a couple of wireless vans and three tempos. All the

residents were asleep and completely unaware of what's in store for them. The Police mercilessly beat up around twenty one men from the Pardhi community and arrested them. The police then assaulted the womenfolk by tearing off the sarees from their bodies and used those sarees to truss the legs of the arrested men before throwing them in the tempos. Nobody knew where the men were taken. The barely dressed women covered with blood, as the police had left them in that condition, arrived at my house. They pitifully cried and lamented as they narrated the police atrocities. I immediately arranged for sarees - some from my house and some from our neighbouring houses. I placated them and assured them that I would bring their men back. At that time I had a Luna scooter. I immediately took it and went to Baba Adhav. He immediately accompanied me. There were about forty ladies. He reviewed the situation and we went to the Police Station to lodge a complaint. One Mr. Poman was the officer of that Police Station. He told us that he was unable to help them out and even refused to record our complaint. But we compelled him to do so. Mr. Poman spoke in an extremely rude manner even with Baba Adhav. Next day, the members of the *Hamal Panchyat* distributed new sarees to the affected women. Neelamtai Gorhe's help in this action was significant. That time the festival of *Rakshabandhan* was drawing to a close, where a sister ties a silk thread to her brother's wrist as a bond of love and in return, the brother assures the sister of lifelong protection. So the members of the Hamal Panchayat conferred a gift of sarees as protection to these women. This philanthropic act garnered a lot of appreciation and publicity in the news media. After four days we got the information that those men were taken to Lonikand Police Station. Police had brutally beaten them, inflicted burns with searing hot rods on their private body parts, and had also tortured them with electrical shocks. This was an indication of the deep rooted hatred the other people harboured towards the members of

our nomad community. Society at large did not want nomads in the main stream of the society.

We repeatedly approached Sharad Pawar during his tenure as the Chief Minister of Maharashtra with our problems. One day he asked us to meet him with all the relevant papers related to our demands. At that time, Shreeniwas Patil was Collector of Pune District. He was going to assign the parcels of land to the people. We obtained considerable signatures on our application. I talked to the people and garnered their views with regard to the method of allocation of land. They expressed their views that the land must be allocated as per a caste wise group. For instance, land of all people of Kanjarbhat community followed by the Kaikadees community, then the Pardhis and the Takaris. Accordingly, I conducted meetings and obtained their thumb impressions on the proposals and submitted the same to the Collector. Accordingly, the concerned department formulated the 7/12 extracts of the land.

In the year 1987, Laxman Mane also arranged a convention in Satara, where some people got 7/12 extracts of lands but they continued to quarrel because some were wrongly allocated grazing land while they lost their fertile land. These concerned people too, harassed me for 5-6 years. Then they met the District Collector and also the Chief Minister Sharad Pawar to elucidate on the mistakes and submitted relevant statements but the outcome did not materialize as per their expectations. Hence they held me responsible for all their problems. I even received threats. Then I summoned them for a meeting and told them, 'If you wish to kill me, do it just now. Whatever I have done, I have done based on our meeting. I asked you before taking any steps or actions. Had I not done what I have done, you would not have even got what you have got today! Then what would you have done? If you feel your problem will get solved by killing me, do so.' After the

speech, I went and waited at the house of one member of Pardhi community. A few young and elderly people provided me with protection. But no one came to harm me. After that confrontation, I was never troubled. However, quarrels amongst them still continue.

During the early period, I had divided our school at two places, at my house and at the farm. Deaf and mute children lived at my house and the normal children stayed at our farm. The school was not bestowed with the Government grant at that time, hence, I had to go from door to door to collect food grains for the children. One day it so happened that there was not enough food for dinner. I went to few more people but did not get help. I wondered what to do! I approached Baba Adhav and in the evening, I went to his house and told him the grim situation. He helped me and asked me to visit the Hamal Panchayat's office the following day. He had arranged for grains worth three thousand five hundred rupees. This was in the year 1987. Later on too, he has helped me out many a times.

Shankar Endoo Lokhande, Aane, Junnar.

It must be around year 1985. Our Socialist party members used to meet at the Ex-Mayor Shantaram Diwekar's house. Baba Adhav, Anna Joshi, Bhai Vaidya, Anil Awachat, Anita Awachat, Laxman Mane and I used to meet together. Though S. M. Joshi was ailing at that time yet he would make it a point to attend the meeting. One day the news came that the police had arrested a social worker from the Vaidoo community from the town, Aane. People of Vaidoo community were moderate drinkers. They used to collect medicinal herbs such as *Hirda*-Myrobalan and *Behda*-Terminalia Bellirica in the areas around Bhimashankar and used to sell them to the Ayurvedic Doctors from Pune. One Shankar Endoo Lokhande from the same Vaidoo community was a major

collector and a prominent vendor. Police used to extort commissions from such illegal sales, so perhaps he must have refused to pay the extortion money to the police and hence, they arrested him and he died of police atrocities. But the police declared him dead owing to the suicide committed by him by hanging himself to the tap. His body bore the marks of brutal assault. We read about this incident in the newspaper and Baba Aadhav asked me to get more information on this matter. He himself declared one day's hunger strike against the atrocity of police. Laxman Lokhande, corporator of Bhartiya Janata Party, Anna Joshi's associate and I went to the police station. Sada Dumbre and Arun Khore accompanied us. Shankar belonged to the Vaidoo community. We visited the Police Station at Junnar and asked for the resignation of the concerned Police Officer. He was dismissed. Many such incidences used to occur.

Rally of Nomad and Wimukt (De-notofied) communities (1988)

A rally of the Nomad and Wimukt community was organized in Pune. Minister of Revenue of Maharashtra State and the Guardian Minister of Pune District Shree Madan Bafna attended the rally. Honourable M.P. Prof. Ramkrishna More presided over the rally. Honourable Chairman of Pune District Council Rameshchandra Dhamale, Baba Adhav, Shivalal Jadhav and Laxman Mane- Chairman of the Association of the Nomad and Wimukt Communities and author of the popular book '*Upra*' were also present for the rally.

The Social Circumstances penned into words

During that time Anil Awachat, Laxman Mane, Vilas Wadekar, Moorchand Bhaat, Shidoo Shinde, Ramnath Chavan, Narendra Dabholkar, Balkrishna Renke used to call on me regularly.

Ramnath Chavan visited me every Sunday to discuss and garner information on the world of nomads. Many a times we would visit the temporary huts erected by the nomads to interact with them and study about their traditions and customs. Ramnath would also patiently listen to their agonies and sufferings and used to jot down a few notes. Thus, based on his understanding, observations and the information, he authored many books about the nomads. Like Ramnath, a few others too approached me and then authored some books. All these authors have made a specific mention in their books regarding my help. Had they visited the nomads on their own, no one would have permitted them or spoken to them at length because basically, the nomads are suspicious and hesitant of strangers. They felt that such people divulged the information to the police or to the Government Authorities which meant trouble for them but, they trusted me and had faith in me since I was their 'Mass Leader'. Hence, with me around, they harboured no apprehension as they spoke about their personal lives, deaths, marriage process, divorce or even the aftermath. They are basically pure at heart. Peoples' ill treatment made them suspicious. They don't allow any stranger in their slums. Thus, through the books written by my friends, the true saga of the nomads was unveiled before the world.

Progress in Educational Work :

Balwadi-kindergarten functioned efficiently at Mundhwa. During the period, 1982/83, my mother was on the path of retirement from her services. Her long career span of 35-40 years as a caretaker of the children and also as a cook at the Remand Home had forged such a bond with those children that it was difficult for her to retire and be away from them. She always pondered as to why the poor children of our nomad community, who resorted to begging on the streets or even stealing, live like

parasites? Why couldn't they be a part of the main stream of the society? In answer to such questions, in the year 1985, we gave refuge at our home to nine orphans including deaf and mute children. I collected food for them and tin sheets and wood to build a shelter for them. There was a Grocery Shop in Mundhwa, run by Motisheth Kaswa. His two sons, Ashok and Vinod and my wife were classmates. Since 1955, the year we arrived in Mundhwa, we were regular customers of Motisheth Kaswa's Grocery Shop (we continue to be his customers even today). Our families are very close-knit. Motisheth treats my wife Sangita as his own daughter and his sons, Sangita's classmates, treat her as their sister. There was one more, special reason Motisheth had admiration for me - my proficiency in calculations!

Finally, my mother retired in 1985. Our small school at home was well established. However, we were not conversant with the rules and regulations of running a school and our well-wishers too, cautioned us. I was fortunate in getting suitable help and guidance from the right persons. The Secretary of Department of Social Welfare Mr. Harshe, and officers Belwadikar and Jadhav helped me in the establishment and registration of the Institute. Accordingly, on 14th January 1985 'Educational Institute for Nomad and 'Wimukt' (De-notified) tribes' was registered and our work was 'institutionalized' - of course for the orphans.

Thus, the school was registered but it did not have the Government Recognition. People cautioned us that nurturing orphans at home needs an approval and authorization from the Ministry of Social Welfare. Even when we approached the donors for aid, they would primarily inquire if the school possessed the necessary Government Recognition. In absence of the same, they would desist from granting any aid but in turn, they would frighten us about the possibility of some legal action against us. In

spite of all such odds against us, our '*Balwadi*'-Kindergarten ran smoothly. Every year, the number of children grew steadily, resulting in shortage of space. So I began to transfer the children to the Residential Schools in places like Baramati, Daund, Sonwadi, Lamboti near Sholapur. Whenever I came across a lad who wished to learn but couldn't do so on account of poverty, then, I would meet his parents to assure them regarding the importance of education and personally undertake the responsibility to enrol him at a suitable Residential School. This pertains to the year 1983. A person from Wadari community had started a Residential School in Mamurdi, near Dehu Road. I had enrolled some boys in that school. I had visited Mamurdi for some work, so I dropped in at the school to meet those boys. When I reached the school at noon, it was empty. I was informed that all the boys had gone for a dip at a nearby brook. I went to the brook and saw the boys bathing in very murky, filthy water. I ordered them out from that place. Then I inquired about their lunch, they informed me that they would have it immediately after returning to school. I accompanied them to the school. A man clad in white clothes waited for them. He introduced himself as the '*Sarpanch*' - Head of the village council. He told me that the School Administrator failed to provide food for the children, so he made sure that the boys do not remain hungry. Hence, he would supply some food for them, like bananas, *bhel* etc.. That day he had brought *Bhel* for them. I was extremely annoyed. Had some parent of one of those boys accompanied me that day and witnessed the grim reality of sheer negligence and carelessness, they would have held me responsible and in no way I would have been able to exonerate myself from that blame. This grim reality brought to fore my sense of intolerance for injustice and I reached the Social Welfare Department. Mr. Jagtap was in charge and I filed my complaint with him. He told me that they had sent many letters to the School Administrators, but the pleas fell on deaf

ears. It was only at the time of collecting the Grant, the two brothers would arrive and squabble. So I asked, 'Why don't you grant recognition to my school? I have been running it so very efficiently and I have enough space for the school at Mundhwa.' Upon which he revealed the fact that for permission to be obtained for Government Recognition required a close proximity with the Minister. Coincidentally, Minister of Social Welfare, Shivajirao Moghe was scheduled to arrive at Pune for some function. I found out that he would be arriving by the Deccan Queen Train. I immediately gathered a group of 20-25 of my associates and went to Pune station. As soon as he arrived, a few of my associates and I attempted to reach out to him but the police prevented us. I pleaded with the police and somehow reached the Minister. I told him about the poor condition of the school in Mamurdi and requested him to close that school and issue recognition to my school. He listened to me and then explained that these issues need to be handled through proper channels. He asked me to meet him for discussions on Wednesday at the Ministry. I rejected his proposal and insisted on immediate decision. He, once again, attempted to explain the documentation process of submitting an application and then obtaining the requisite approval. He asked me not to create unnecessary commotion and to avoid police interference. Finally, I retreated but my associates indulged in some derogatory slogans against the Minister. I refrained them from shouting slogans and left.

The following Wednesday, I decided to visit Mumbai to meet the Minister. Since I did not have enough money, I borrowed and managed to reach Mumbai. I went to Mr. Moghe's cabin, greeted him and introduced myself. He recalled our meeting at Pune Station. Then he tried to advise me that running a school was not an easy task. He mentioned that one needs sufficient space, all-encompassing experience of social work and most importantly a

reference letter from the designated M.P. from one's area and also a sound financial backup. I stated the facts, 'I already have 100 children in my school, they are all from nomad communities. I have done my Masters in Economics and Politics and doing my PhD as of now. I have an in depth knowledge about the history of these nomad communities which is unique. I love teaching and above all, it is not business but the goal in my life.' Since I was talking in a very passionate manner, he phoned the Social Welfare Officer, Mr. Jagtap in Pune and told him about me in these words : 'Mr. Shivalal Jadhav, a social activist is running a school and he needs recognition from us. He is not like the other so called leaders and is very well educated.' He asked me to meet Mr. Jagtap for further procedures. With that assurance I left the Ministry. Those days I did not have a telephone in my house. So Mr. Jagtap resorted to call the nearest police station and a policeman came to our house to deliver Mr. Jagtap's message. He had summoned me to his office. I slung my long cloth bag on my shoulders and went. As I met Mr. Jagtap, he berated me, 'Are you Shivalal Jadhav? Why did you meet the Minister directly? Why did you not meet me? Do you think yourself to be very clever?' Then he asked me, 'What do you want?' I pointed out the worst condition of the school in Mamurdi and requested him to accompany me and have a look. He ignored my request and asked, 'What do you want now?' 'Government's official recognition for my school.' I said.

He pointed out that one needs to make an application for the same and proceeded to inform me about the list of requirements like, one needs to own a place, a building with appropriate bathrooms and restrooms. Then he asked me, 'Out of this list, what do you have today?' I replied, 'I have the land, I can show the school space as rented.' Then I assured him to do whatever was necessary. I submitted an application in January, showed the

school space in Mundhwa as rented. At that time the permission was granted in stages – initially for the first class followed by the next. Finally, my application was approved in November 1987 and the order was officially issued to start the school from June 1987. I had four rooms in Mahadevnagar, where Samarnath Dube and I used to run the factory. Our school was established there. My mother was extremely happy to know that our school was recognized by the Government. The first suggestion she made was to appoint a good cook! (She was in Sholapur at that time.) She was worried about feeding the children. The recognition allowed us to appoint a teacher and a peon cum guard. We appointed Raju Shinde, a young boy of 18 as peon. My mother had brought this boy after his release from Remand Home when he was 12 years old and had given him shelter. Thus, two school employees were in place. Their monthly salaries were Rs. 430 for the teacher and Rs. 120 for the peon. Till we established Standard Four, we had only two employees. Later, for a good cook, we appointed Raju Shinde's wife! Thus, our school went on an upward growth.

The Pune Police found a girl at the Pune Railway Station. She was from Hyderabad, staying in the vicinity of Warangul Railway Station. Her name was Meghmala. She was admitted to the Child Reformatory. At this institution, a court exists which decides the child's destination either to an Orphanage or to a Residential School, followed by a suitable legal procedure. Such a court and a Child Welfare Committee, sometimes referred to as Juvenile Court, exists in each District. This committee comprises of a panel of five persons who take the appropriate decision. Whenever the police find children wandering alone, they admit them to one such Reformatory. The law permits these children to stay at the Residential Schools only up to age of eighteen after which they are, once again, presented before the Child Welfare

Committee. Sometimes the court asks the schools like ours to retain those eighteen years old children or at times, they are sent to work in the prisons for which the Government provides them with meagre monetary help. I am always on the lookout for such children to bring them to my School.

I had retained two hours in the evening from seven to nine p.m. to search for such lonely, abandoned or orphan children at the Railway Stations and Bus depots. Whenever I spotted children wandering alone, I would talk to them, seek information about their parents. In case they were orphans, I would take them to the nearest Police Station, meet the officers and provide them with the required information and take the child's statement about his daily activities etcetera. They would later allow me to take the children to my school. This work created considerable enemies for me and I used to get threatened by the shady characters who used these children for their illicit activities. Persons from the Pardhi community generally sell balloons, lemon and chillies on Saturdays and on full moon and no moon days. They would employ these children to sell their wares in return for the meagre food. So, with the shelter offered to them at my school, the Pardhis would be deprived of cheap labour. Hence they would issue threats to us. They were hand in glove with the police for their shady dealings. Each work area of theirs was overseen by a local leader referred to as a 'Dada' who would abuse and threaten me : 'Release them, else, we will not leave you!' They would question me, 'What are they going to get from the education? Are you going to provide them with jobs?' I used to seek help from certain diligent, honest and sincere police officers. Mr. Ashok Ghiwre was one such police officer who would always help us out.

Mr. Manikrao Gaikwad from Dapodi, was a senior activist from our community. His son was active in Politics and his daughter-

in-law was a Corporator. Owing to a political discord, the Police arrested Manikrao's son and brutally beat him up. Some people from Dapodi, belonging to our Takari community telephoned me about the incident. I immediately met Mr. Ghiwre, provided him the factual information and the integrity of Manikrao's son. He immediately intervened and stopped the police brutality. I really could not thank him enough but when he was awarded with President's Police Medal in 2014, we cordially invited him to our school and honoured him at a function. His kindness is really unforgettable.

The children admitted to our orphanage are mostly unknown to us. We know neither their caste nor religion. When I established the school in our house at Mundhwa, initially there were nine children and gradually the number grew to 27. So, I submitted an application to the authorities for the Government Recognition of that school. It was rejected by the Education Commissioner on the grounds that my name appeared in the space for 'Father's name' in case of many children. In reality, these children were from the poor Kolhati community. The women from this community would earn money by entertaining people by singing and dancing at public and private shows. Thus, some of them used to be a victim of the lascivious gaze of the village head or some wealthy persons. The outcome of such libidinous, carnal relationships would result in the birth of unwanted children. The biological fathers would use their clout to ensure total anonymity even while enrolling such children at school, so much so, that at times even the School Authorities would receive threats. Hence, for such children only a mother existed but no father! Hence, I resorted to providing my name as the 'father' of such orphans. The Commissioner summoned me to his office, flung the file at me and asked me, 'Do you deceive the Government with such erroneous information and attempt to get recognition?' I patiently

heard him out and quietly told him 'Sir, I am the father to these twenty one children only on paper, not in reality. These children belong to the Kolhati community. Their mothers exist but not their fathers. The reality is, it is not possible to find out their fathers. If you so wish, then, I can bring the women to your office and you may personally question them and hear the truth. Later, you may penalize me if you find me guilty.' The Commissioner did ask me to come with their mothers. I explained the entire situation to those mothers. They readily agreed to meet the Commissioner. So, on the chosen day as usual, they dressed up in their stage attires with full garish make up. Being saucy, attractive and seasoned stage performers, they were neither shy nor timid. Thus, 18 to 20 sassily dressed women brazenly approached the Commissioner's office as the people around gawked at them. Before the peon at the door could question them, one of them impudently kicked the door open and entered. The Commissioner was aghast and taken aback as they began ranting and raving about the Commissioner's whereabouts. I followed them just in time. He surmised the entire situation and directed me to take them away. I brought them out and ordered them to sit quietly. The Commissioner quietly asked me to write the mother's name in place of father's name for the children. Then he signed and approved our application.

In the year 1987, I established a Residential School at our farm. The deaf and mute children were kept at my house while the other children were kept in a tin shed built on the grazing land about three kilometres away from my house. The Residential School too, received the necessary Government Grant. Many officials had extended a helping hand for the establishment of this school. Prominent amongst them was Mr. Harishchandra Tikekar, District Social Welfare Officer. Hailing from Otoor and being a like-minded person with a strong socialistic bend along with a

history of participation in various agitations and rallies. My mentors and friends, Dr. Anil Awachat and Sada Dumbre too, hailed from Otoor. Thus, these factors aided in forging the friendship. In my school, the number of deaf and mute children was on a steady rise, consequently, there arose a need for a trained teacher to teach them. In the year 1992, a widow named Kanchan Kamble was my neighbour. She had recently lost her husband and her children were young, so one day she approached me for a suitable job. Instead of working as a servant at some place, I advised her to do a year's Diploma course in Teaching the Deaf and mute children and become a teacher. She readily agreed to that. At that time Ramdas Athavale was the Minister of Social Welfare. We knew each other well since our days of participation in various agitations. I met him and requested him to grant the necessary recognition for the School for the Deaf and Mute. So, in June 1992, school was granted recognition and the Grant was also sanctioned. As per the rules, in order to obtain recognition, a school needs to function for at least three years but the Minister had made an exception. Immediately, the heads of many established Educational Institutes were up in arms and lodged a complaint. I was summoned at the Ministry and informed that sanctioning of the grant was a mistake. I was asked to refund the salaries paid by the government. Since it was not possible for me to do so, I requested them to adjust the same after the prescribed three year period and it was sanctioned. At that time there were 22 deaf and mute children in the school. I appointed Kanchan Kamble as the teacher for them. The classroom was built by covering the top floor of my house with tin sheets. Other children were accommodated in the room built with tin sheets on my farm. My friend, Rajabhau Lonkar understood my requirement and helped me to acquire half an acre of land in Wagholi. So in the year 1990, we built rooms with tin sheets. Popatsheth Sanghvi from Timber Market and a few of his business associates came

forward to help us. When the school was being run from my own house, there used to be a paucity of food grains. For wood, tin sheets, I used to approach Popatsheth and for food grains I used to approach his friends who owned grain shops and collect '*mhatra*'. In these shops, the grains, pulses or nuts which get spilled are collected in a huge, empty oil receptacle and that assorted mixture is called '*mhatra*'. It is the staple diet of the porters who grind this mixture and make flatbreads. It is a very healthy and wholesome blend. I would also bring it for our home consumption. Though the Government Grant was accorded yet it was difficult to make the ends meet. Kalpana Munot was the very first teacher to be appointed for the Residential School. Kaswa Sheth's two sons, Ashok and Vinod were my wife's classmates and with whom we had close family relations, readily helped me. He referred a lady named Kalpana Munot. She was about 20 to 22 years old with an infant girl. Unfortunately, she lost her husband in an accident. I appointed her as a teacher at the Residential School. She worked till her daughter grew up and in 1998 when her daughter got married, she left the job. She worked very well and took very good care of the School.

A lot of deaf and mute children would come from Shiroor Taluka. There is a considerable difference between deaf and mute and mentally challenged children. Hence, it was not possible to admit mentally challenged children at the Wagholi School which was meant for deaf and mute children. Once I had visited Pabal to attend some function where Mr. Sharad Pawar was also present. That time a person introduced me to the then Home Minister, Bapusaheb Thite. He hailed from a place called Kendoor near Pabal. He asked me to enrol some children from his area in my school which I readily agreed. After that function, as advised by Bapusaheb, parents along with their children approached me and asked me to admit their children to our school. The certificates

submitted by those parents confirmed that the children were mentally challenged. My school was for the deaf and mute children and as per the Government norms, we could not accept them in our school for the deaf and mute. The teaching techniques and the curriculum for the deaf and mute and the mentally challenged children are different. So I sent those parents back. They complained to Bapusaheb regarding the denial of admission for their children to our school. However, when I learnt of this, I personally met and explained the facts to Bapusaheb and he was convinced. But he strongly recommended me to establish a school for mentally challenged children also. I gave it a serious thought and took a survey of the entire Shiroor Taluka of which Kendoor and Pabal were parts. Then I took a firm decision to establish such a school in the same area as I felt a need for such a school. One of the reasons to select Pabal as a place for my school was the historical connection of our *Takari* community to that area. As explained earlier, Mastani was spurned by the Peshwa family for desecrating their religion, hence, Bajirao Peshwa built a grand mansion for her and appointed a few sturdy and fearless members of our community as personal guards. For the excellent service rendered, they were amply rewarded by Peshwa with land. Even today people from our community cultivate and own about 100 acres of land in that area. Ten years ago, the Department of Forest suddenly issued notices to the farmers of our community and we agitated against it. I convened meetings in Nasik, Pune, Baramati, Sholapur, met the District Collector, presented the factual information, the elaborate history behind it and thus effected a stay on that notice and stopped that unjust move. Hon. Sharad Pawarsaheb had helped me tremendously and thus, a big calamity was avoided. With the backdrop of the above incident, I did not find it much difficult to establish another school in that area. I needed a good, sincere social worker to carry out that work. I met Shivaji Gaikwad and Rameshbhau Gaikwad,

whom I used to call '*Mama*' - maternal uncle. Both were from our *Takari* community. I asked them to suggest a suitable person and they suggested one Gajanan Jadhav. Gajanan had studied up to tenth standard and hailed from Ambarnath in the Thane district. Since his father-in-law's house is at Pabal, he is a frequent visitor to Pabal.

Shivaji Jadhav introduced me to Gajanan. He apprised Gajanan about the work I was doing and my expectations from him. Since he was interested in social work, he willingly agreed. I entrusted him with the work of carrying out the survey of mentally challenged children in and around Pabal area. During those days the infrastructure like roads, conveyance and communication facilities were practically non-existent, yet Gajanan worked conscientiously. Whenever I visited Pabal, on my Kinetic Luna, he would provide me with the updates. Sometimes both of us would together survey the towns, colonies, habitations and look for mentally challenged children. We used to check their medical certificates. The children were located but the difficulty was to obtain a suitable place to establish the school. We solved it by renting two rooms in the huge house of one Mr. Kishor Ratnaparkhi located near Mastani's tomb in Pabal. We started the school in these two rooms and also found two teachers to take the responsibility to run the school. There is one more reason to select Pabal as the location for school of the mentally challenged children : This entire region is famine oriented. Paucity of water is perennial. Owing to such adverse conditions, parents from other places are not willing to marry their daughters to prospective bridegrooms residing in this area. Hence, most marriages take place within the periphery of close relatives. Thus, the outcome of such marriages is the birth of children with severe physical or mental handicap which is very evident here. Pabal is located about 20 kilometres off the Pune-Ahmednagar highway. Visitors

come to Pabal to see Padmani Jain Temple and Mastani's tomb. The Jain Temple attracts many devotees from Jain and Marwadi communities from Pune, Nagar and Mumbai yet, this area is not fully developed and known as the famine-stricken area. However, there is a majority of people from our *Takari* community. I too, have relatives in this area and often visit them. So I have affection for this area. I always yearned to do something worthwhile in this area and perhaps the school for mentally challenged children was the outcome of my strong yearning.



Actor Shri. Rahul Solapurkar in conversation with mentally challenged children.

The school continued to run in Mr. Ratnaparkhi's house till 2001. Then we purchased an acre land from one Mr. Choudhari and shifted the school in the new place. The building for the school was constructed on a room by room basis out of donations received from various donors. The need for permanent teachers was a necessity and accordingly we obtained the statutory permission from the authorities. We advertised in the local

newspaper 'Sakal'. 15 candidates arrived for the interview. One of them was an eighteen year old Muslim girl from Nasik. Her name was Reshma Tamboli. Her family hailed from Dhule, but owing to her father's job compelled the entire family to shift to Nasik. Reshma was not an ordinary girl because she had defied the orthodox elders in her house and in her community too, and completed her education. She obtained a Diploma in teaching the mentally challenged children from Prabodhini Vidyamandir at Nasik. She was tormented by her family and other community members too but, that did not deter her. She had specially opted for this diploma because her cousin was mentally challenged. As she reviewed his life, a strong desire to help such children surged deep within her because normal children had somebody to guide them but helping and teaching such children would bring a lot of contentment. The fervent compelling force to do something constructive for the mentally challenged children propelled her to opt for this diploma. But there was another more pathetic facet to Reshma's life which I learnt later after her interview was over.

After all the interviews were over, Reshma's mother approached me while Reshma sat outside. Her mother's eyes brimmed with tears. Initially I was a bit perplexed but then she pushed a medical report towards me. I felt numb because as per the report, the mother had a life span of barely six months. The malignant tumour in her brain had cut short any hope of survival. I can never erase the memory of her pinched, forlorn look on her face. At that time, it was imperative to help Reshma for a couple of reasons. First and foremost was the single minded focus of her goal and second was the profoundly underlying anxiety in the mother's tears for her daughter's well-being. I decided to appoint Reshma. She undertook the responsibility of teaching 10-12 children. I offered her a meagre salary of 100 rupees, but she worked very diligently and in a dedicated manner, and she is working in the

same manner even as of today. Her husband Munna Sheikh is helping me at Vocational Guidance Centre and their son is studying in a school in Panchgani.

Gajanan Jadhav, the social worker and the initial surveyor became the administrator of the school and Reshma the teacher. Both of them are running the school very efficiently, with total dedication and affection.

After allotting the responsibility of the school on Reshma, she surveyed around three to four Talukas for mentally challenged children and got them admitted in the school. Generally, the parents of such children are completely ignorant about the existence of such schools for children with special needs. In reality, a very different skill is required for handling such children. As compared with the normal children their IQ is much less and hence, unusual methods of drawing or sign language have to be used while teaching them. Besides, it is imperative for teachers to have abundant patience and understanding because at times, it takes three to four months to teach them a simple objective or a lesson. While teaching such children certain phases have to be demarcated. Children are examined by Psychiatrists and upon their recommendation, they are admitted to the relevant class. Children are admitted to the school even at the age of 18 and their Intelligent Quotient decides the class to which they get admitted.

As of today, this school has received Government Grant based on the strength of 40 students, but actually there are 60 students in the school. It takes around five to six years to train and raise these students to a feasible level of intelligence. This school being a Residential School, we had a dual daily activity to be followed to begin the day, one was to seek for food from the neighbouring village and second was to teach these children the basic activities

like brushing teeth, bathing and dressing etc. Under such circumstances, the parental co-operation is essential. Besides, very often these children suffer from some ailments and they are unable to express themselves, so they frequently need medical attention. Very many children suffer from epileptic convulsions and have to be administered medicines twice a day. In brief, these children need much more care than normal children. The teachers and myself strive to do our best to look after them throughout the day. The Pune Rotary Club and an Institute of Holland selected our school as the best one and constructed a modern building for our school. We strive to impart the knowledge of fundamental matters to these children so that they may be able to lead a more or less an ordinary life. They are unable to comprehend their own actions, at times, they undress themselves or spit on the lunch that is served and eat the same too. They are not conscious of their own unexpected actions. Hence, many a times, parents ill treat them by trussing up at home and then give them to eat. In our school, they are taught in a steady and systematic manner so they may be able to learn to live and behave normally.

Till date, I have always been on the lookout for donors and thus, expanded my school. It would not be out of place but I must mention that people from Jain and Marwadi communities have helped me the most. Some have provided and have continued to do so with clothes, foodstuffs and food grains for our school children, some have set up *Pani puri* stall while some have supplied educational material and have even constructed additional classrooms. The Ghule Family have been helping us for the past twenty years. In the year 1990 Mr. Shivajirao Ghule, founder of the sugar mill '*Yashwant Sakhar Karkhana*' in Manjri, supplied us with firewood for our kitchen. His grandson and director of the company, Naval Ghule, whom I look upon as my own son, continued to help by providing sugar, clothes, food,

building material. Many social Institutes too, came forward to help the school. Thus, owing to such generosity, the school functions smoothly. Though there is never any surplus yet, there is never a day when the school children have to go hungry. Students from my other schools and centres work for this school. One such student is Bipin. One of my friends had found Bipin on a Railway Station at Madhya Pradesh and brought him to me. I had enrolled him in my Residential School in Wagholi. He completed his schooling and then joined as a caretaker at this school for the mentally challenged children at Pabal. This school which was established at Mr. Ratnaparkhi's house is now functioning from its self-owned premises. The foundation stone for this new modern building was laid by Respected Vijay Vishwakalyanji. An Institute in Amsterdam, Holland too, contributed generously for setting up this school and the classrooms were constructed by The Rotary Club of Pune.

Institute which provides autonomous education and training.



**Consulate General of Japan, Mr. Hoshimura's
visit to our school.**

The strength of our school is around 600 students comprising of orphans, mentally challenged, deaf and mute. There is no support from the Government for the orphan students after they cross the age of 18. Hence, later these children without any support tend to go astray and resort to theft, pick pocket, begging and thus, become criminals. In order to make such children self-reliant and capable of running some small business, I set up a Training and Vocational Guidance Centre. Mr. Kawathe, Head of the Social Welfare Department, provided substantial help in this project. We cordially invited him as the Chief Guest for the inauguration ceremony. In the year 2016, with the help of some farmers from Pabal, 'Credenza Farmers Produce Company Limited' was established. This set up was not meant only for the students of my Residential School, but also for the small land owners and farmers to impart training and the modern techniques of running businesses that would complement to the farming activities. Dr. Vivek Bhardesaheb, the Joint Commissioner of Department of Animal Husbandry of Government of Maharashtra initiated the concept to start a similar Institute for the orphans, deaf and mute and also for mentally challenged. Work to raise the financial assistance for this Institute is underway. The aim is to train farmers and also children and make them self-sufficient by providing education and training for managing the businesses which will complement the farming.



Training and Vocational Guidance Centre for Nomad and Mentally Challenged Children.

These days, I devote my entire time for the rehabilitation of orphans and handicapped children and finding ways and means to provide livelihood to the poor farmers. I work from eight in the morning till eight in the evening. Later, I devote some time for my school at Wagholi. I have completed seventy years of my life. People often ask me, 'How do you derive energy to work for such long hours, almost 16 continuous hours at this age?' I think 'willpower' and the inclination to work provides me with the energy. Age is not a factor to be considered then. I am hopeful that in the coming years, very large businesses will start. Here, through my Institutes, we are running many projects and activities such as rearing of livestock, hydroponics - farming without soil and with mineral nutrients and water. Subhash Jadhav and Sanjay Shebde have provided 4-5 acre land for our projects.

We have built sheds as per the Government Rules for Goat rearing. We have also attempted to construct affordable, low cost barns for the famers by using bamboo, grass and also with discarded furniture. The land required for the Institute which has been established on the basis of the idea given by Dr. Vivek Bharde, has been procured for a period of three years on annual rent of Rs.7,000. I am the Chairman and Dr. Vivek Bharde and Mrs. Manasi Bharde work as Secretaries. My friend Mr. Dhoble is the Chartered Accountant and the Advocate. He looks after the Accounts. Some farmers who are members of the Institute are also Office Bearers. Day by day, since the problem of employment is becoming rather grave, so we have compromised on certain principles and have undertaken Goat rearing, Poultry Farming, Animal Husbandry and Farming using modern techniques. For these projects, we arranged Bank Loans for 16 poor farmers which will benefit them.

Goat rearing yields very good income in a short span. It is analogous to the Automated Teller Machine - ATM. After three months of nurturing, goats can be sold very profitably. We need lot of milk for the students of our various schools. This business helps us to satisfy that requirement too. At present we have brought the breed of goats from Kota and Usmanabad. Cattle rearing too, has been started by us. For that, we have brought the very well-known and superior breed of Gir cows from Gujarat.

To meet the requirement of huge stock of fodder for all these animals, we have planted maize. Suitable techniques are being utilized to get maximum production in minimum space, a demonstration of which I had in Khed. Generally the plants are cultivated in soil. But in case of the shortage of soil, now it is possible to cultivate them only with water. This process is known as Hydroponic Farming. This technique was developed in Israel. The harvest of this form of farming is pretty nutritious. The seeds are required to be soaked in water for 24 hours. Then after every one hour, water is dribbled for a minute. We have been cultivating maize at Pabal with this method. I have attended a training session of Hydroponic Farming conducted by 'Sakal International', at Baner Road, Pune. The yield of one acre land can be achieved in only 400 square feet of land. Now, the young nomads from our school can conduct Goat and Poultry Farming with minimum space. All these activities have lent a support to our aim of making these children self-reliant thus, giving them an impetus to achieve loftier goals and become worthy businessmen. This is the first experiment of farming with the use of the most modern techniques conducted in Maharashtra. It is going to prove beneficial to the ordinary farmers too, because it is carried out with minimum expenses and in minimum space.

Deepali Tukaram Dhore works as Secretary of this massive project. She belongs to a small town Dhore-Bhamburdi, Shiroor Taluka, Pune District. It is very near to Pabal. She met me while enrolling her children in my School at Wagholi. She had lost her husband and was facing a difficult situation. She was in need of work. So when I offered her job in school she willingly agreed. She became the caretaker of the girls in my Residential School in Wagholi. She had left school fifteen years ago when she was in eighth standard yet, she strived to study. One day she expressed her desire to continue her studies. I truly admired her grit to study. I asked her to contact my daughter Ratnamala and Principal Sonawne. As per their advice Deepali submitted Form 17 and decided to appear for the Tenth Standard Examination. She started studying with other girls from the Residential School, attending lectures whenever possible. All the teachers encouraged her and provided her with a strong support. She passed the examination with 77% marks. She appeared for Twelfth Standard Examination and passed with 66% marks. In the meantime, she also completed MS-CIT course. Thus, now she is efficiently bearing the responsibility as the Secretary of Credenza Farmers Produce Co. Ltd. It will not be out of place if I may make a mention that all my projects are progressing successfully only because of many associates like Deepali who work diligently and honestly and above all immensely cherish and care for their work as well as the Institutions too.



Accolades / Honours

Samajik Krutadnyata Nidhi - Social Gratitude Fund :

During the decade of the 80's, I began devoting my entire time to the school I had established as per my mother's inspiration. Though I spent time to garner funds from the wealthy people in the society, I never neglected my social work which I carried out in a very dedicated manner. During that time, my associates in the various social agitations, Niloo Phule, Dr. Shriram Lagoo and Sadashiv Amrapurkar lent a helping hand through their **Samajik Krutadnyata Nidhi - Social Gratitude Fund**. During the year 1987, they had staged a Marathi play called '*Lagnachi Bedi*'.



Marathi
Film Actor
Shri.Nilu Phule's
visit to our school.

The funds earned from the play staged all over Maharashtra were utilized to honour many Social Activists in Maharashtra. I was one of them. The selection was done District wise. One activist was selected from each District and a monthly honorarium of Rs. 400 was conferred. This honour filled me with a profound sense of fulfilment for the recognition of my work thereby giving it a remarkable impetus. This Social Gratitude Fund has a significant place in my life. Baba Adhav has always provided valuable help in my work.

Appointment on the Pradeshik Duiyam Sewa Niwad Mandal (1993) - Board of Regional Secondary Service (1993)

I have been in close contact with Hon. Shri Sharad Pawar ever since I began working with Baba Adhav in the various social agitations, rather, I knew him even before that. During the days when the land issue of Mundhwa was raised, Laxman Mane, Moorchand Bhaat, Vilas Wadekar and myself would often meet him. In due acknowledgement for my dedicated work, in the year 1993, Sharad Pawar appointed me as a member of the Regional Secondary Service Selection Board. During that period, he was the Chief Minister of Maharashtra. Laxman Mane persistently asserted for my appointment since I was the only candidate who was not only a Post Graduate in dual subjects but also the only one who was wholly devoted to the cause of the upliftment of the orphans and nomads.

To select candidates for the positions at the Maharashtra state level and to guide the Regional Secondary Service Boards, the Maharashtra Regional Secondary Service Selection Board [Apex Board] was established in 1988. There was a provision for the appointment of two part time candidates. Prof. Sayda Wasim Kadri and myself were appointed. I was appointed for two positions, as a member secretary of the Apex Body of all other

Regional Secondary Service Selection Boards for the entire Maharashtra State and also as a member of the Regional Secondary Service Selection Board for the Pune Area. After the announcement of this appointment, though I received a lot of accolades from many persons, my mother did not comprehend much about the details but she was fairly aware that her son had won laurels. But she cautioned me. She said, 'Do whatever you think good, be big, but never neglect these children! Always remember that they are your first and foremost responsibility.'

District Vigilance Committee (1994).

Decision was taken by the Government of Maharashtra to appoint some non- governing members on the District Vigilance Committees. Pune District Collector was authorized to do so with due approval of the Guardian Minister of the Pune District. Accordingly, eight members including myself were appointed on the District Vigilance Committee for the abolition of untouchability.

Review of my work by Honourable Sharad Pawar.

Our group of friends and associates involved in social work would assemble annually at the school established by Laxman Mane in Jakatwadi, a town in Satara District, to commemorate the death anniversary of Yashwantrao Chavan. In those days I had founded an Institute for the nomads and Wimukt (De-notified) tribes. Sharad Pawar was the Chairman while Laxman Mane was the Chief Executive, Dr. Baba Adhav, Vilas Wadekar, Moorchand Bhaat and myself were the Founder Members. Sharad Pawar was very supportive in garnering the funds to run the Institute. He would visit the Institute and spend an entire day in reviewing our progress.



Shivalal Jadhav with Hon. Sharadchandraji Pawar at
All India Takari Community Convention

We used to read out the reports to him but also discuss our difficulties. I was also a member of the Institute in Satara. Sharad Pawar himself would ask us to voice our formal grievances, if any. So we mentioned our displeasure at the absence of our community's representation in the State Legislative Assembly. Since our community was extensively scattered, it was very difficult for a candidate to win majority in one constituency to win an election. Sharad Pawar understood our predicament and decided to give representation to our community, though not in the State Legislative Assembly but in the State Legislative Council. Accordingly, Laxman Mane became the first member of State Legislative Council. It was planned that subsequently the positions would be given to me, Moorchand Bhaat, Vilas Wadekar and a few others. But I never pursued that matter since I had no interest in Politics whatsoever.





मतिमंद मुलांच्या शाळेचा
'पाबळ पॅटर्न' राज्यात राबवावा

ब्राह्मण पात्रार्थे यच्च आवाहन

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वाघोलीच्या आश्रमशाळेतील प्रकल्पांचे उद्घाटन

महोदय कृपया

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 विष्णु भक्ति
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Special children's day out at Andhra High School

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*Articles by
Dignitaries*

Man with a maternal heart



Dr. Baba Adhav
Senior Leader

I am a strong believer and an ardent advocate of the doctrine of equality as put forth and abided by the great leaders like Mahatma Jyotiba Phule, Rajarshi Shahu Maharaj and Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar. Every participant of our crusade too, shared the same views. One such staunch activist who shared such analogous belief was Shivalal Jadhav who became a part of our crusade. He hailed from the nomadic community. Laxman Mane, Motilal Rathod and Laxman Gaikwad from the same community were already members of our movement. In society, this community led their lives as 'Upras' - 'Outcasts' at that time and continue to do so as of today too. A man from Phaltan, who wandered around for

alms with an embellished bull, called 'Nandi Bail' (Bull is worshipped in our society as a vehicle of Lord Shiva) once told me 'Sir, we do not have a domiciled place. We are here today but tomorrow we have no idea where will we be!' He aptly described the condition of the nomads who do not live within the four walls, but without the four walls. Thus, this is their status! There are nomads and there are *Wimukt*, De-notifieds.

In 1970s, a big movement known as 'the Dalit Panther' came into being in Maharashtra. Raja Dhale, Namdeo Dhasal and many more were at the forefront in this movement meant for the dismissal of the discrimination of the lower castes in the society. In the past, the movements led by Mahatma Jyotiba Phule and Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar were known as '*Satyashodhak Chalwal* (unveiling the truth movement). During the '70s such movements for the lower castes gained momentum. They highlighted the difficulties of not only the *Dalits* - people from low castes -, but also those of nomads, Adivasis, workers and labourers. Activists like Laxman Mane, Shivalal Jadhav worked for the nomads and the *Wimukt* (De-notified) tribes. Shivalal and myself met each other for the first time during the issue related to the land in Mundhwa Settlement. That was the beginning of our friendship. I familiarize myself with the work he was doing as also his future plans. His selfless struggle was amply evident. At that time we were working for *Satyashodhak Chalwal* (unveiling the truth movement). Shivalal joined us in that movement too.

In the nomad communities, the overall percentage of educated people is low. Of late, the educational level has increased to some extent, but during the decade of the 70's it was very low. The lowly educated nomads used to find some odd jobs. But in those days, Shivalal was highly educated. Obtaining a well-paid job was not at all difficult for him, but he harboured a deep rooted belief that the utility of his education would not be for personal

gains but it would be for the upliftment of the society. The *Satyashodhak Chalwal* (unveiling the truth movement) was based on the sublime thoughts and principles of Mahatma Phule and Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar. Mahatma Phule in a bid to elucidate the significance of education, emphasized in his tome '*Shetkaryancha Asood*' (Whip of the Farmers) as under :

*Without education intellect is lost, without intellect ethics is lost,
Without ethics momentum is lost, without momentum wealth is lost
Without wealth progress is lost,
See, without education everything is lost!!*

Thus, Phule neatly paraphrased the importance of education in a modest stanza. Later, Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar too, laid emphasis on 'learn, unite and fight'. To draw the society from the abyss of illiteracy, access to adequate educational Institutes was imperative. Shivalal did that. Those who were deeply inspired by the philosophies of Mahatma Phule and Dr. Ambedkar, shouldered the responsibility to facilitate education for the masses. Karmaveer Bhaurao Patil founded '*Rayat Shikshan Samstha*', Maharshi Karve founded '*Karve Shikshan Samstha*', Babanrao Patil and Punjabrao Deshmukh too founded similar educational institutes as also many leaders from the Congress Party. Baburaoji Gholap founded the 'Pune District Education Association' That Association is running innumerable schools and colleges in Pune and other places. Ramkrishna More founded the Maratha Education Institutes. There are many Educational Institutes like the *Maratha Shikshan Samstha*. Baburao Jagtap, who worked for Sayaji Gaikwad and Maharaja for Baroda State, had devoted his life for education.

A virtue of Shivalal Jadhav that appealed to me the most was that he was never attracted to politics but always stayed focussed on the arduous task of imparting education to the less fortunate

children as also fostering them, which he sincerely continues to do even today. Laxman Mane and Laxman Gaikwad who were with Shivalal, entered politics at one point. Shivalal has founded Educational Institute for the nomads. He obtained two acres of land on Pune-Nagar Road for the Institute. This task was an onerous one and called for considerable foresight. I definitely feel that he has it. Nomads are born with an innate amount of difficulties and they cohabit with them. They are deprived of so much in life yet they are not aware of it. Hence, it is inexplicable to surmise the hardships and troubles these nomad children face, especially the trying situations the nubile, young girls have to undergo. Shivalal is determinedly toiling for the upliftment of this younger generation by attempting to bring them in the mainstream of our society. I had an opportunity to visit his school. An Advocate from Baramati, Vijay More accompanied me. We were pleasantly surprised to know that so many students of his school are successful professionals like, teachers, engineers, doctors etc. He continues to slog for the orphans as he assiduously collects food grains to feed them. My very humble and phenomenal tribute to his efforts. Fostering these children is really a herculean task given the innumerable obstacles like, where to keep them during the school's summer vacation or where to find shelter for them? They have neither parents nor a roof over their heads to call their own. It is well-nigh inexplicable to play the role of both parents simultaneously. To carry out this job successfully, it calls for the soft flair of a maternal heart which Shivalal has! I have always perceived a reflection of the virtues of Sane Guruji in him.

There are innumerable sugar mills in Maharashtra as also Educational Institutes too. Hence, there are many well known Sugar barons as also great Educationists, but how many of them have come forward to espouse the cause of these poor orphans or

nomads? It needs to happen but it does not! So, people like Shivalal have to depend on the Government Grants or on the charity of the philanthropic members of the society. Shivalal does that and makes sure that he does not get embroiled in the politics which is an inevitable part of all such philanthropy. Really, his work is akin to the conquest of Mount Everest!

Shivalal follows the lofty principle of, 'Simple living and high thinking'. He is devoid of any addiction. Today his entire family is engaged in the field of Education. Some time ago, Shivalal lost his son in an unfortunate accident. Though he is devastated by the unexpected loss of a young son yet, he did not allow his grief to cast a dark shadow on his work because deep within, he is very honest. He neither capitalizes on his caste or community nor does he ever indulge in politics. He does not have the power or the wherewithal but that does not deter his struggle for carrying out his work. For his work, he seeks help from the society. Sometimes he approaches me for help and I provide him to the best of my ability. The first time he came to me for help was for the issue of land in Mundhwa Settlement. Ever since I have been observing him as he continues to work hard for the wellbeing of the society.

Shivalal is multi-tasker. Generally, one attempts to spiral upwards in one's endeavour. For example, one who runs a school, then tries to open a college and collect more and more fees, but Shivalal's journey is in opposite direction. He strives to offer his services to the down trodden class. He worked for nomads and orphans, then he accepted the mentally challenged children in his school. In reality, children living in cities get whatever they want but here there are children who don't get anything. Shivalal also works on the farming activities. He helps the orphans to be self-reliant. He does not work to satisfy his needs, but the needs of the society and the society needs it. He endeavours to bring about a

considerable change in the society. He is the guardian of the orphans. He has also begun ancillary businesses to agriculture for the farmers. He strives to attain that such businesses are useful for well-being of the society. He may not be very adept in juxtaposing matters in order, but he has the foresight. He is not prudent but he has the potential to gain the trust of others. He gained my trust and that is precisely the reason why I promptly render help during his difficult times. Whatever he does he always has the society's interest in his mind. During the issue of the land at the Mundhwa Settlement, Shivalal invited me for a meeting to guide the affected farmers. While I was talking to them, an old man stood up and rudely shouted, 'Stop this nonsense! Nothing will happen. We have to suffer whatever is destined for us!' I understood his outburst very well. It meant that those in power never cared for people like him. A large disparity existed between the two classes. Hence, the need of the hour was to bring about a harmonious relationship between the two classes. Under the present circumstances, Shivalal has been attempting to bring about a radical change in the society's outlook. He does not waste his time in whining. Hence, the work that he has been doing is very vital for the transformation of the society. I would like wish that may he get enough courage and strength for his work. My very good wishes for his exceptional work.



A true, honest, sincere social worker



Bhai Vaidya,
Ex-Home Minister of Maharashtra,
a senior socialist, philosopher and leader.

While travelling from Ghorpadi to Mundhwa, on the left hand side is a school and behind that school, was the Settlement established by the British Rulers before Independence. In the year 1871, British Government legislated an act and proclaimed many nomadic communities as criminals and incarcerated them along with their families within the compound secured by barbed wire fences on the periphery. Thus, this community had to lead their lives in this confinement. They were liable to daily attend a roll-call before the police. It was in this settlement I met Shivalal Jadhav for the first time. We have been associated with each other for over fifty years. I have a great affection for Shivalal because he is an honest and sincere social worker.

In those days I was a frequent visitor to Mundhwa and very often I used to visit the Settlement too. For seven years, I was a full time member of the *Rashtra Seva Dal* - an organization to serve the nation. A large congregation of the members of the *Rashtra Seva Dal* (which we call 'Shakha') was held daily at Mundhwa Settlement with almost 100 youngsters in attendance. Tayappa Bhandari was the leader and the responsibility of the administration was entrusted with me. While handling my responsibilities, I would also guide the people who used to come there. I would commute on a bicycle in those days. During such travels, Shivalal met me and continued to meet me often. *Rashtra Seva Dal* used to organize a week's or a month's camps at Pune. Senior leaders, great Sociologists, Philosophers from all over the country would visit such camps and impart valuable guidance. Thus, this helped to mould the activists at the grass root level. S. M. Joshi, N. G. Gore, Acharya S. D. Javdekar were amongst those leaders. Acharya Javdekar was the editor of 'Lokshakti', a daily newspaper and was a Professor in Rashtriya College at Talegaon. He had written a Marathi book - '*Adhunik Bharat*'-'Modern India' which was extremely popular in those days. We used to read it over and over again. There is an effortless fluidity in the presentation of his thoughts and ideas. This book highlighted the national movement - it's growth, the influence of the diverse ideologies on the national movement and the impact on its proliferation as it finally converged with the Socialist philosophy. Well-known national leaders like Jayprakash Narayan, Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia, Sane Guruji and Madhu Limaye would visit these camps and express their thoughts. Such great, brilliant thinkers with their support and able guidance aided in the expansion of many young minds. Shivalal was one such young man, who was greatly influenced and nurtured by such events.

Later, Shivalal and Laxman Mane, author of the book '*Upra*'

(Outsider), participated in many agitations and rallies for the issues of the injustice meted out to their nomad community. Shivalal used to be at the forefront and gradually emerged as a promising activist of his nomadic community. Pune Corporation had passed a legislation to grab the lands belonging to the farmers at Mundhwa Settlement. We vehemently opposed the legislation and wholeheartedly supported Shivalal's efforts. Consequently, Pune Corporation had to withdraw its legislation. During that period, I frequently met Shivalal, as I marvelled at the steady progress of his work and was suitably impressed. A characteristic of his which truly impressed me was that he just did not focus on the agitation per se but on the manner of how to sort out the basic problems and difficulties of the society. That accounted for the establishment of the Educational Institute by Shivalal. He and Laxman Mane are two prominent organisers of setting up Educational Institutes. Shivalal once invited me to his school at Wagholi and I was pleasantly surprised to learn that the co-ed school strength was around 300 to 400 with a hostel for boys. I deeply appreciated that Shivalal had provided facility for education right from kindergarten to middle school level. He firmly believed that education is the key to development, growth and progress not only of an individual but also of the society at large and therefore placed considerable weightage on Educational Institutes. I visit numerous places and stress on the importance of the establishment of educational institutes because the accessibility to such Institutes will ensure the growth and sound development of the budding young activists and they in turn, will aid the society on the path of progress. He himself has put forth the example. Shivalal accurately honed on this need and established the educational institutes. Being a Post Graduate, he realized the importance of education as he left no stone unturned to make sure that every child from the society must have an access to education for the society to tread on the path of progress.

Shivalal grew up in the Settlement and has witnessed the abject sufferings of the members of his community. A surge of affection and pride sweeps over me as I see the manner in which Shivalal fully immerses himself with great devotion to carry out the productive work for the society. He does it mainly because he is an honest and sincere social worker. We do not meet very often but we have immense regard and affection for each other. He cordially invites me for all his functions and I assiduously make it a point to attend them without extending any excuses and I also promise I will do that forever.

Nomads are constantly on the move and that is why the community is not organized. They do not have domiciled hometowns or homes to call their own! There are many internal castes and sub-castes which accounts for the difference in their dialect, beliefs, superstitions and customs. Inter-caste marriages are totally banned as Caste Councils are predominantly decisive. People are far too bound by customs and rituals. According to the Renke Commission's report, the population of these nomad communities is around 11 crores with about 286 tribes in that community. Out of the 11 Crore population, around 2 crores are settled in various cities. The rest of them are continuously on the move. Government does not pay much attention to these nomadic communities. However, the most unfortunate issue is that the children of the nomads remain uneducated! Children drag around with their parents and are deprived of education. The most alarming and shocking attitude is that of the Education Departments at the Central and State Government level which has neglected this issue but they must not do so as of now. They must open Hostels for these nomadic children as they have done for the Adivasis. Adivasis have farms but do not have the ownership i. e. the 7X12 Extracts of the lands. So whenever a new large project is announced, they tend to lose their lands and

cannot fight for it for the want of the 7X12 extracts. However, nomads do not have farms! Arundhati Roy has put forth a fact : 'According to a survey, since the Independence of the country, four crores of Adivasis have been displaced. Three and a half lac farmers have committed suicides. The Government barely took notice of it and continued to neglect them.' Thus, the Government has neither paid any attention to the nomadic communities nor did it make any employment available to them. Highest employment is generated, not through factories but through farming because workers from factories are summarily dismissed from employment. Shivalal has recently established a Training Institute for farmers which offers training in businesses that are complementary to farming. Recognizing the importance of farming he has laid stress on that sector because as of today, the annual requirement of employment has reached the level of a crore. This problem has become very critical and yet, it does not obtain sufficient attention from the Government. Government needs to extend the top priority to the problem of employment but it fails to do so. With this background, Shivalal's painstaking efforts to ensure that the youth get suitable employment by imparting the business skills that complement the farming activities, is in my opinion, extremely important.



A lotus that bloomed in the swamp



Balkrishna Renke

Ex-Chairperson of National Commission
for De-notified, Nomadic and
Semi-nomadic Tribes (NCDNSNT)

Shivalal Jadhav is my friend and associate from various agitations. We met for the first time during 1975. I was on the tour of the entire state with my colleague Daulatrao Bhosle to organize and unite the members of nomadic and de-notified tribes. During our visit to the Mundhwa Settlement at Pune, I came across a young educated man with an impressive personality. He was Dr. Shivalal Jadhav. During our first meeting I was informed that Shivalal is not only a Post Graduate but also, the only educated youngster in the Settlement. I was deeply impressed right from the first meeting itself and the curiosity to know him better overtook me.

As compared to the rest of the surroundings and society, Settlement, the place where Shivalal resided was known as society and colony of the criminals. These residents were alienated from education. I did not come across any educated person in that community, yet, Shivalal was a Post graduate! It was a very commendable achievement and even as of now very creditable that given the odds of 80% of the people around were involved in a web of crime, he was drawn to education and indefatigably pursued it. I was curious to know how he achieved it because the very first meeting was not sufficient to know him better. Later, we continued to meet often to discuss the social issues. I got to know him better and better as the various facets of 'Shivalal - the activist' unfolded.

We were all working for the society. Shivalal was also working so also many others were working towards the same goal. Since we worked as part of particular organizations, there would be differences of opinions, disputes and even rifts. Such circumstances result in the division of the strength of individuals thereby weakening the combined strength to fight for the needs or against issues and injustice. So we formed a team to forestall such discords and ensure unity. Shivalal was one of the members of this team. We once discussed on the various modes and means to sustain the unity of the organization and proposed to hold a rally at Pimpri-Chichwad area. The rally was well organized and many put in unstinting efforts to make the rally a success but Shivalal's contribution towards the success, was prominent. Not only during that rally but even otherwise, he works in a very sincere and selfless manner without assuming any credit. Though the Criminals Tribes Central Act was abolished and some facilities were provided for the development and progress of those tribes, yet there was not much change in the mindset of the community. They continued carrying out the same old activity of brewing

illicit liquor. In and around Mundhwa alone there were around 200 illicit breweries. Widespread violence, quarrels, thefts, abusive behaviour continued as the order of the day. Against such a backdrop of quagmire, in that swamp Shivalal bloomed like a lotus!

This Lotus did not allow the hardships, sorrows fade it's calmness, cheerfulness, pleasantness. He lost his father even before he came in this world. Both father and son were not destined to see each others' faces. His mother toiled very hard to give him a sound upbringing. Once he mentioned to me that when he was just eleven days old, his mother was engaged in hauling heavy boulders from the deep pit of a well and carrying them all the way up. The on-duty Supervisor was deeply moved by the plight of a recuperating newly minted mother carrying out such laborious work. She called his mother aside and inquired about her. When she learnt that his mother had studied up to seventh standard, she undertook special efforts and entrusted her with the responsibility to cook food for the girls at the Remand Home. Thus Shivalal's mother obtained a Government job. There were two parallel paths in their community, one which easily turned to crime for livelihood and the other, which steadfastly believed in hard work to come up in life. Shivalal's mother opted for the latter path. Shivalal grew up under the maternal canopy and thus, imbibed her virtues. When she was transferred from Sholapur to Mundhwa, Shivalal was in first standard. Throughout her life, his mother assiduously fostered the social obligation. Shivalal too, followed in the footsteps of his mother. While studying, he started a Kindergarten – *Balwadi* and also classes to teach tailoring to the women to desist them from the path of petty crimes. Shivalal displayed the path of honest work to earn money and run families. He had a very small house, not sufficient for his own family, yet, he gave shelter to some orphan children in his house and took care

of them. His mother was working and her salary was not sufficient enough to lead a life of luxury but it was not too meagre to starve either. Yet major portion of her earning was being spent for social work. Shivalal or his mother or even his wife never refused help for any genuine cause. Whenever we visited his house for some organization's work, we were cordially served either meals or some tea. Later on, we learnt that at times there used to be a shortage of food and his wife used to borrow *bhakris* - flatbreads made from the flour of millets - from the neighbours and feed us. It was just not in the nature of Shivalal to ever whine or grumble about his personal problems. He was very well aware that compared to his personal problems those of the society were much more important. He had the attitude to serve the society at the cost of own sacrifices.

In reality, owing to his innate inclination towards society, Shivalal joined social movements. It was a conscious, deliberate decision to be in this field. Had he opted for a normal, personal life, he would have reached loftier heights. He is a Post Graduate and wished to go for the Indian Administrative Services - IAS. At that time, there were special training classes for candidates from nomad and de-notified communities, where preparations used to be made for the examinations of IAS. Shivalal had appeared for its entrance examination and obtained eleventh rank in the merit list and there were only ten seats. However, he found that one of his friends obtained fifth rank in the merit list. He found it a bit strange because that friend always scored less marks than Shivalal roughly by at least 5 to 6 %. He was upset by the injustice and so he directly approached the Vice Chancellor of the University and demanded for the reassessment of his papers. After the reassessment, he was selected! This is Shivalal who is normally calm but aggressive against injustice.

Whenever we visited Pune, he would accord full co-operation to us. Around 1982, an issue arose regarding the land allotted by the Government to the nomad and de-notified communities in Mundhwa Settlement. Pune Municipal Corporation took a decision of relocating the barns of the animals from the main city to that land. As the news was published, an agitation began to retain the land with those nomads and de-notified people. Shivalal Jadhav was at the forefront of the local agitation. Knowing fully well that the nomads and de-notified tribes were weak and without any support, it was planned to suppress the agitation and shift the barns as planned. Pune Municipal Corporation took the help of the Police and attempted to suppress the agitation by emphasizing on the criminal background of the nomads and de-notified land owners. To add to the conflict, one day at the crack of the dawn, between two and two thirty, Police conducted a raid on the settlement. Police not only mercilessly beat up the men, but also assaulted the womenfolk by tearing off the sarees from their bodies. The people were disgusted by the police force. We took Shivalal Jadhav with us to meet social leaders from the nomad community as also others. We met Baba Adhav, Bhai Vaidya, Anil Awachat, N.G.Gore and explained the situation to them. They led the agitation which received good response from the general public. To register the resentment against injustice and to garner sympathy from the society for the women who underwent the abominable indignity at the hands of the police, Baba Adhav presented them with new sarees and that too on the occasion of Bhaubeej - a festival to highlight love between brothers and sisters. All this was possible due to Shivalal Jadhav's strong bond with the people at all strata of the society. Since the public opinion was in our favour, the land remained with their original nomads and de-notified owners. The land was again distributed legally and the moment it was reinstated to the original nomads and the de-notified tribes, Shivalal Jadhav

quietly stepped aside because he did not wish to meddle any further. After getting the possession of the land, the quarrels between the owners began on a large scale. Earlier, the news of the slaying of the members of the Pardhee community by the Kanjarbhats and vice versa were heard but then, it continued due to the trivial problems like the intrusion of ploughs in one another's lands. The basic reason was the ignorance amongst the nomads and de-notified. Shivalal used to patiently solve their disputes. It is easier to get into any group but to sort out such disputes and render peace amongst the warring parties is very challenging which Shivalal could manage because he was impartial and had no interest in the land. Instead of glorifying himself as a leader, he engaged himself in taking the social workers from Pune and Mumbai to the place of disputes, to discuss and pacify the landowners. With his complacent attitude, he could deal with the intellectuals, bureaucrats, officers etc and request them to pay a visit to the affected area in order to talk with the concerned people. With a good command over English language, he could impress people. Gradually, they realized that he was not antagonistic towards them as they began to repose their trust in him.

But people are inclined to forget! The people for whom Shivalal toiled to retrieve their lands promptly forgot the good favour he had done as they did not come forward to help him when he was in need of some place for his school. But Shivalal did not hold any rancour against them as he continued selflessly carrying out his duty. One of his friends gave him land in Wagholi and he established his school. He is doing extraordinary work in the field of education and simultaneously he is also taking great efforts to treat the mentally ill or weak people. Many people indulge in finding drawbacks in others, but very few, like Shivalal take a note of virtues in others as they imbibe the same. That is the

reason people repose their trust in him and willingly come forward to help him. He deemed it as a necessity to help the mentally as well as physically ill people, hence he started working for the orphans, deaf and mute, physically and mentally challenged children. He even planned for their rehabilitation. For them, he established the Vocational Training in Goat rearing, Poultry Farming and Animal Husbandry. The work originally started in Wagholi has now reached Pabal as he keeps pushing his social work borders further and further. Recently, a pall of gloom descended on such a dynamic social worker. Two years ago, his son, daughter-in-law and two grandsons died in an unfortunate accident. His plan of delegating the enormous responsibility of his Educational Institutes to his son and daughter-in-law was nipped in the bud by destiny. It was extremely difficult to recover from that crushing, devastating grief but Shivalal did recover. With his steadfast belief that social work is the goal of his life, he bounced back with great elan to continue his work. My very best wishes to him for his work.



Constructive Work



Neelamtai Gorhe
Shivsena Leader

In 1981, we established the '*Stree Adhar Kendra*'- 'Women's Support Centre'- at Satavwadi in Hadapsar. My medical consulting room too, was at Satavwadi. Destitute, under-privileged women from the nomad community approached me with their social problems. At that time the Dalit Movement for the eradication of caste discrimination had gained momentum as also the Nomad movement. The most fundamental agenda of the Nomad movement was to eradicate the stamp of criminals on them. The participating leaders and activists of that movement who were striving to solve problems of the nomad communities would come to meet us. Balkrishna Renke, Laxman Mane,

Shivalal Bhosle, Laxman Gaikwad were among those leaders. They belonged to different organizations and different political parties as they dealt with the problems of their own communities. The common thread amongst them was that they were all keen on providing education to every member of the society, forging a strong unity amongst the members of their community and doing away with the ruinous and appalling customs and traditions. In the process of pursuing these common interests, I met them and we all became acquainted with each other.

Around that time a Convention of the Nomad and De-notified Community was held at Pimpri-Chinchwad regarding the issues and problems faced by the womenfolk of those communities. When I realized the gravity of the problems faced by women from Joshi, Pardhi and the *Nandibail* community- who wander around with a decorated bull begging for alms (Bull is worshipped in our society as vehicle of Lord Shiva), I joined the convention. There I met Shivalal Jadhav, a social worker who was striving for the development and progress of his community. He resided at the Mundhwa Settlement. If there were any problems pertaining to the women at the settlement, I would visit the settlement. I attended many functions arranged by Shivalal Jadhav and also visited his school. Many social workers and organizations established schools, but Shivalal did so, not only for the children of his nomad community but also for children of all religions and castes.

Anil Awachat wrote in one of his books that the people who migrated to Sholapur Road area and did not find any shelter, moved to Hadapsar and settled there. Given the situation, Shivalal Jadhav began working for such people and opened a school without any grant. Shivalal Jadhav opened the portals of education to the underprivileged who were penniless and had no status in the society. I can state that Shivalal Jadhav founded his

Educational Institute based on the same principle on which *Rayat Shikshan Sanstha* was founded by Karmaveer Bhaurao Patil. It is a common norm in social struggles that, many associates remain together forever while some part ways. It was the same with Shivalal Jadhav, yet he continued his constructive work and achieved stupendous success. Schools founded by Shivalal Jadhav are currently a crucial requirement. Society needs schools for the children of the nomad community, may it be in Beed area or in Usmanabad area. The standard of education required by the children of such communities is different than the education of the normal children. So it is imperative that they obtain that basic education.

Shivalal Jadhav, the participant of various social movements and agitations, did an excellent job in Mundhwa of providing opportunity of good education for the children of the nomad and underprivileged communities. When he began this work, very few institutions were working for these children. When people from the rural areas moved to Pune's Hadapsar area, Shivalal Jadhav opened a school for them. Along with educational work, the colonies which were allotted to the Pardhi community were akin to a prison. Shivalal Jadhav did the work of amalgamating this community into the mainstream of the society. For this philanthropic work, I would truly like to place on record my most sincere appreciation. With a comprehensive view, Shivalal Jadhav has opened the doors of education to all the castes and sub castes of his community. In 1986, we had organized workshops for the women folk of the Pardhi community in Nimgaon-ketki and in towns near Baramati. We realized that the children from that community were starved and the women carried big bundles of rags. To our dismay, we found that they carried pieces of *Bhakris*- flatbreads, collected from people's houses to feed their children in case no other food was available. Shivalal Jadhav and

his family took efforts to supply food to such starving children. They are, in a way, building those children's future. Sometime ago, the Social Welfare Department discontinued the grants of the Residential Schools. That time Shivalal Jadhav brought the Organisers of the Residential Schools together and raised an agitation. He phoned me and I raised the issue in the Legislative Assembly and attempted to reinstate the grant. Later, he withdrew the agitation. When I was a Member of the Legislative Assembly, I always supported the Institutions that had no political support. But at times, I have some qualms whether it is the right manner or not. But in case of Shivalal Jadhav, I am confident that my patronage is appropriate. My most sincere good wishes for Shivalal Jadhav's work.



A Selfless Activist



Laxman Mane
Senior Leader

Subsequent to the release of my autobiography 'Upra' (Outcast), many felicitation programmes were organized and I was receiving many invitations to give speeches. Since I was visiting many places, I had chance to meet many other activists and celebrities. A halo had grown around Laxman Mane! My autobiography inspired many youngsters from the nomad and denotified communities and they were drawn towards me. Besides the lavish appreciation generated by 'Upra', veritable exchanges of thought processes and fine points of each others' work were also being carried out. During one such occasion, I met Shivalal Jadhav. Impressed by his gratitude towards the society coupled

with a fervent passion and grit about his work, I sought more information on the young activist. I learnt that he was Post Graduate in Economics and Politics from the Pune University and was pursuing his Doctorate. When I inquired with him about his origins, he said he belonged to the Takari community! I was pleasantly surprised because I also hail from the backdrop of the same community. A foregone conclusion was that in this community you point at any youngster and he would be illiterate. Yet, under such circumstances, Shivalal had taken a scholarly quantum leap. We decided to work together.



Shri. Ajit Pawar, Shri. Balasaheb Shivarkar, Laxman Mane and others distributing land to Nomads at Mundhwa.

Being highly educated, Shivalal could have easily got a well-paid job anywhere, but he decided to pursue his Doctorate and was studiously working towards it but he was also staunchly devoted to the social agitations too. This social work frequently brought us together as we struggled to achieve similar aims of creating social awareness, tightly knitting the society together and

interacting with the people. Gradually, a bond was established between us and we grew closer more as brothers rather than friends. Under the able leadership of Shivalal organizational work was established in and around Pune. Shivalal is a person who pitches himself headlong in work, who is wholly committed to his work and who is also fully aware of it. No movement subsists without activists or rather it is the universal equation that 'Movement means activists'. But amongst such activists, many are mere enthusiasts, inexperienced novices who just participate and have no genuine sense of involvement or commitment. Many harbour personal interests and vanish after their purpose is served. But I found that Shivalal did not belong to that category. He was an alien to selfishness else an intelligent post graduate like him would not have given up the luxury of a comfortable lifestyle afforded by a highly remunerative job and rush headlong into the arduous social work to dedicate himself for the upliftment of the poor and deprived.

He did not have a financially sound background. He was poor but not starving. He owned a rickety two wheeler Luna that always seemed to threaten to come apart with a wobbly wheel. Both of us used to travel on that rickety vehicle around the length and breadth of Pune city. I used to occasionally meet him but our talk always centred on social work, social issues, movements and agitations. That was and is still an indication of his profound involvement and commitment to his work. Whatever he does, he does it full-heartedly, does not spare anything. His wife, Sangita too, has the same nature. It never happens that I am in Pune and Shivalal is not with me. We are always together. Hence meals at his house are inevitable. Very often, we reach his house at an odd hour, perhaps by two or three a.m., but even at that unearthly hour I am served fresh, warm food cooked by Sangita - who is akin to my sister-in-law. No guest at his house ever goes to sleep on an

empty stomach. Sangita invariably extends the finest hospitality to every visitor and that too with a cheerful face and with great affection. Her cordial hospitality has no under shades of being obligatory at all because she is totally dedicated to Shivalal and his work. The couple used to look after 20-25 children, when Shivalal started Balwadi - kindergarten - in his small house. We used to be worried but Shivalal always took it in his stride! The Balwadi functioned without any grant and he would depend on people's generosity. Husband and wife nurtured those orphans like their own children. In their house, after Balwadi, there used to be Tailoring Class for the womenfolk. There was never a moment's respite at his house. It was a beehive of endless work, school followed by the tailoring class followed by something else... just one after the other. Till today, it is difficult to fathom how he managed the financial aspect of these activities at that time!

The remarkable job Shivalal did for the Mundhwa Settlement was to retrieve the lands for the landowners when Pune Municipal Corporation planned to grab them. The land allotted to Sarvoday Farming Society for the nomads and de-notified people by the Government was in the process of being snatched away by the Pune Municipal Corporation. With our agitation, we dealt a sharp blow on that attempt and Shivalal played a major role in that agitation. Each of the 70 landowners got two acres of land totalling to 140 acres. But their financial condition was so bad that they did not even have twelve rupees to pay for the 7X12 extracts of their land. Shivalal and myself crowd funded and paid the money to the authorities and completed the formalities. Thus they got back their land.

In 1987, we had organized a *Shodhyatra* - 'Search Journey' from Latur to Mumbai. The responsibility of the Pune area was entrusted to Shivalal. It never happened that, Shivalal ever failed

in carrying out a responsibility entrusted to him. Hence, it went without saying that one could always rely on Shivalal and still it holds true. In the year 1988, Sharad Pawar became the Chief Minister of Maharashtra. We had a very good rapport with him. He mentioned that educational institutes need to be established for children of nomad and de-notified communities. Accordingly, I established a school while Shivalal established a Residential School in Wagholi and Bheemrao Guruji, also from our community, established one in Sholapur area. Thus, along with movements and agitations, we also got involved in Educational activities. We immersed ourselves in work that we almost overlooked everything else like jobs, family, worldly affairs etc. At that time, the means of communication were not as advanced as they are today as also the mode of travel was not that comfortable. We used to be away from home for over a week at a stretch. There were neither mobile phones nor land line phones to communicate with our family. Our families would meet us on the day we reached home! Anyway, our families were pretty accustomed to this way of life. Besides, owing to the staunch support accorded by our families, we were able to accomplish such a considerable amount of challenging work.

In the year 1990, owing to Sharad Pawar, I became a MLA - Member of Legislative Assembly. It was a welcomed change. A social worker who was struggling for well being of nomads and de-notified communities became a MLA. Then many old and new friends were connected for political gain. But Shivalal always steered clear from politics. I am fully aware of the sacrifices he has made. Had he become a Professor in a college, he would have led a comfortable, luxurious life. Since his sacrifice for the society was invaluable, after I became a MLA, I strived for Shivalal's appointment on the Regional Committee and with Sharad Pawar's help, he was duly appointed. Later, Shivalal got

fully involved in Educational work. He founded an Educational Institute though he had no political blessings. Today his educational activities have proliferated like a banyan tree. Thousands of orphans, poor, physically and mentally challenged children are learning at his Institutes. Education has been a virtual portal for obtaining good jobs. The lamp of education lit by Shivalal has been generating a glow of happiness in myriad homes. The ground reality as of today is that, workers like Shivalal are carrying out the work with full dedication but their numbers are very few as compared to the increasing number of dishonest and unscrupulous ones. We are born with the innate attitude to combat against the system which does not permit us to be silent against injustice. Shivalal has always been a dedicated, silent worker whose work speaks volumes for him. What else does one need?



Rukmini outside the temple



Ramnath Chavan
Senior Author

On Pune-Nagar Highway, on a secluded open land, veiled by the houses and bungalows, standing alone is 'The Residential School for nomad, de-notified, deaf and mute and orphan boys and girls' - bare walls of eight to ten short rooms surrounded by hardly three to four feet high compound wall, crudely built with stones and bricks, some rooms with iron frames, some with wooden but all without doors, rooms covered with tin sheets of different sizes and of odd shapes as roofs retained in place by putting heavy weights of stones and bricks. However, a big and wide iron gate to welcome, but that too precariously clinging to the compound wall.

I entered through the gate accompanied by the Founder and Director of the Residential School, Shivalal Jadhav and Fulchand Shelke, a social worker. In the central open yard of the school were a few old bed sheets, bed covers, blankets and worn out quilts spread out to air in the sun. Nearby a few scantily clad five to eight year old children played in the sun.

I peeped in one of the rooms. There were around seven to eight children having their lunch. A woman was feeding the deaf and mute children. In the other room was a kitchen with two to three fireplaces in a corner and a few kitchen utensils. The fire places were burning brightly with firewood and coal as food was being cooked. In other room, fifty to sixty children were watching TV. The moment we entered that room, the children turned around and saw us. Like a flock of birds engrossed in picking up grains suddenly take to flight on sensing someone's presence, so also, the children promptly stood up, joined their hands together and said, '*Ek Saath Namaste*'!- 'Salute together!'. Innocent, pale soiled faces with dishevelled hair and outsized clothes, they stood motionless for some time. Shivalal called out the names of those children whose information we were seeking. 'Rinkoo, Appa, Pappya.... come here, please...' he said.

In the meanwhile, from the lot of the bedsheets that were spread out in the sun, a couple of good ones were brought in and were spread out in the opposite room. We sat on the sheets. Rinkoo - a tall and slim twelve year old girl with a wheatish complexion, wearing an old salwar and kurta, entered first, followed by Appa and Pappu. Appa, eleven year old boy dressed in khaki shorts with an untidily tucked oversized shirt. Pappu, an eight year old shy boy dressed in oversized trousers meant for fifteen to sixteen year old, folded at the bottom and an oversized, loose shirt, reaching up to knees. The three of them were orphaned siblings. They entered as they looked suspiciously at us and sat down with their

heads bent low. Rinkoo appeared a bit matured and cheerful. When we inquired about them, she spoke very briefly 'My name is Rukmini. (Rukmini is the name of a very popular Hindu Goddess). But ever since I came here, Baba (that is the way she addressed Shivalal) calls me Rinkoo. I remember my original name but do not remember Appa and Pappya's names. As far my memory goes, everyone has been calling them Appa and Pappya . We are here with Baba for the last six years.'

I asked her about her parents and her home. She said, 'We were staying in Pune, in a slum near the Timber Market. My father used to work as a labourer in one of the shops at the Timber Market. Mother used to be at home. Father worked as a daily wage labourer. He would drink alcohol every evening and used to return home totally drunk. Then he would pick a quarrel with our mother for trivial reasons like, oil, salt, dinner, expenses or anything. The quarrel would end up in vile abusing and severe thrashing. Mother used to lie in a corner, weeping and starving. We also would sleep on empty stomachs.'

She continued, 'Father was earning good money, but half of it was spent on alcohol. Mother had to run the house with the remaining half pay. She somehow managed at times with only *Bhakri* – flatbread and no vegetable or at times, only vegetable and no *Bhakri*. But father used to insist on having some nonvegetarian food with his *Bhakri* and failure to do so, would result in hurling the food laden plate at mother. Her saree would get soiled but she had no other saree to change. We too, hardly had any clothes. A half pant and torn shirt for Appa, a petticoat and a blouse for me. Pappya was naked till he turned two years old. Mother did not have milk to breastfeed him and we could not afford to buy milk. Sometimes Pappya used to become so hungry that he would eat banana skins lying on the road.'

As Rinkoo outpoured their ill-fated childhood, Appa and Papya silently listened.

'One day father came home, as usual totally drunk. Finding no non-vegetarian food for dinner, he began quarrelling with mother. That day, mother too, lost her temper. She said, 'you come home drunk every day, you don't give me money, do you want me to cook my bones for your non-vegetarian cravings?' Father turned more violent as he kicked and punched her. We three were frightened and ran out of house. Father came after us abusing. Mother was alone in the house and on that day, she set herself on fire and died.'

'At that time, I was five years old, Appa was four and Papya was three years old. After mother's death, we used to go with father to the shop, his workplace. He used to work while I would sweep the shop. Appa and Papya would play in front of the shop. During lunch break, father would buy some meagre food like, bread and chickpea fritters, or bread with some potato fritters for all of us. We all used to subsist on that. Sometimes the owner of the shop used to give us rice, bread and vegetables. He would advise father to quit drinking alcohol and to look after us. He would caution him that one day he would die of an overdose of alcohol and we would become orphans. 'Stop drinking and save your children' would be his often repeated advice to our father. But father did not pay heed. As soon as he would be paid in the evening, he would send us home and go for his drinks. While returning home he would bring something for us to eat. We were habituated to junk food, drink water and go to sleep.'

Appa and Papya naively watched their sister as she spoke. 'Then one day, father became ill. In the morning, he could not get up from the bed. He became restless. Then we called our uncle, father's younger brother who was our neighbour. He got my father

admitted in a hospital. Doctor treated him, gave medicine with strict instructions to discontinue drinking alcohol. He cautioned my father that if he continued drinking, he would die. Father did not follow instructions. He ran away from the hospital and drank excessively. The same night, he died in our house.'

'Papya was unaware but Appa and I sat in a corner and wept the whole night. Uncle took us to his house and fed us. He had got married only a month or two before that fatal incident. So, he had no children. He kept us with him for three days, on the fourth day his new wife, my aunt, accused me of the theft of her anklets. She hit me and Appa with chappals and starved us. Uncle came home in the evening and took out her anklets from a box and handed them to her. Then, he thrashed her for accusing me and beating us.'

'Next day, as soon as uncle left the house for work, aunt drove the three of us out of the house. She abused us, said, 'both your parents are dead, now nothing belongs to you... go anywhere, beg and fill your stomachs. Do not come back to my house again.' I held Appa's hand, took Papya in my arms and came on the road. Appa was asking for food and Papya was crying. I went to the nearby colony and begged at few houses. Some women gave us stale food. We sat at the side of the road and ate. At night, we went to the shop where our father used to work and slept outside its entrance.

We started begging at the houses, at the food stalls, at the gates of small and big restaurants. I used to ask for money too. People used to drive us away. We ate whatever we got. We began standing at gate of the temple in our area. Devotees used to distribute 'Prasad', food as God's blessing. We would grab that again and again. Sometimes, we used to go in front of the shop where my father was working and the shop owner used to

invariably feed us. Standing daily in front of the temple early morning to collect 'Prasad' and standing in front of the shop at noon became our routine. Sometimes I would sweep the shop, run errands for the owner. That time Appa and Papyia used to sit at roadside and beg. We were sleeping near the shop. Uncle used to see us but avoid us.'

While narrating her woes, suddenly a very brief flicker of happiness crossed her face and her tone was a bit happy. She said, 'That day was some auspicious day, some festival day. We had sumptuous 'Prasad' at the temple in the morning. Then we went to the shop. Some people were sitting with the owner. He was telling them about us, our misfortune. I do not know what happened, but he took the three of us to his bungalow, gave us a delectable lunch with sweets and asked us to sleep in the outhouse. After a very long time, that day, we had sumptuous, good food and sound sleep inside a house. Oh! We had such a lovely day!'

'Then one day the shop owner called our uncle at his shop and as per shop owners' instructions, uncle brought us here at Mundhwa, at Baba's house and left us under Baba's care. Ever since, our uncle never ever came back.'

'At Baba's house, there were many children like us - both boys and girls. We stayed there, ate and also slept there. We spent two years in Baba's house with the other children. Then, when this school got ready here in Wagholi, Baba brought all of us here, in this Residential School. Now we stay here, eat, drink, play, sleep and also learn.'

Rukmini, Appa and Papyia - three orphan siblings who were surviving by begging or eating 'Prasad' at the temple have now 'blossomed' at Shivalal's Residential School. Rukmini stood first in her fourth standard examination while Appa stood second and

both of them are now studying in the fifth standard. Papya has passed the third standard. They are studying and also cherishing the dream of being educated and prospering in life.

I asked the three siblings, 'Do you miss your parents?' They shook their heads in negation. They looked at Shivalal and replied, 'He is our father and mother. We are going to do whatever he will ask us to do.'

(With thanks from Author's book - Ghanerichi Phule' -
'Oleander Flowers'.)



Reforming juvenile delinquents in benevolent adults.



Ramnath Chavan
Senior Author

There are many social workers who pledge a lifetime of selfless service for the upliftment and progress of the downtrodden. Such dedicated selfless workers, in general, alienate themselves from the spotlights and place greater emphasis on their work, hence people are unfamiliar with them and the work they have been doing. With an intention to familiarise such work and the workers that are far away from the spotlights, or rather to give an impetus and support to such projects, given below are some social service-oriented Institutions:

Institutions for Nomads :

The nomadic communities which are presently classified as 'De-notified' communities were the same communities which were proclaimed as 'criminal by birth' and confined within barbed wired fences under the British Rule. For very many years, these communities were nomadic by nature and stayed away from the established mainstream of the society. Therefore, they had been deprived of social, educational and fiscal progress. With the aim of providing education and thereby making the children of these communities capable of making social and economical progress, Shivalal Jadhav, a social worker from Pune has established '*Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha*' (Educational Institute for Nomad and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes.) Shivalal Jadhav is a Post graduate in Economics as well as Politics and for the last twelve years he has been assiduously endeavouring for the growth and progress of these nomadic and de-notified communities. Armed with the objective of meeting such a young, dedicated social worker and becoming familiar with his work I visited his house at Mundhwa. A spacious residential place at Sarvodaya Colony but not really a 'home' because only a couple of rooms were allocated for the family while the rest was occupied by a Kindergarten, a few classrooms and a tailoring class. I perceived the vast magnitude of his activities and asked Shivalal, who always shunned the spotlight, 'How did you manage everything?' He spontaneously replied, 'Once you dive in the water, you learn to swim!' Well, it is natural to swim with the current but to swim against the current is difficult and calls for a lot of effort. Shivalal has genuinely accepted that, which is clearly evident from the magnitude of his work. Hence, I encouraged him to talk about his work and he began..... :

Constructive Beginning

'While participating for the various agitations and rallies for the nomadic and de-notified communities, I realized that instead of holding meetings, marches and rallies, some constructive work needs to be done and I turned towards Educational work. I began assembling people together in groups and convincing them of the importance of education. These efforts paved the way for the establishment of two *Balwadis* - Kindergartens - and today there are hundreds of children from those *Balwadis* who have passed SSC examination and about eighteen of them have graduated.' I comprehended the modest pride in his tone. He further added, 'Then, I realized that very many children who passed through the *Balwadi* were genuinely interested in further studies but were constrained to accompany the continuous wandering families for livelihood and so, compelled to discontinue studies. Some children continued with their family's occupation while some turned to crime for livelihood. That gave me the idea of establishing Residential Schools - where children could reside and thus induced them with the idea of continuing their education.' He told me about the earlier condition of children in *Balwadi*. 'More than half of the children used to be naked. Some used to be clad in only shorts while some had only a shirt to cover themselves. As their clothes were obtained by way of donation, boys used to be clad in patched pants while the girls in a maxi.' However, of late, the conditions are much better. The Institution is running programmes like two *Balwadis*, a Residential school, employment for the jobless women and also a Vocational Guidance Centre. This centre is recognized by the Government and receives grants from the Social Welfare Department. In this Centre known as the 'Kamala Nehru Shikshan Kendra', tailoring skill is imparted to the women from the nomadic and de-notified communities to enable them to be economically independent and

run their homes. Every year more than twenty women avail of this facility and become self-reliant. Today there are very many women who have become the financial backbone of their respective families. This work of providing training is not easy, but Shivalal is successfully carrying out this difficult task with dogged perseverance. He is of the firm opinion that an all-round growth and progress is not possible without education and his '*Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha*' (Educational Institute for Nomadic and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes) is the outcome of this strong and firm belief. His another aspiration, a 'Residential School', initially got materialized in the form of a rented place at Mahadeonagar, Manjri, twelve kilometers from Pune. Today there are thirty children residing and learning in that school which is recognized by the Government and it also receives grant.

Assistance to all

Shivalal's dream is that the nomads wandering from place to place for livelihood, must settle down at one place, be educated, self-reliant, and live with self-respect and he is toiling hard for days together to achieve the same. He has to face enormous difficulties because as he says, 'To establish a Residential school is comparatively easy but to run it on a day to day basis is difficult. Though the Government provides financial help yet the overheads are too high as compared to their grant. For example, Government issues permission for the Residential School, provides due financial assistance, but as per their rules, the school must own a minimum ten acres of land. At a place like Pune, to have access to ten acres of land is well-nigh difficult and a huge financial worry.' But Shivalal overcame that difficulty, borne that burden and completed that challenge. He said, 'Pune is a place where you get everything. There are people who have established Institutions and there are people who make sure that those Institutions are regularly functioning.' Shivalal needs people of

the latter category, to be the guardians for the nomad children and also to provide financial assistance for their maintenance. He also needs help in the form of other necessities such as educational material like, books, notebooks, stationary and also building material for the schools and other facilities. He needs thousands of helping hands who consider it their social obligation to work for the upliftment of the nomadic and de-notified communities. He says, his work is no more going to be limited to nomads and de-notified communities but he is going to conscientiously work for the underprivileged, orphans, handicapped and the elderly persons of all religions and castes. He is toiling hard to develop cultured, responsible citizens out of those who have been neglected for generations as being criminals as well as the naked children of those who have been stamped as 'criminals by birth' and are ostracised by the society. He knows very well that the only way to attain his goal is through 'Education'. Nothing is possible without Education. Once I asked him, 'Shivalal, why are you doing all this? What for?'

He gently and lovingly caressed the head of a naked child standing next to him and said, 'Do you know the story of the great sage Valmiki? Earlier, he was a robber who later reformed into an illustrious sage and poet and wrote the major epic Ramayana. I too wish to reform these juvenile delinquents into benevolent and caring adults.'

(In gratitude to the column '*Ase Samaj, asha Sanstha*' appearing in Daily newspaper 'Tarun Bharat'.)



An accomplishment of rebirth



Jaybala Pankaj Shah

President, Saurashtra Stahnakwasi
Jain Sangh (Mahila Wibhag)

In the year 1999, suddenly my brain ailment deteriorated as the chances of my survival turned grim. I had to undergo a life-threatening brain surgery and fortunately, I was saved from the jaws of death. In a way, it was a rebirth for me! Thus, my life changed and I began to lead a new life. I had a penchant for social work ever since my childhood. During the days in school and college, I availed of every opportunity to help out the poor and needy students, though I never felt that I was doing something significant. After I recovered from my surgery, I firmly decided that my life would now be dedicated for helping out the needy and to live for the betterment of the lesser privileged. In the

meanwhile, a friend of mine took me to the orphanage/ Residential School in Wagholi. As of today, that was seventeen years ago! My very first visit to this place gave me the impetus for living as I firmly decided to dedicate my life for those children at the school. I began visiting them frequently and I found genuine happiness in meeting the children, talking and playing with them, helping them to solve their difficulties or providing the necessary school material. Just as we do everything for our very own children, I felt like doing the same for these children too. On my return from this orphanage, I would weep as I reminisced the memories of those unfortunate children.



Jayabala Pankaj Shah in conversation with the children of
Residential School

I wished to do a lot for these children, but just one person cannot accomplish everything. So I thought that since I couldn't do much singly, I could garner support. I began taking people from my Jain community with me to the school. I would bring around 10 to 15 persons at a time, as I explained the condition of the children as

well as that of the school and their need for books, food, clothes as I appealed to them for help. Gradually, many people from my Jain community were drawn to this school. Afterwards, they continued helping the Residential School on their own, without my knowledge. They would tell me, 'Jayabala, you are really doing a wonderful job and we are always there to support you' and they sincerely stood by me. Like me, many of them are deeply committed to this school since the past seventeen years. Earlier, they felt a little bit of help would be appropriate, but gradually they realized that true happiness lies in 'giving' and thus, they resolved to make it into a lifetime practice. Students did not have an appropriate place to study. The classrooms were not in sound condition and the walls were so thin that the noise from the adjacent classrooms and from the street outside was a disturbance. Standard facilities need to be provided for the appropriate evolution of the intellect. So, my parents, Prabha and Nemichand, donated money to build good classrooms. When our children reach 8th or 10th standard in school, we provide them with all the necessary facilities like, books, guides, other study material, food and we interact with them to understand their difficulties, if any. I thought, why not extend the same facility to these children? Keeping this in mind, we began providing them with guides, old examination papers as well as solved examination papers. We envisaged the dream of these students becoming self-reliant and turning into successful doctors, engineers etc.

A very special milestone was achieved by these students by scoring an astounding 100 per cent success at the 10th standard examination. They had achieved the same level of success as that of the normal children. Thus, it was not only the stupendous progress of the students of the Residential School but also of the school too. Their examination results gave us the same happiness

as our own children gave us and this achievement was the outcome of a lone, dedicated guardian angel who ceaselessly worked for it, and that is Baba - Shivalal Jadhav. Honestly speaking, I have never ever met a person like him and I see a reflection of Bhagwan Mahavir in Baba. For him, the children from the School are his own children, he tends to them and solves their difficulties. At this age too, he is fully involved in the School and the children. There can be none as selfless as him.

I only introduced a few people from my community and as of now, a considerable amount of persons are supporting this Residential School. When my parents passed away, they left Rupees Eight Lacs for the school. Five classrooms were constructed using that money and it was named as 'Nemiprabha Vidyamandir'. I did what was possible for me to do. I feel very happy when men and women, and also religious heads of our community visit the School. It is said 'Charity begins at home' and rightly so, because my husband, my two sons - Darshak and Alap along with their wives, i.e. my entire family supports me in helping the school and children. The little children in the School are like my own children. Whenever I visit the School, the girls insist on feeding me a morsel with great love. That is the happiest moment of my life! I go ahead and also on my own, take a morsel from each girl's dish. The School is as much as my family as it is Baba's.

I want to do much more for 'my family'. I taught a prayer to the children in which they pray to the Divine to give them a lot more strength. When they recite that prayer, I feel deeply overwhelmed as my eyes fill with tears. I sincerely pray that may the Divine impart a lot more strength than what they are asking for!



A selfless worker



Bharat Jadhav

President, Rashtrawadi Congress,
Sholapur District.

My father *Dalitmira* (Friend of oppressed) Bheemrao Jadhav has dedicated his entire life for the well-being of the nomad community. Since 1940, he set out on the mission of creating awareness amongst the nomadic tribes. He ardently strived for effecting an improvement in their lives and assuring an access to education. So, in the year 1956, he established a Residential School in Sholapur and set up seven Farming Societies in and around Mumbai. He toiled hard for improving the financial conditions of people from Pardhi, Bhat, Kaikadee, Mang and Garudee communities. During the course of this philanthropic work, he found many sincere workers. Dr. Shivalal Jadhav is one such person who worked under his able guidance. When my

father established a farming society in Mundhwa, he entrusted it's responsibility to Rama Shetty, who in turn passed it on to Shivalal Jadhav - a poised and devoted personality.

Shivalal Jadhav too, dedicated his entire life to social work and has carried out a lot of constructive work. When the issue of the Farming Society in Mundhwa arose, Shivalal and his associates, with the support and able guidance of Baba Adhav, put up a strong resistance and made sure that the landowners could retrieve their lands. Owing to the gruelling work of the social workers like my father Bheemrao and Shivalal Jadhav, the nomadic community leads an orderly life. At no point of time did Shivalal ever hanker for any returns from the society, rather, he dedicated his life for the upliftment of the society owing to the compelling innate fervour. The Chief Minister of Maharashtra, Sharad Pawar duly acknowledged his selfless work by appointing Shivalal Jadhav as the member secretary of the Apex Body of all other Regional Secondary Service Selection Boards for the entire Maharashtra State and also as a member of the Regional Secondary Service Selection Board for the Pune Area. Shivalal did not turn to social work because he was unable to do anything else. Being a Post Graduate, he could have easily got an excellent, remunerative job and revel in the comforts of a luxurious life, but his life's goal was predetermined as he followed the path which led to it.

Shivalal has an innate characteristic of helping to solve difficulties of others and extending them a helping hand. He has a propensity to endear himself to others so much so that even, if a person approaches him in a fit of anger, he would return self-composed with a pleasant smile on his face. Elderly persons would confer their blessings on Shivalal before leaving while youngsters would touch his feet in reverence and seek his blessings. This is Shivalal's charisma. Shivalal Jadhav is very aptly carrying out the legacy of my father Bheemrao. Thousands

of students are learning in his Educational Institutes. Wealthy people from the society admire his work and offer him help. Running a Residential school is perceived with an incongruous perspective, but the same vanishes when one visits his Residential School. We fondly address him as 'Dada'. He is still devotedly working for the progress and prosperity of the society. He has participated in many agitations along with Social Workers like, Laxman Mane and Balkrishna Renke. He worked ceaselessly for the betterment of the society. Today he tops the list of the sparsely few people who work tirelessly without expecting any returns. Since he has followed the footsteps of my father, I am following his footsteps. I wish him a happy and prosperous future.



Be a strand in the tapestry of experiences

Christal

I am Christal. I hail from London, U.K. For the past 36 years, I have made India my home and since the past fifteen years I am closely connected to the Institution founded by Shivalal Jadhav, to his family, orphanages, Residential School and to the innumerable innocent children residing and studying at these places. Every child who comes here possesses a different background, but once they become a part of this place, they all become symmetrical as the differences just fall apart. Today, this Institution has blossomed beautifully well and a lot of changes are effected since the past fifteen years. When Mr. Enfield of Family Care Centre- a munificent benefactor assured of generous aid, there were just 100 children in the Institute. Today, that number has swelled to well over 600. At that time the basic facility like washrooms did not exist and hence, no privacy existed. Since Mr. Enfield had an engineering background, he donated a welding machine to the Institute. It was primarily used to install doors for the bathrooms and washrooms.

Ever since I became acquainted with the Institute, I have observed Shivalal Jadhav's complete dedication and commitment towards the Institute. I was a participant in the Students' Exchange Programme under which overseas students used to come to the Institute and teach the students of the Residential School. I was a graduate student and was a part of that programme. We taught English language to the children. We played with them, taught them craft, conducted some projects with them and also joined in their picnics. We did our utmost best to make sure that they did not harbour any inferiority complex issue. We would indulge them and treat them as any normal children. Shivalal Jadhav considers each and every child at the Institute as his very own. Besides, not just Shivalal Jadhav but his entire family is involved in this work.

A virtue of Shivalal Jadhav that I highly appreciate is his unwavering loyalty and devotion for his work. I have never ever seen anyone else with this calibre of honesty and loyalty. The sheer toil and the grind that I observed fifteen years ago have not diminished even a wee bit! This nation needs many more dedicated social workers like him. While tending to the orphans, many a times he neglected his family and at the same time, he never permitted family problems or difficulties to be a hindrance in the path of his work. He is always there to help anyone in need. I truly see Jesus in him! He may be very busy or tired or preoccupied with some worry but, the moment a child from the school goes near him, he puts everything aside and makes it a point to interact with the child by making him smile, talk to him or offer him sweets or biscuits. He has become so very immersed with the children that his entire being always hovers round the residential school and its children!!

In present times, many schools have implemented a system of pinning the identity card on the students' uniform, to enable the

teachers to identify them by their name and address them accordingly but, Shivalal does not need such facility because he knows each and every student by his name. Just as parents do not forget the names of their children, so also, Shivalal does not forget the names of the children under his care! That is the sort of bonding he nurtures with each child of his school and this is possible only when one works with complete dedication and trust. That is why I always appeal to my friends that in case anyone wishes to donate anything like, clothes, food, grains or books - think of Shivalal Jadhav's Institute, because one is always assured that whatever is given will definitely be utilized for these needy children.

For last fifteen years, there is an upward spiral in the progress graph of Shivalal's Institute. Mukul Foundation has provided considerable help to this Institution. Besides the nomad and denotified communities, there are children from all castes and religions at Shivalal's Institute. There are farmers' children too as also the children of the unfortunate, desperate farmers who committed suicide. There are children with very high IQs as well as those with low IQs. There are normal children and special children. There is a Residential school in Pabal meant for the mentally challenged children. My daughter was a student of that school. There is big playground for children and the school nestles amidst beautiful, halcyon nature. One can easily perceive that the atmosphere is very conducive to learning as well as living too. People in general have certain reservations against the mentally challenged children, but for Shivalal all the children are equivalent to 'God's gift'. He firmly believes that every child has a right to learn, to enjoy nature and must be loved in the same manner as parents do and they have an equal right of education too. His schools are not mere schools but they are homes! He assiduously strives to give the best to every child. I am highly impressed by his work.

Going a step ahead, in addition to the Institution for the basic education, Shivalal has also established Professional Centre for the children. I am of the opinion that every educational Institute must also provide Professional Training. At the age of eighteen, when the children leave the Institute, everyone does not get a job or finds a means of livelihood. It is necessary that they should stand on their own feet and for that Professional Centres are helpful and therefore, a necessity. Shivalal aptly recognized this need. In his Professional Centre he provides business training that is ancillary to farming activities such as Goat Breeding, Poultry Farming et cetera. My brothers are closely involved with Shivalal's Professional Centre. They visit the centre quite frequently. I feel fortunate enough to be involved in Shivalal's work else I would have missed an exceptionally wonderful experience. There are very few noble souls like Shivalal. He strives to do what is the best - be it material, or crop or breeding of animals, he emphasizes only on the best !!

Shivalal strives day and night for the children of his Institute. Anyone will definitely be impressed by his work. His motto in life is 'Simple living, High thinking'. I would urge everyone to help Shivalal and his Institute. It is imperative to visit the Institute once and experience the genuine happiness on the faces of more than 600 children and be a strand in the tapestry of their experiences because it is a life-changing experience. If youngsters are looking for a role model, here is the perfect one - Shivalal Jadhav. Shivalal has a goal, a dream as he focusses on attaining it. So far he has trodden the appropriate path towards that goal and will continue to do so. I wish him all the success!



Momentous Pride!

Sangita Shivalal Jadhav

It was year 1973. I was studying in fourth standard. One day Shivalal Jadhav's mother, presently my mother-in-law, visited our house with a proposal of marriage for me with her son. I was much too young to understand what marriage meant, but my father, Pirappa Gaikwad found the idea of a well educated young man as his son-in-law very appealing and he promptly accorded his consent. In a week's time, I was married to Shivalal Jadhav. Since I was pretty young, I continued to live with my parents for a year after marriage. After a year, I came to Mundhwa at Pune. It was not only just me who was absolutely in awe of my husband's education but my relatives and those in our society too shared my feelings. Time and again, my husband expounded the significance of education and inspired me to continue from where I had left off. Subsequently, my name was duly enrolled in a school, but, when I was in the ninth standard, I had to discontinue schooling due to my pregnancy.



Since my mother-in-law worked at a Remand Home, her affinity

to the poor, destitute children was greater. She always cherished a firm belief of doing something much more for their betterment. This belief took a concrete shape in the form of a '*Balwadi*' - a kindergarten in our house itself! My mother-in-law retired during the year 1985 and by that time, my husband had already begun working for the upliftment of the poor, destitute children. He resigned and left his job. So, in the beginning four to five destitute children were picked up and brought home. Our five children along with those orphans were being brought up together in our house. We looked after them and taught them. During the same period, my husband established the '*Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha*' (Educational Institute for Nomad and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes. Many residents from our neighbourhood would consult my husband for their problems and difficulties regarding their farms, land and even family disputes. My husband would help them to the best of his ability. Besides, he was also entrusted with the responsibility of the Society. Very soon we all realized that only helping and teaching children was not enough, the women of the house too needed to be fortified and self-reliant, so, we began to operate a Tailoring Class, that too from our house. The women from our community had practically no work and being jobless, they would resort to either pick pocketing or take up some gruelling work. There were a few educated girls who joined our Tailoring class. Gradually as I began to get involved in all these activities, I developed a penchant for social work and thus, I participated in the work my husband was carrying out.

As time went by, his social work increased. I made it a point not to distract him from his work with our domestic day to day issues. If there was a shortage of food grains in the house, I would temporarily borrow from someone and tide over the situation. Our house had become like a cafeteria with a steady inflow of visitors most of the time! The teapot would be on the stove all the time. Both of us always ensured that every visitor to our home was extended the hospitality of either a beverage or a meal. I follow this tradition even if my husband is not at home. Slowly there was a manifold increase in his activities. Post establishment

of the Institute, a Residential School was established too. The number of students at the *Balwadi* at home increased to 30. We appointed a teacher for these children who also stayed in our house along with our children. Thus, our family had swelled to about 30 to 35 children! All of them grew up together and we never discriminated on any grounds between them and our own children. All these children were poor, destitute orphans and they were also very fond of us and attached to us. We always took utmost care to make sure that none of them felt like an orphan.

I have always supported my husband for everything in life. He has ceaselessly worked and continues to do so through the Educational Institute for Nomad and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes. I am deeply overwhelmed at the work that he has been carrying out. He has constructed everything from ground zero and I am very well aware of the untold struggle that he has gone through which has now paid rich dividends. Looking back, it was a very grim scenario then and now, I really find it difficult to even imagine of how we went through it all. Very often, there was no food in the house with so many mouths to feed, but then as the old adage goes, 'a good doer in life always attracts good souls to support him or her'. So, the kind support and co-operation of many such good souls helped us to attain our goal till this day. Our children were witnesses to our struggle and hard work, consequently, those were life's learning lessons for them as they spontaneously extend a loving and a helping hand to their father.

As I reflect today on what we were and what we have become today, a gentle cascade of tears generates in my eyes. I am barely educated as compared to my highly educated husband, yet, he has always empathised and encouraged me. Going forward, he instilled in me a deep sense of self-confidence and never ever criticized my lack of sound education. Today I possess the invaluable identity of being the life companion of a noble soul-Shivalal Jadhav, who has dedicated his entire life for the upliftment and the betterment of the lives of the nomad and de-notified communities. I bear a momentous pride to be a part of my husband's journey of life.

My Father



Ratnamala Shivalal Jadhav

Teacher of Madhyamik Ashram school,
Wagholi.

The atmosphere in my home is definitely not as normal as compared to other homes. It is very unique and stands out as different, as time and again experienced by me since my childhood days. It was these very motivational beliefs of deep abiding faith and progressive outlook that nurtured and sculpted my attitude and outlook in life. My Grandmother worked as a caretaker at a Remand Home and she had immense compassion for the children at that Remand Home. That was her world. She was particularly compassionate towards a young lad, called Raju. Finally, she adopted him and brought him up as her own child.

Raju too, grew very attached to her and became an inseparable member of our house. He used to be of immense help in every activity of the house. Baba was too busy with his work to pay enough attention to the family or to the domestic matters but Raju used to help us in his absence. I recall an incident : during my mother's last pregnancy (at the time of birth of my youngest brother Milind), one morning her labour pains began. Baba, as usual, was not at home. She, on her own, got admitted at Sasoon Hospital. In her absence, Raju took over the complete charge of the house. Cooking, carrying meals for my mother at the hospital, looking after us, four siblings, everything! Since we were all small children at that time, he did everything to keep us happy, content and ensured that none of us would miss our parents or cry. He fed us our favourite food and pampered us. Thus, we too developed immense love and respect for him. We lovingly address him as '*Rajumama*' - maternal uncle- mother's brother.

We, five siblings were growing up and so was Baba's work which was spreading its tentacles rather rapidly. Hence, Baba was not able to pay attention to his family or to his growing up children as also the house. In short, he could not spare any time for us! He would leave the house at dawn before we could wake up and return home after we went to sleep. At such a tender age, I would often feel a tug at my heartstrings when I would see my friends' fathers accompanying them, taking them out to the park or playing with them. It was more so on my birthdays, when I would eagerly wait for him to return home and wish me. It would be a mammoth effort to keep sleep at bay as I waited for him to arrive, to pamper me and spend a few moments on such an important and joyous occasion. But, in the end, sleep would overtake me and Baba would never meet me! He would come late and I would be fast asleep after moments of anxiety and disappointment. I only had to celebrate my birthdays with my dear Baba in my dreams!

Our parents had cultivated lot of vegetables around our house. Mother used to always explain the values of cultivation with great affection and pride. Amidst dire poverty in the house, my elder brother Ratanlal and I would harvest the vegetables like pumpkins, brinjals, bitter gourds, gherkins, chillies, ivy-gourd etc and go from door to door to sell the same. Mother would utilize that money to run the house and sometimes give us a rupee or two as 'pocket money'! Good clothes were an unaffordable luxury. We would darn old torn clothes and use them for a long time. This condition continued till I joined college. Then our paternal aunt, Saroj, took up the responsibility to provide us with clothes. She worked as a nurse at a Government Hostel at Shiroor. Whenever she would visit our house, she would buy clothes of her choice for us. We would ardently yearn to visit the Clothes Shop with our parents and shop for clothes as per our liking but that remained as a wishful thinking! The question of our 'liking' did not exist because without a murmur we had to wear whatever Aunt would bring and deep within console ourselves that at least, we got some new clothes! Generally our aunt's visits were scheduled twice a year, one at Diwali time—The Festival of Lights, and one to attend the annual pilgrimage during May. So just two new outfits during the year!

My grandfather (Tatya) worked as a peon at Punjab National Bank. Every month on his pay-day we would eagerly await his arrival, because that used to be the only day in a month when he would bring for all of us some sweets according to our liking! Otherwise our parents never ever brought anything for us. Of course there were reasons - our financial condition was not that sound to indulge children and secondly, Baba was very busy throughout the day because the needs of the destitute and orphan children were far greater than ours, hence we did not get our father's company in those days. Mother, without bearing a

grudge, single-handedly managed the house and stood firmly by Baba's side. But we, children spent our childhood yearning for his affection and his homecoming to spend quality time with us and lovingly gather us in his arms. But that childhood with its yearnings and the infantile sorrow is now a distant past. On looking back, the unknown, naïve sacrifices on our part during our childhood laid the foundation of the flourishing Educational Institute.

My Grandmother's job at the Remand Home brought her closer to the world of the poor, destitute orphans. This proximity to them made her very compassionate and considerate towards them which was very evident in her speech. Thus, the seed of upliftment and betterment of such unfortunate children was sown in Baba and that made him restless as he sacrificed the interest in all other aspects of life like politics, agitations etc, so much so that he even gave up a sound, remunerative job with one of the renowned Kirloskar Companies. The upliftment and betterment of these children became the goal of his life. He decided to create a world of affection, hope and progress for these children by basically providing them with education. But at that time, the conditions were not very conducive to translate this concept into something concrete. Besides a cherished, soaring hope there was neither available place nor money but that did not deter Baba. He went ahead and established the *Balwadi* - kindergarten at our house at Mundhwa. In the beginning, there were just four to five children. These destitute children and we, five siblings, were brought up together.

My mother would manage the cooking with the help of vegetables cultivated around our house. She never discriminated between us and these children. Food was never cooked separately for us or for those children. It was just simple, standard fare for all. Gradually the number of children grew and that created space

shortage. The vegetable patches around the house were replaced by small rooms. All the rooms had many doors and windows. The layout of the rooms was such that a big room was constructed at the centre with small rooms constructed all around it, so, anyone exiting from the smaller rooms invariably would reach the central room and for a new comer, it used to be a bit perplexing to easily find the exit to the main door. Our neighbours, in jest, would call our home '*Shaniwarwada*' - a historical labyrinthine fort in Pune with five gates. We got the opportunity to experience the emotional turmoil of these children in the proximity of our house which helped us to cultivate an attitude of consideration towards others. Since I was the eldest amongst my siblings, automatically, I had to assume the responsibility of helping mother in the housework like, cooking, looking after my younger siblings etc. That helped me to foster an attitude of responsibly accomplishing a task. Gradually, the number of children at the *Balwadi* increased and so, a teacher was appointed. He was from a neighbouring town (from Satana in Nasik District) so Baba asked him to stay at our house. An additional resident naturally gave rise to a paucity of place. Baba had anticipated such difficulties, so, on a war footing, efforts were launched to acquire an independent place for the school and the appropriate persons were contacted for the same. He wandered all over throughout the day, mailed hand written letters, promptly met, discussed with many persons and left no stone unturned to obtain a place for the school. Ultimately his efforts bore success and temporary places were obtained at Mahadeonagar, then at Wadebolhai, then at Saisatyam Park and finally it was established at it's own independent place at Wagholi.

The daily workload increased manifold which compelled my mother to wake up at the crack of dawn around four in the morning to complete all the housework and accompany Baba to School. The number of children in the school increased and so did

the teachers. Baba was always equally compassionate about the teachers as well as about the children. A teacher from a distant town joined the school. He was very sincere and as he got accustomed to the children, he diligently worked. He established good contacts with many prospective donors and thus, donations increased. His involvement in all the school activities increased but owing to some personal and domestic reasons, he became addicted to alcohol. The grip of addiction strengthened to such an extent that he stopped attending school, his family fabric was sundered and at times, he would be found in an inebriated condition on the streets. Baba found it difficult to withstand the appalling deterioration of such a rational person to addiction. He did not terminate his services but initiated a systematic treatment for de-addiction. When it did not work out, he admitted him to a 'De-addiction Centre', monitored his recovery till he was totally free of addiction and then, reinstated him at school. Today this teacher is totally de-addicted and re-united in peace and happiness with his family. Baba considers each and every person in the school like his family member and personally tends to any of their difficulty or calamity with aplomb. During problematic times, the Principal and the staff tend to get worried or anxious. At such times, Baba's assuring words instils confidence to face the situation. Many poor, needy and destitute widows work at the school kitchen. Baba extends due compassion to them and helps them as much as possible and at times, supports their families with food, shelter and clothing. He also helps them to become self-reliant. Baba's helping hand is always extended to every needy person. He makes sure that no one returns empty handed.

A female cook lost her husband. Her in-laws usurped the money that was left for her and the children. By depriving her of the legal right, the aggrieved woman was besides herself with worry at the prospect of running the house, raising her children, their

education etc. Baba stood by her and diligently rendered all the possible legal aid and finally assured that her rights were duly reinstated. During this entire harrowing and time consuming process, frequently visiting the pleaders, it was heartening for me to see the boundless satisfaction on his face.

Day by day school keeps expanding with the number of students as well as the staff too. Myriad people and myriad mindsets gave rise to a kaleidoscope of opinions, views resulting in disagreements and hence, more problems. But Baba had his finger on everybody's pulse! He precisely knows how to judiciously utilize each person's skill either for the school's benefit, for its future or in the interest of the students. While allocating work or supervising any work, Baba never uses harsh or abusive language. He patiently lends his ear to everyone. Today, even though in his seventies, his day begins at five in the morning. He is diabetic but his zest for life will put youngsters to shame. During the entire day he is busy with the school administration, providing guidance, meeting people, garnering donations for the school from philanthropic persons. He also makes it a point to spend quality time with the children to understand them, to sort out their fears and difficulties and accordingly gives instructions to others. All these activities keep him busy almost till midnight! He never goes to sleep till he reads that day's newspaper and yet, never complains that he does not find time to read! Many a times I ponder from where Baba derives this energy from? My query gets answered as I look at the smile, happiness and contentment on the faces of school children, teachers and staff members.

Mine is a love marriage. I was very apprehensive about informing Baba about our intentions of getting married but when I did, he was the first one to approve and support me. At that time I came across such a considerate and loving father who predominantly

accorded a priority to his daughter's sentiments, her happiness and her marital life rather than his prestige in the society. Now, my husband and I have been entrusted with the responsibility of one of the schools of Baba's Institute. In case of any difficulty, be it regarding the school or students, we seek his advice. He always has a panacea for every problem! As we run a school, we realize the amount of efforts and hardships he must have faced while erecting this edifice. As of today, he does not wish to spend time for his own well-being. If he feels any uneasiness or pain, he does not visit the Doctor, but asks mother to fetch medicine for him.

I have minutely watched the growth of the tiny sapling of his Institute grow into a mighty, thriving banyan tree with its adventitious prop roots - School for deaf and mute, Primary School, Secondary School, School for mentally challenged (at Wadegavan, Pabal) and now Goat rearing, Poultry Farming, Animal Husbandry and Farming using modern techniques. Baba has deftly balanced all these varied activities in his able hands. Today my mother and we - siblings and our families - unstintingly participate in all these activities and support Baba. My husband, Jitendra and my sister-in-law too, are actively involved. On 20th December 2015, our family faced bereavement. My younger brother Motilal alias Pintoo, his wife and their two children met with a fatal car accident. It shattered all of us but it dealt a traumatic blow for my parents who were devastated. While they took it in their stride as destiny and feebly managed to regain their composure yet, this unfortunate fact lies buried in their minds as they march ahead for the cause of the injustice towards the unfortunate children. The school which was started in 1985, in our small house with four-five children, has now grown with an amazing strength of 650 children. There are many schools, innumerable activities, various projects, camps, trips, excursions, vocational training etc. as Baba is constantly working to bring

smile and a glow on the faces of children from the nomadic and de-notified communities, to provide them with strength to grow and be self-sufficient. Now many of his students have grown, become strong and are now supporting other needy children. Baba's legacy is being carried forward.

My siblings and I were fortunate enough to witness the growth of the sapling into a mighty, thriving tree. All this was possible due to the unstinting efforts by my parents and the due inspiration from my grandmother. I feel content and successful in my life. I am extremely proud of my father's achievements too. About Baba's life I would say :

While embracing the sky

Plant the feet on terra firma

While bestowing the heart

Plant a smile on the lips

Challenge the disaster

with grit and elan

Look straight into life's eye and retort

Accomplishments be such that

when you depart from this earth,

copious tears be shed by many, and,

even the harsh tone of the time will soften

and time will stop short.

so, look straight into life's eye, and retort.



I am fortunate!

Milind Jadhav

As I grew up and grasped the reality around me, I would wonder why there were so many children in our house? Yes, our house used to be full of children. I would ask my parents, 'Who are these children? Why do they stay with us?' They would reply, 'They are your brothers and sisters.' That answer was deeply imprinted upon my naive mind and I began to feel pompous at the thought of having so many brothers and sisters! Gradually as I grew more matured, I began to understand my father's work better and got the right answers to all my niggling questions.



Right since my childhood my parents never discriminated between us, siblings and those children. The treatment or favours were never any different. Thus, my childhood was spent amidst a large family! After I passed the tenth standard, I opted for a Diploma course in Computer Engineering. I followed it up by B.E.in Information Technology and in 2011, I enrolled for

M.B.A. At that time the situation was changed. My father had established an Educational Institute and there were many schools, also a Residential School. I thought of doing something for the school children. Incidentally, at the same time, I was assigned a project on the subject of 'e-learning' from a company. While carrying out the project I thought that these children ought to get access to this latest form of education and they must be conversant with the computer. Accordingly, I approached the teachers at our Residential school and discussed about this project. I got due guidance from my father too. There were no computers in the school at that time, so, Baba arranged for a few through some donations. We set up a Computer Laboratory in the school. These children had never seen a computer before and they were fascinated by the idea of working on them. I would teach them the use of computers on my weekly days off from work. I was deeply impressed by the determination and the happiness and the response of these children and I continued teaching them with great pleasure. I taught them the basics of the computer. During that process I realized the importance of my parents' upbringing with great love and devotion and the values they were inculcating in them. I feel deeply overwhelmed and am extremely proud of my parents. One needs to be fortunate enough to have such parents and siblings and well, I am that fortunate!



A sapling transformed into a Banyan Tree

Ratanlal Shivalal Jadhav

I work as a Secretary of the '*Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha*' (Educational Institute for the Nomadic and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes). The Institute that was established by my father out of nothing has grown into a huge thriving Banyan Tree. Words fail me to aptly describe the process of its foundation, the inspiration behind it and the gruelling hard work put in by my dear parents to set it up. The struggle to survive seen and the affection and compassion developed for the destitute children in my grandmother's mind while working in Remand Home, and her repeatedly expressing her passion to my father, inspired him to work with a steadfast determination for the upliftment of these children is just astounding! The initial concept of tending to just a few needy children was the virtual seed that germinated into a sprawling Banyan tree. In the beginning, about four to five orphan children aimlessly wandering at Vashi Railway Station in Mumbai were brought home. They became a part of our family - a large family! There is a very huge difference between that day and



today. These children formed a part of our childhood. Ever since then, my father wholly devoted his entire life towards social work. In our childhood, he was never available to us - no sitting together, no chatting, no pampering. I as well as my brothers and sisters used to feel a pang of melancholy as we watched other parents who pampered or indulged their children now and then. But then we realized that my father does not think only of his family's well-being and happiness, but that of the entire society and hence, he could not spare much time for us. That thought that the time he is spending is towards a noble cause makes us feel very proud. We learnt the meaning of life from our grandmother, our mother and our father, from their thoughts, their work, their teachings. As of today, everybody earns money and leads a good life. But to lead a meaningful life is something that we experienced since childhood. Though my father was unable to spare time for us yet, he did not neglect us. There was no deficiency in our upbringing. While we did not suffer yet, we experienced and witnessed the suffering around us. We saw the children who did not have parents, who were abandoned by their parents, who witnessed their parents being slayed in front of them ... such grief is just unfathomable! We too, experienced profound sorrow on the untimely demise of my brother and his entire family in an unfortunate car accident. So we could understand the pangs of severe grief of these children around us. That was the turning point of our outlook as we set to work and assiduously put in efforts to improve the future of these children. Around 99 % of the children in our Institute have such a traumatic background.

The untold suffering of these children gives an impetus to my father to work harder for their betterment. The vim and vitality that he works with is enough to put us youngsters to shame. He is in his seventies now, yet his day starts at the crack of dawn and continues well into the night. He ardently wishes to eradicate the suffering from the society and put a smile on the faces of these destitute and orphan children. My humble prayer to the Divine that may he be blessed with enough strength to fulfil his dream!!

*The mindset of
orphans about **baba...***

Photographs of various occasions

















Baba gave me identity

Nikhil Bhausaheb Barve

Nikhil Barve – as of today, this name got an individuality only due to Shivalal Jadhav, whom I call Baba and Sangita Shivilal Jdhav, his wife, whom I call Kaku. They are more like my parents. My mother passed away when I was very young and I was bereft of maternal warmth and affection but my Kaku replenished that need while Baba showered paternal affection. Today with Baba and Kaku's love and blessings I subsist in the society with self-respect. The towering, multi storied buildings, which once upon a time, appeared as too distant and unreal for me, are now a part of my workplace. I work at a five star hotel. The food which I never had access to, is now what I consume regularly. How did this become possible? Only because of Baba and Kaku.



I came to Baba's school when I was in eighth standard. Since then Baba and Kaku have been my parents. Baba not only took care of me but guided and encouraged me tackle life and live it

meaningfully. Owing to their values and teaching I could get a job at Mahindra International. While I was at school, I recall, Baba would invite many accomplished personalities in school. Such people who had triumphed over the odds and achieved success. We got to learn a lot from them and drew inspiration from them. The children in school were very apprehensive of learning English language, so, Baba invited many engineers and high ranking officers to teach us English and instil confidence in us. On the strength of that confidence, I can speak fluent English today. Once, Baba Adhav visited our school and he depicted the true illustration of the society. Baba inspired in me the tenacity to overcome the odds in life.

Baba had firmly resolved that the children will not be deprived of any facilities because they are orphans as he continues to work for their welfare. When I was totally unaware about computers, Baba arranged for computer classes. Today this knowledge assists me in creating reports at work.

When I enrolled for the Hotel Management interview, majority of the incumbents were from families who were already in similar business. Being the odd man out, I had serious doubts about getting a job in that field. But the discipline imbibed during school days gave me success. My knowledge of English was good. But I had other problems. My intelligence quotient was not up to the mark and so was my thought processes. I approached Baba and discussed at length with him. He assured me, encouraged me but did not permit me to accept failure. Today where I stand in life, is only due to Baba and whatever I may achieve in the days to come, the entire credit would inevitably lead to Baba, the source of my inspiration and my role model. His motto has always been that 'never to retract because one has to be aware, in the first place, of why one opted for that particular path'. His often repeated mantra is, 'in case of any obstacle, approach me!'

Since Baba was there...

Sheetal and Geetanjali Parshunath Thakare

(Taluka Vaijapur, District - Aurangabad)

My mother passed away when I was very young and we were neglected by our father. Then my maternal aunt took over and for a while looked after us like her very own children but, she was not financially very sound and had four children of her own. So she took us to the Residential School and put us under the care of Baba and Kaku. Baba would collect funds, clothes and other necessary things from wealthy businessmen or philanthropic people for the school children. After tenth standard, I wished to study further and had no place to stay, so Baba, Kaku and the school staff helped me a lot. He personally helped me to obtain college admission and gave accommodation at the school hostel. They were always very helpful so much so that I had no cause to complain! Even as of today they are doing everything possible for the betterment of the school. He and the staff are available to sort out any difficulty at any time of the day. We never felt the absence of our parents and were never in want of anything where

education was concerned. We could complete our education. Baba used to bring the orphans to the school, adopt them and give them an identity. Today, many students of our school are well placed in life and holding significant positions. Baba and Kaku had Shivaji Maharaj, Shahu Maharaj, Mahatma Phule, Babasaheb Ambedkar and Savitribai as their role models and thus, never discriminated on grounds of religions, castes and communities including the nomads and the de-notified. All students had equal access to education. We sincerely wish that Baba's work continues and may he get sufficient help and support and may we be able to contribute to this noble cause.



Protector of the orphans

Gokul Pandurang Shirore

In the epic of Mahabharat, there is a story of Guru Dronacharya and Arjun. Guru Dronacharya was responsible for teaching the art of warfare to the Kauravas and the Pandavas. Once, Dronacharya decided to assess all his students. He hung a wooden bird to a branch of the tree. He then, assembled all the students and one by one asked to aim at the bird's eye with a bow and arrow but before they could shoot the arrow, he asked each one of them a question. 'What do you see there?' Everyone replied that they could see a bird, a tree, a branch etc. Some even mentioned that they could hit him. Last, it was Arjun's turn, he too was asked the same question. He said, 'I can see only the eye of the bird and nothing else.' Dronacharya was pleased with his answer and only Arjun passed the test.



The moral behind the above story is that to achieve a goal in life one has to wholly focus only on the goal. Once this single point

focus is achieved then, one can even develop a thriving garden in a desert, in brief, turn the impossible into possible. With similar dedication and devotion a very unique goal has been achieved by our guardian angel, the respected Dr. Shivalal Jadhav, our Baba.

Baba is passionate about his goal of providing education to all nomads, orphans, under-privileged, backward children and youngsters to improve their standard of lives. He has taken upon himself to be a guardian angel to these children, as he gently appeals to their emotional quotient to bestow a new lease of life.

To him, they are like the tender blossoms in the garden of equality and he assures that adequate amount of values are instilled in them for the evolution of emotional, physical and intellectual quotient which will enable them to achieve knowledge to enrich their lives. Children are provided with theoretical, practical and experimental education in all the fields. Baba and his wife, Sangita, known to all as Kaku, together feed knowledge and strengthen the wings of the beautiful butterflies in their garden of equality so that they can soar high.

The core values of life that were inculcated in Baba during his formative years by his mother, is the grand legacy he has inherited in life.

His mother worked at a Remand Home, hence she had an affinity towards the poor, destitute orphans and their problems. Being brought up in a Jain family since her childhood, she was highly influenced by the teachings of Bhagwan Mahavir, the noble saint of Jain religion, his principles of truth, non-violence and kindness. Hence, compassion towards the poor, disabled, destitute and orphans was an integral part of her.

Any normal youth, harbours a dream of owning a big sprawling house, a car and a large estate but, Baba cherished a very different dream. With grit and determination, impossible turned possible

and a very living example of the same is my school and it's founder – our Baba.

In our country during the pre-independence days, discrimination on the basis of race, caste, community was rampant. Besides, since the men and women from nomads, de-notified communities and other backward classes were kept away from education, progress and evolution of these individuals was impossible. So with the aim of providing them with the required education, Baba gave up his remunerative government job, and in the year 1985, brought a few orphans, poor, deaf and mute children together, gave them shelter and established a school, right in his own small house. Gradually, the number of children continued increasing.

A philanthropist from Wagholi, named Dhole Patil saw Baba's enthusiasm and tenacity and donated half an acre of land in Wagholi, a village on Pune-Nagar Road, close to Pune. Later, Baba put in herculean efforts, toiled day and night to amass donations to construct a school building on that land. Major contribution came from people of the Jain community. School got established but the financial condition remained stressful. At times, Kaku had to pawn her jewellery to feed the school children. But the school was their family and that was their world, so, they kept it going. Their own children were motivated and they too got involved in the school activities. Thus, in Wagheshwari, not only a school was established but a 'Samskar Kendra' - where children were not only academically educated but also family values, culture and ethics too, were imparted.

Today, all the poor students who have come from the nooks and corners of Maharashtra enjoy sound facilities like spacious building, a huge playground, learning material, uniform and a bed. Meals arrangements are personally supervised and healthy, wholesome food is served. Teachers are well qualified, very hardworking and dedicated. They are always inclined to improve

the overall educational quotient of the students through varied projects and activities.

Students like the school very much and are attached to it. During the long school holidays like Diwali, many students stay back at the school, those who do go home, go reluctantly. That is the degree of bonding between the teachers, staff and students.

Thus, a small sapling has grown into a huge, thriving tree which is reaching out to the sky. I am pretty confident that our school will attain the altitude of Ravindranath Tagore's Shantiniketan. In this honourable work, people like me have been fortunate enough to get an opportunity to offer our humble contribution and thus, our lives have turned meaningful.

Baba is now a celebrity, but he judiciously stayed away from politics. His feet are planted firmly on the *terra firma*. In reality, had he entered politics, he would have become a veteran politician or had he turn to writing, he would have become a remarkable author or had he chosen a field of art, he would have become a well-known artist. It is said that even if a diamond is cast in the muck, it will continue to glitter. It's lustre does not depend on borrowed glory. A lotus too blooms in the quagmire. Once, veteran author Ramnath Chavan visited our school. In his speech, he endorsed his achievement in literature to Baba. He told us that Baba took him to the settlements and colonies of the nomad and de-notified communities to showcase the stark reality which he translated in writing without mincing any words. That put him on the pinnacle of success which later led to the publication of many volumes of his writing.

On a departing note, I wish to mention that may Baba's work continue to spiral upwards even in his advancing age, may he be blessed with sound health and long life and may our school achieve a name in the list of honours in the entire country.

Magnanimous father

Jayraj Rajput

Year 1970. Movements for the rights, for the well-being of and against injustice on nomads, de-notified people and women were at their peaks. Meetings, agitations, marches, demonstrations, efforts for increasing public awareness were in full swing. Leaders like Baba Adhav, Anil Awachat, Shivalal Jadhav, Laxman Mane were the idols of the movement. I was studying in college that time and had strong liking for social work. I used to write in media about the issues and problems faced by my Kanjarbhat community and thus unknowingly got connected to the movement. I started attending weekly meeting regularly at Baba Adhav's residence every Monday.



Many years later, on 24th October 1986, our colony was attacked by a group of workers of Dnyan Prabodhini. They did not want our community to stay in that area. The attack was like a robbery. They damaged our houses, beat us up and made us homeless. I ran

to Baba Adhav's residence and told him about the robbery. Shivalal Jadhav accompanied me back to our damaged colony. He was very sad but also was very angry. He helped us, guided us. We demonstrated under leadership of Baba Adhav. Baba also wrote articles in many newspapers. The issue was in the public eye for quite some time. Our opponents criticized our actions but ultimately, at least to certain extent, we got justice. We were resettled.

During that time, I had an opportunity to observe exceptional capabilities and leadership qualities in Shivalal Jadhav. I found in him a dedicated, wholehearted social worker. He was running a small Residential School and a School for Deaf and Mute in Wagholi.

Eight days back I received a phone call from Shivalal Jadhav. He informed me that he was in need of some help from me and was coming to Khed Shivapur to meet and discuss. I was very glad. First thing, he remembered me even after a gap of thirty four years, secondly, he was offering me an opportunity of helping him in his work. So, my senior friend (he is seventeen years older than me!) came on a Sunday and we met at my Hotel.

He was looking for a land of about one acre in my area for a cowshed to rear Geer cows. I was surprised, I asked, 'Why are you rearing cows?' He explained me. About 700 children - orphans, blind, disabled - were staying and learning in his various Institutes and schools. There is no support from the Government for the orphan students after they cross the age of 18. Hence, later these children without any support tend to go astray and resort to theft, pick pocket, begging and thus, become criminals. In order to make such children self-reliant and capable of running some small business, he had set up a Training and Vocational Guidance Centre. The aim was to train those children and also farmers and

make them self-sufficient by providing education and training for managing the businesses. They had chosen businesses which would complement the farming. Cattle rearing was one of those businesses and he had brought Geer cows to rear. He was having one plant and was looking for a plot for the second plant. I promised him to look for a suitable plot.

We exchanged many old memories. He showed me a recently published book which was his autobiography and also had articles written by many dignitaries, his co-workers, his relatives and his students expressing their love, respect for Shivala Jadhav. He informed me that the book was being translated in English and asked me for an article. So here it is - a small effort from my side.

My best wishes for the English edition.

After he left, I was thinking about him and his great social work. What a tremendous struggle! Long days of hardships and misery! I remembered his mother who singlehandedly brought up her children, provided them education and showed them the right way of life. For that she also fought with many odds, went against society norms and taught her children to surmount difficulties and stick to ideals and own paths. I respect and bow to that lady from a nomad, criminal community who inspired her son, Shivalal Jadhav to undertake such valuable task of educating nomads, orphans, deaf and mute, physically and mentally challenged children and shape their lives. Shivalal Jadhav founded and established many schools and Institutes for that purpose and he is still working day and night for the welfare of those children. He has become 'Father of orphans' - I would say, 'A magnanimous father'.

I remembered an incident. Shivalal Jadhav had submitted an application to the authorities for the Government Recognition of

his school. It was rejected by the Education Commissioner on the grounds that Shivalal Jadhav's name appeared in the space for 'Father's name' in case of 23 children. In reality, those children were from the poor Kolhati community. The women from this community earn money by entertaining people by singing and dancing at public and private shows. Thus, some of them become victim of the lascivious gaze of the village head or some wealthy persons. The outcome of such libidinous, carnal relationships results in the birth of unwanted children. The biological fathers ensure total anonymity. Hence, for such children only a mother existed but no father! Hence, my senior friend resorted to providing his name as the 'father' of all such orphans!

My eyes welled up!

Salute to my senior friend, his unparallel work! My best wishes!!

Jayraj Sampat Rajput

Khed Shivapur, Taluka - Haveli, District - Pune.



Remarks...

Satyamev Jayate!..... Truth alone triumphs !!

Baba Aadhav,
9th August 2014.

Unless the cerebral infirmity of the society is done away with, the propriety of celebrating the 'Disability Day' cannot be achieved. The work carried out by this Institution is noble, philanthropic and totally selfless. The school is a reflection of the society and it must be acknowledged by all.

Hearty congratulations to Shivalal Jadhav – Baba, his family and all the teachers of the school.

Rahul Solapurkar,
3rd December, 2013.

Today I was extremely happy to visit the *Samskar* School founded by our dear friend since the last 54 years. Dear Shivalal *alias* Raja *alias* Baba, hearty congratulations....
Lots and lots of good wishes.....
and books too..... !

Vikram Gokhale
15th October, 2016



Dr. Shivalal Jadhav

Introduction

Birth date : 2nd November 1947

Education : M.A. in Economics and Politics, Pune University

Doctorate : ETO University, Chennai (2017)

Educational and Social responsibilities :

A) Chairman, '*Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha*' (Educational Institute for Nomad and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes) in Mundhwa

1. Primary Residential School, Wagholi, Pune.
2. Shree School for Deaf and Mute, Wagholi, Pune.
3. Madhyamik Ashram School, Bakori Road, Wagholi, Pune.
4. Residential School for Mentally Challenged Children, Pabal, Shiroom, Taluka, Pune District
5. *Balgruh* – Children's Centre, Wagholi, Pune.
6. Training Centre for Self Employment, Pabal, Shiroom Taluka, Pune District.
7. Centre for counselling and managing physically challenged children, Pabal, Shiroom Taluka, Pune District.

8. Centre for counselling and managing physically challenged children, Wagholi, Pune.
9. Kamdhenu Gosanwardhan (Cow rearing) - Training Centre, Mundhwa.

B) Chairman, Pintoodada (Motilal) Shivilal Jadhav Charitable Trust (2016), Mundhwa, Pune 36.

C) Ex-Member

- 1) *Pradeshik Duiyam Sewa Niwad Mandal Samiti (1993)*-The Maharashtra Regional Secondary Service Selection Board [Apex Board] (1993)
- 2) District Vigilance Committee (1994)
- 3) *Vishesh Karyakari Dandadhikaree* (1990) - Special Executive Magistrate (1990)
- 4) Chief Promoter - *Pratibha Mahila Audyogik Society*,-(Pratibha Women Industrial Society) Kharadi, Pune

D) Founder Member - *Bharatiya Bhatke Wimukt Sanshodhan Sanstha*, Satara. (Indian Nomad and De-notified Communities Research Institute, Satara.)

E) Ex-Chairman

- 1) Sarvoday Collective Farming Society, Mundhwa, Pune (225 Acres)
- 2) *Laxmi Yantramag Society*, Kharadi, Pune
- 3) *Pratibha Mahila Kagad Udyog Sahakari Society*, Mundhwa (Pratibha Women Paper Industrial Co-operative Society)

Social Work :

- 1) Continuous efforts for providing facilities of Education, Health, Self-employment, Special Training and rehabilitation, by conducting rallies and arranging various types of projects, for homeless boys and girls aimlessly wandering in the streets and are prone towards criminal activities. This work is going on for last 35 years by Shivalal Jadhav, a noble minded social worker. He gave up a lucrative job as a Professor and for last 35 years he is toiling day and night for the development of the underprivileged.
- 2) Working with many Organisations such as CYDA, SAATHI, DISHA - dedicated to providing Education and rehabilitation of the children of women from the Devdasi and Kolhati communities and prostitutes.
- 3) On realizing that only providing Education is not enough, sought co-operation from companies like Kirloskar, Cummins, Johnson and Johnson for the employment of the underprivileged students. Arranging Vocational Training and Guidance for the students in the Research and Training Institutions run by Mukul Foundation in areas such as Cow rearing, Goat rearing, Poultry Farming et cetera.
- 4) Professional rehabilitation of young boys and girls, assuming the role of a patriarch for assisting them in selecting the appropriate life partner, arranging their marriages either at the Institute or at their hometowns.
- 5) Though the opportunity of stepping into politics was available when he was appointed on *Pradeshik Duiyam Sewa Niwad Mandal Samiti*-The Maharashtra Regional Secondary Service Selection Board [Apex Board], and with many of his colleagues obtaining lofty positions in political

field, Shivalal Jadhav never got attracted towards politics or acquiring social importance. He preferred to allocate top priority to the development and rehabilitation of nomads, neglected, underprivileged, scheduled caste girls and boys and founded an Educational Institute on an isolated land and it proved to be like the river Ganges for nurturing the needy children.

- 6) In 2000, Japan Embassy took notice of the best accommodation given to the students by '*Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha*' (Educational Institute for Nomad and '*Wimukt*' (De-notified) tribes) and awarded the Institute with special financial aid.

Awards :

- 1) Asia Pacific International Award
(Bangkok, Thailand, 2017)
- 2) Vijayratna Gold Award
(Integration Council of India, New Delhi, 2016)
- 3) Jewel of India Award
(International I.E.M., New Delhi, 2016)
- 4) Samajik Samarasta Manch Puraskar (1988)
- 5) Samajik Kritadnyata Puraskar
(Social Gratitude Award) (1987)
- 6) Dr. Abdul Kalam Life Time Award - Chennai (2017)
- 7) 'Samajratna' Puraskar,
Vikramshila Hindi Vidyapeeth, Bihar (2017)



Appendix

Communities declared as 'Criminal' :

British Government, under a legislation, declared certain communities as 'criminal'. Kaikadi, Bhamta (Takari), Bester, Pamlor, Kanjarbhat, Rajput Bhamta, Chhaparband, Fasepardhi, Mang-garudee are some of them. Each community has its own dialect. People from these communities can only converse in their mother tongues but they cannot write.

Kaikadi Community :

People of this community mostly hail from Tamilnadu but their Tamil dialect is not the original but somewhat distorted. Before the year 1900, people from this community were mostly thieves. The leader of this gang of robbers used to be called as '*Pulekallu*'. *Pulekallu* was revered as the patriarch and he would authoritatively distribute the spoils from the robberies to the members of his gang. There are two clans in this community - *Satpad* and *Kavad*. There can be marital relation between these two clans.

Bestar Community :

This community used to be populated in the area around the border between Tamilnadu and Andhra Pradesh. Hence, their mother tongue is Telegu. In both the states, people from this community were pickpockets and they were known as '*katralelloo*'. There are two clans - one is Sannabiam Punchkolu and Kopwar and other is Gunje Bannolu and Doknolu. Marriages take place between these two clans. Lately this community works as construction workers.

Pamlor Community :

This is a sub caste of Kaikadi community. Their mother tongue is the distorted version of Telegu. The ancestors of this community were snake-charmers. They would intentionally leave a snake in the houses of moneylenders, then enter the house with the intention of capturing the snake and closely observe the layout of the house and later at night raid that house.

Mang-garudee Community :

The dialect of this community is a distorted version of Marathi. The women of this community would visit shops, distract the shopkeeper's attention and steal. Another ruse was, while making payment after purchases, they would give a note of low denomination and create a ruckus of having given a note of a higher denomination and get more money in return. Shop owners in a bid to safeguard their reputation would quietly pay.

Fasepardhi Community :

This community probably hails from Gujrat as it's dialect is a distorted version of Gujarati. Khudaria-Kale, Chouwadia-Chavan, Ikotia-Pawar are the clans of this community. People of this community used to hunt in the jungle by ensnaring deer, pigeons and chittar.

Rajput Bhamta :

This community probably hails from Rajasthan as it's mother tongue is Hindi. Salunkhe, Chavan, Pardeshi and few more are clans of this community. Marriages take place between these clans. The method of looting used by this community is to work as a domestic help for some wealthy person, win his trust and then one day break the safe and rob all the money.

Kanjarbhat Community :

This community also probably hails from Rajasthan and its dialect is a distorted version of Rajasthani. These people would move about in pairs to rob others. One of them would distract the victim by talking while the other would steal and abscond. In a later period, most of them turned to illicit brewing of alcohol.

Chhapparband Community :

This is basically a Muslim community, migrated from Rajasthan to Karnataka. The dialect is a distorted version of Hindi. Gare, Mal, Mithare, Rawat are the clans. This community was working in the Mint of Adilshah, the King of Vijapur and was minting his currency - 'Dinar'. During the battles, they would build tents close to the battlefields for the high ranking warriors. The tent provides shelter, a roof and roof is called 'Chhappar' in Hindi and Marathi, thus the name Chhapparband.' As per the available information, while serving Adilshah this community got converted to Muslim religion.



There are innumerable sugar mills in Maharashtra as also Educational Institutes too. Hence, there are many well known Sugar barons as also great Educationists, but how many of them have come forward to espouse the cause of these poor orphans or nomads? It needs to happen but it does not! So, people like Shivalal have to depend on the Government Grants or on the charity of the philanthropic members of the society. Shivalal does that and makes sure that he does not get embroiled in the politics which is an inevitable part of all such philanthropy. Really, his work is akin to the conquest of Mount Everest!

- Baba Adhav, Senior Social Worker.

Though the Criminals Tribes Central Act was abolished and some facilities were provided for the development and progress of those tribes, yet there was not much change in the mindset of the community. They continued carrying out the same old activity of brewing illicit liquor. In and around Mundhwa alone there were around 200 illicit breweries. Widespread violence, quarrels, thefts, abusive behaviour continued as the order of the day. Against such a backdrop of quagmire, in that swamp Shivalal bloomed like a lotus!

- Balkrishna Renke,

*Ex-Chairperson of National Commission for De-notified,
Nomadic and Semi-nomadic Tribes (NCDNSNT)*

Today there are very many women who have become the financial backbone of their respective families. This work of providing training is not easy, but Shivalal is successfully carrying out this difficult task with dogged perseverance. He is of the firm opinion that an all-round growth and progress is not possible without education and his 'Bhatkya Wimukt Jati Shikshan Sanstha' (Educational Institute for Nomadic and 'Wimukt' (De-notified) tribes) is the outcome of this strong and firm belief.

- Ramnath Chavan, Senior Author

It is amply evident that the battle waged by Dr. Shivalal is a common fate of all those born in similar nomadic tribes, especially in 'so called' independent India. Many families and classes of that category of society still wander and their number keeps on growing for want of appropriate social awakening. In this autobiography, along with the details of the writer's own work and experiences, there is lot of information which bears a historical value about the people, their living habits, professions, culture and religious beliefs and worship. That history of such persons or their communities is as ragged as they are. Such fragmented pieces when sewn together form a quilt. Dr. Shivalal Jadhav's autobiography is akin to this quilt.

**- Dr. Narayan Bhosle, Department of History,
Mumbai University, Mumbai**



मैत्री पब्लिकेशन

ISBN 9-78-81-93-81028-6



9 788193 810286

₹ 250